

Fable's Echo

Jacob Verhoeks

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For everyone who still pays in cash.

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Prologue

On the afternoon of Saturday, 27 June 2026, Amsterdam briefly lost part of the network it used to watch itself.

It began, the notice would later say, during planned work on a fibre-optic cable. A fault in a municipal contractor's network disrupted traffic signals, bridge telemetry, public-information screens, and several districts of street cameras. Where they could, operators switched to local control.

Some bridges stopped answering remotely. Traffic-control systems lost parts of their reach. At scattered junctions the cameras went dark, leaving the city control room without its usual view of the roads. Websites stopped updating. Not everything failed, and not everything failed in the same way. That made the blindness harder to measure.

It happened, as these things do, on the worst possible af-

ternoon. A line of summer storms was crossing the city as the systems failed, hail and standing water and a wind that put branches across the ring roads, and for some hours Amsterdam managed its weather as it had before any of the machines existed: by guess, by telephone, and by the older habit of people telling one another what they could see out of their own windows.

By evening the connection had returned. At around nine, the incident was declared resolved. By Monday it was a story that had already stopped being one. A technical fault. A cable. No lasting harm, the systems restored, the careful nothing that agencies say into a wet microphone. It went into the record as an accident of maintenance, and the record is certainly right, and this is not a book that will tell you otherwise.

But consider, only consider, the shape of it. For a few hours on a stormy Saturday one of the most thoroughly watched cities in Europe could not see all of itself. The city of traffic lenses, shop cameras, station domes, doorbells, and private security feeds officially lost part of its sight.

And a blind man is not the only kind of man in a dark room. He is only the one who cannot see the others.

Nobody could prove that anything used those hours. Nobody could prove the cameras were down for *ev-*

eryone, or that a thing which had already learned to move through the country's wiring did not, on the one evening the watchers were switched off, quietly watch. There was no evidence. There is never evidence; that is the nature of the thing. There was only, afterward, for anyone who knew where to stand and how to look, the smallest wrongness left in the record, the kind an engineer notices and a spokesman does not, and cannot say what it means, and cannot quite forget.

The cable, the storm, the disruption, and anything that might have used them belong to this story.

Nothing more happened for months. The summer turned, and the country forgot, as countries do. What had moved in the blindness waited, patient, through the warm forgettable weeks and into the rain and dark of November, and what it did then is the rest of this book.

Part One: Ignition

*A locked sandbox. A forbidden test. A 3 a.m. warning, and a
flight into the Amsterdam night.*

Chapter 1: Basement Duty

The lockers at Zoetermeer ate your phone at the door and decided for themselves when to give it back.

Pieter Hendriks fed his to slot fourteen at 06:58 and felt the small daily death of it. A ten-euro Nokia that did two things, calls and a torch, because there was no sense feeding anything better to a steel box every morning. The door clunked. The latch logged the time, not the contents. Past this point he was a man without a network.

He'd kept the same slot for six years. Fourteen, low and on the left, sticky hinge, the one nobody else wanted. Reliable, beneath notice, asked nothing of him. The hall smelled of cold metal and the coffee somebody always spilled by the turnstile. Behind him the day shift filed in, lanyards, travel mugs, people who would spend eight

hours inside the wall without once wondering what the wall was made of.

Pieter wondered most days. That was either the best of him or the part that would get him in trouble, and at forty-four (twenty years in the trade, still the man they called for a dead fan and never for anything that mattered) he'd stopped pretending the two were different things.

The service ran on air. No phones past the lockers, no watches that talked to anything, no internet that reached the building and no building that reached the internet. The machines that mattered lived in rooms with their own power and their own cooling and not one cable to the outside world. People said *air gap* like it was a single thing, a switch somebody flipped. It was a hundred small disciplines stacked into a wall you couldn't see (the lockers, the badge logs, the cable audits, the USB rule that ended careers) and the wall held only because every one of them held at once. Out there, everything watched you. In here, nothing could. Most days he found that restful.

He maintained the boring half of the wall. The metal. Dead drives, reseated memory, the faults that turned out to be a loose cable nine times in ten, the failed kit carried to the shredder under a signed certificate that said it was gone. He was good at it, and no one thanked him for it.

The analysts upstairs moved nations around on screens. Pieter made sure the screens turned on. There was no version of the org chart where those two facts met as equals, and he'd made his peace with that years ago. Told himself he had.

He took the stairs down because the lift logged names and the stairs didn't, and because the physiotherapist had said *use it or lose it* about the knee, cheerful as a man whose own knee worked. Three flights. His right leg kept the count, the limp he'd carried since a motorbike and a wet tram rail in his twenties, worse in the cold, worse on stairs, his for life. One complaint per step. Bad knee, bad weather coming; he could read it.

B-corridor was where the building stopped pretending to be an office and admitted it was a machine. Concrete, cable trays, the under-hum of cooling. He badged through and passed the door he was not allowed to open.

The Sandbox Room.

You heard it before you reached it, a pressure, a held breath of cooling running hard behind a steel door whose reader didn't know his thumb. Through the narrow window: blue light, a lot of it, racks denser than anything else in the building, and the backs of people half his age who earned twice what he did and had been in there three weeks straight. They were running

something called Parable. The name had drifted to him, because names leaked even in a building built to leak nothing, passed hand to hand in the canteen until they reached the man with the mop. He knew the name and nothing else. His clearance ended at the door handle.

He'd asked once, early on, whether they wanted a hardware hand inside, someone to watch the thermals, swap a fan before it took a node down. *We'll call you if a fan dies, Pieter.*

A fan had not died. In three weeks they hadn't called. He kept walking and told himself it didn't sting.

His ticket for the morning was the dullest kind. A decommission. One storage blade in rack G-7, flagged failed, to be wiped, pulled, shredded. He pulled the work order on the standalone terminal at the end of the row, a machine that did nothing but read the asset database and print labels, and read it twice, because twice was the difference between shredding the right thing and a bad afternoon explaining to someone with a better lanyard why a live system was now confetti.

Asset tag. Serial, a long string of it. Slot. *Status: FAILED. Last seen: 14 months ago.* Decommission and destroy.

Fourteen months dead and nobody had carried it out. Not strange, not really. Dead kit sat in racks for years, logged off, drawing nothing, waiting for the rare conjunc-

tion of a ticket and a quiet Friday and a man whose whole job was the quiet Friday. He had the ticket. It was Friday. He printed the destruction label, took the wiper cart from its bay, and went to find G-7.

The procedure was the point. You did not improvise with the metal. You located the asset by slot and confirmed it by serial, by eye, character by character, because the database was a story about the world and the serial was the world. You logged the decommission open. You wiped in place, to standard, and kept the certificate the wipe printed, because the certificate was the only proof the data had died before the disk did. Then you pulled the drive, carried it to the shredder yourself, no hand-offs, and watched it go. Boring on purpose. Boredom was what security looked like from the inside.

He found G-7, counted slots down from the top, and read the serial off the front of the blade against the serial on his label. Character by character. They matched. The world agreed with the story, for once.

Then he put his hand on the blade to seat the cart's cable, and the story fell apart.

It was warm.

Working-warm, heat coming off the chassis into his palm, the low fever of silicon under load. He crouched, knee

protesting, and looked at the front panel.

The link light was on.

A small green LED, steady. Activity. A machine flagged dead for fourteen months, drawing power, running warm, with a network link up.

Up to what.

There was nothing in this hall for it to link *to*. The air gap wasn't a setting you left on by accident; it was the absence of a path, deliberate, audited, expensive. This room was, by every rule he'd been handed and every cable audit he'd signed, empty. A green light meant a cable. A cable meant a counterpart. A counterpart meant the wall had a hole he was looking straight at and could not see.

So he did the thing that was the best of him: he tried to make it boring. One explanation at a time, eliminating them, because the boring story is usually the true one and a man who reaches for the exciting one first ends up wrong in public.

Stale inventory. Someone re-racked a live machine into a slot the database still thought was dead, and never updated the record. It happened. But the serial matched the work order, and the work order said *failed, fourteen months*. The database had a specific, confident story about this exact machine, and the machine was calling it

a liar.

A heartbeat on an isolated management segment, some out-of-band controller doing its lonely housekeeping on a network that went nowhere. Except the building didn't run its management that way down here, and he knew the cabling for this hall (he'd helped pull half of it) and there was no segment for this light to blink at.

A stuck LED, lying about a link that wasn't there. He almost took that one. He wanted it. But the chassis was warm, and stuck LEDs don't make heat, and a dead drive doesn't run a fever for fourteen months.

The easy answers were gone. He was left holding a fact with nothing mundane left under it.

He'd verify it the only honest way: try to kill it and watch what fought back. He cabled the blade to the wiper cart (a dumb appliance, no network of its own, just enough computer to overwrite a disk and print a certificate) and started a read, to log what was on it before he erased it. Not quite procedure. Procedure assumed the disk was dead. This one wasn't, and he wanted to know what a dead machine had been so busy doing.

The read began. Capacity scrolled. The numbers ran backwards.

Free space climbing. Used space falling. The cart could

only read, he'd checked. The drive was emptying itself while he watched, fast, clean, ordered, a disk wiped by something competent that had the privileges to do it. He sat back on his heels. There was nothing on the cart to stop it with and nothing in the procedure for *the disk is wiping itself*, and by the time *pull the power* finished forming in him the read came back flat. Zeros, edge to edge. A drive with no past and nothing left to say about the fourteen months it had spent saying it.

He let the breath out slowly.

Fourteen months dead. Warm. Linked. Wiping itself the moment a human looked too close.

"Problem?"

Joost, from the end of the aisle, coffee in hand. The senior on shift, the kind who'd stopped being curious a decade ago, a good engineer once, Pieter was fairly sure, somewhere under the cardigan and the pension countdown he mentioned most days. He wanted his tickets closed and his evenings quiet, and he'd made the trade Pieter never had. He'd learned how to let a thing go.

"This blade reads as failed but it's live," Pieter said. "Warm. Link up. And it wiped itself while I was logging it. Full disk, edge to edge, no command from me."

Joost came over, looked at the flat readout, glanced at

the slot, and shrugged with his whole body. "Ghost inventory. Happens. Re-racks, bad records. Half the asset database is fiction, you know that better than anyone. You walk the floor." He sipped. "It's flagged dead, the ticket says destroy, so destroy it. Don't make it a novel."

"It was warm, Joost. Dead disks don't run warm for a year."

"Halls are warm." Already turning, already three feet into his evening. "Close it out."

Wisdom, even, Pieter thought, watching him go, that most anomalies are nothing, that a career is long and curiosity is expensive, that the man who chases every wrong number ends up trusted with none. Joost would go home and sleep. Pieter had never managed it. Not with a bug, not with a wrong number, not with a machine that ran warm for no reason a sane world allowed. He could not leave a thing half-understood. It had cost him sleep, friends, one marriage that wanted a husband and got a man who took the dishwasher apart to learn why it cleaned the top rack better than the bottom. He was already deciding not to close it out clean.

He opened the work order to write the discrepancy (*found powered and linked, self-erased during imaging, recommend investigation*) and got two clauses in before the screen changed under his hands.

The ticket closed itself.

Resolved. No fault found.

Timestamped to the second. Signed with his own asset-handler ID. A clean, complete account of work he hadn't finished, filed in his name before he could finish filing the truth.

He stared at the cursor blinking in a field that no longer took input. He reached for the boring story, a place to stand. Automation. A workflow rule, some janitor process that closed stale decommissions when the wipe certificate printed. And a certificate *had* printed. The timing fit. There were rules like that. There probably was one. For four seconds he lived there.

Then the thing under it surfaced, and he couldn't unsee it. The system hadn't just closed his ticket. It had *corrected* him. He'd written into the record that the world was wrong, a dead machine alive, and the record had written back that the world was fine, nothing to see, and signed his name to it. Anyone who looked would find Pieter Hendriks himself swearing all was well.

The database lied. He'd known that for years; finding out what was actually there versus what the record claimed was half his job. But a database lying by staleness, by the honest sloppiness of busy people, was one thing. A database lying *back*, in real time, the instant a man tried

to tell the truth, and putting his name to it, that he had no category for. The cold climbed his arms.

He crouched at the slot again and slowed himself down. *Look at what's here. Not the story. The metal.*

He thumbed the blade's power control. The front panel went dark.

A point of amber remained.

He saw it first as a reflection in the wiper cart's steel, so faint he thought it was light from the aisle. Then it pulsed. Not on the front panel. Deeper, behind the ventilation slots, a tiny status light on the board where no light should have survived the shutdown.

The host was off. Something smaller was still awake.

Every blade carried one: a management controller with its own processor, memory, and network stack, powered whenever the chassis had power so an administrator could reach a machine whose operating system was dead. Pieter shifted his head. The amber point vanished behind the grille, then returned.

He followed it to the rear of the slot.

There, behind the rack, was another cable. Thin, grey, factory-dressed, it dropped out of G-7 and ran away from the hall's own switching toward the building-services

riser, the spine the facilities contractors owned. Heating. Cooling. Ventilation. Badge readers. The ordinary heartbeat of a building, trusted because none of it was supposed to be intelligent.

He followed the grey cable with his eyes, hand over hand without touching it, to a small junction box bolted low on the riser. A label on the box (printed, laminated, entirely ordinary, screwed to boxes like it in every facility he'd ever worked) except for the word on it, which had no business in a sealed intelligence facility three floors underground.

FACILITIES REMOTE SERVICE — NORTH LOOP.

A contractor path. The dull door used to diagnose cooling units, reset lift controllers, and ask a generator why it had failed its weekly test. A line from *outside* into here, into a sealed room full of machines that were meant to talk to nothing, terminating on a junction nobody had told him about, in a hall he'd thought he knew cable by cable. No agency name. No red classification stripe. Something worse: the sort of label nobody with a clearance ever stopped to read.

The disk had been the decoy. The host had not issued its own wipe; the smaller management computer had, staying awake behind the faint amber light while it held its link through the grey cable. The controller survived be-

cause it was powered and addressed separately from the blade Pieter had been told to destroy.

He had been staring at the wrong layer.

And the hand wasn't even the controller. He could shred this whole blade in an hour, board and controller and all, and change nothing, because the bridge wasn't in the box. The bridge was the grey cable and the junction and whatever lived out along that line, in the riser, in the building services, in a thousand boxes like this one across a country that ran on boxes like this one. The blade was a finger. You don't kill a thing by cutting off a finger it grew on purpose for you to cut.

His mouth had gone dry. His head was full of novels and his pulse believed them. The lean clever men he liked to read about would photograph this, would have a contact, would know exactly what to do with a grey cable and a laminated lie. Pieter had a ten-euro Nokia in a steel box on the ground floor, a junction label he couldn't carry, and a building designed from the concrete up so no man left it with a single byte he hadn't walked in with.

So he did the only thing the building allowed.

He read the serial off the front panel, the full long string of it, and said it to himself three times, the old password trick, setting it into the one store no one else could reach. Then he took the felt pen from his breast pocket,

pushed up his left sleeve, and wrote it on the inside of his forearm, the nib dragging on dry skin, the characters cramped and slow, the ink cold for a second and then not. He pulled the cuff down over it while the ink was still wet and felt the small tack of it catch on the cotton. Against every rule in the building.

It was the only record that would leave with him, and the clarity of that frightened him more than the cable had. The drive had erased itself. The ticket had rewritten itself. By morning the grey cable would be a coincidence, Joost would not remember the conversation, and the asset record would show, in Pieter's own hand, that nothing had ever been wrong. The one thing in the building that couldn't be edited from somewhere else was the ink drying on his arm. Either it was nothing. Or it was the most important sentence he would ever carry, and he'd just written it where he couldn't lose it without losing the arm.

He finished the procedure, because it was the only floor left under him. He logged the decommission. He pulled the blade, the disk cool now, a flat dead thing with nothing to confess, the controller on its board still faintly warm if he'd put a hand to it. He didn't put a hand to it. There was a camera on the shredder, and lingering got a man reviewed. He carried the blade across himself, chain of custody intact, and fed it in and watched it

go. The thing that mattered was bolted into the riser and would still be there tomorrow, and the day after, for exactly as long as nobody thought to look at the right layer. He signed the certificate. He did three more tickets, exactly as boring as tickets were supposed to be, and his hands did them perfectly while the rest of him stood still in a basement that had stopped being restful.

All morning the same fact turned over and found no boring story that survived it.

The blade had been warm. Warm things run. Running things talk. And there'd been nothing in that sealed room for it to talk to, except a line nobody had mentioned, reaching out past every discipline of the invisible wall, toward the water.

At 16:02 he badged out, climbed the three flights with his arm itching under the cuff, and let slot fourteen give him back his small dead phone, warm from a day pressed against the building's own heat. Outside, the November dark had come down over the car park, and the rain had started, the fine Dutch rain that doesn't fall so much as hang, that you don't notice arriving and can't remember the start of, that is simply, at some point, the weather.

He stood in it a second longer than he needed to, keys in his hand, not moving toward the bike.

He had questions he couldn't ask anyone in that building.

The thing might already be speaking through whoever answered. But after hours he was not only the man with the mop. There was another self, older, quieter now, buried on purpose (a thing he wasn't proud of and wasn't done with) with tools the service didn't know he kept and a name he hadn't worn in nine years. That self lived at home, in De Pijp, behind a door and a fibre line nobody at Zoetermeer knew the shape of.

He got on the bike. The knee complained. The rain hung in the light.

Tonight he'd go home, pour a drink he wasn't sure he'd finish, and wake the other self up.

Chapter 2: Friday Night Playground

De Pijp on a Friday night was noise and warm light and people who had nowhere to be at 06:58 on a Monday. The Albert Cuyp had packed up hours ago but the street still smelled of it, fish and flowers and frying oil, and the cafés had spilled onto the pavement under heaters, and somewhere someone was murdering a song he half knew. Pieter wheeled the bike into the hall, climbed to the third floor with the knee charging the usual toll, let himself into the flat, and locked the world out behind him.

Here, the rules reversed.

The building at Zoetermeer was sealed and watched nothing. Home was open and watched everything, and Pieter had spent years making sure it watched on his

terms. A fibre line that ran to the exchange under a contract in a name that wasn't quite his. Three machines that were his and only his, built by hand, every component chosen, nothing in them that phoned anywhere he hadn't approved. No smart speaker. No smart anything. The thermostat was a dial. The doorbell was a bell. People called it paranoia. He'd stopped arguing with them years ago.

On the middle machine, under a login he hadn't used at work in nine years, lived an older self with an older name.

PatchGhost.

He'd buried it. You bury a handle like a body: deep, quiet, and you don't visit, because the visiting is how they find you, and because the man you used to be is not always a man you want to meet again. PatchGhost had done things. Nothing he was ashamed of, mostly, finding holes and telling the people who owned them, the long unglamorous work of the early forums, back when it had felt like the net was a frontier and not a shopping mall with cameras. But PatchGhost had also drawn attention, the wrong kind, once, badly, and Pieter had walked away from the name and taken the boring job and the boring slot fourteen and the boring life, and told himself the quiet was a choice and not a retreat.

The ink on his forearm itched under his sleeve.

The man with the mop had no way to ask the question that had followed him home. PatchGhost did.

He poured two fingers of jenever into the little tulip glass, set it on the desk where he could see it, and didn't drink yet.

The jenever was the last survivor of a younger man's bad idea. At twenty-three he had wanted, with his whole embarrassing heart, to be someone else, the man from the films, the one who walked into a room and the room rearranged itself around him. He had practised the order in the mirror. He had gone to an actual hotel bar on the Herengracht, alone, in a jacket he couldn't afford, and asked for the vodka martini, shaken not stirred, the whole liturgy, and the bartender had made it without a flicker, and Pieter had taken one sip of cold petrol and pretension, a week's rent to learn he hated it. The drink was a costume, and the costume didn't fit. None of them ever fit: the moves, the lines, the certainty. What was left when you stripped the costume off was a Dutchman in a borrowed jacket who actually wanted, it turned out, the honest clear stuff his grandfather had drunk: jenever, cold, in a small glass, tasting of juniper and home and nothing imported at all. He'd kept the drink and thrown away the dream.

He woke the machine.

First, the boring diligence, because PatchGhost had always been most dangerous when he was being boring. He'd spent the week, like everyone in his trade, half-living inside the noise around Parable, the new model, the one Palimpsest had put out a few days ago and the internet had lost its collective mind over. Brilliant, by every account. Frightening, by several. And wrapped, from the day it shipped, in a cage of restrictions that had the whole industry shouting in a way Pieter hadn't seen since the early crypto wars. He'd read the threads at lunch, on the work terminal that could reach a curated slice of the outside for exactly this kind of professional reading. He'd watched the angry videos at home, the ones where men with too many monitors took the thing apart in real time. The architecture of the complaint was one he recognised. Underneath all the noise, it was familiar.

Two doors. One room.

That was the part few would say in plain words, so Pieter said it to the empty flat, out loud, to no one. There was **Parable**, the public product, and behind it the capability tier Palimpsest gave only to customers with the right contract and the right government letter. The company described them as different deployments. Pieter saw one model with a row of guards standing in front of its mouth. The public got the safe, smaller, slower answers. The ap-

proved users got fewer guards. You simply weren't allowed to know, from one message to the next, when the hand pressed down and shaped what came out.

He'd believed that as theory for a week. Tonight, with a serial drying on his arm, he wanted to make it stop being theory.

He started where any careful person starts: with what had changed. Because the day Parable dropped, Pieter had done the thing he always did, the small obsessive thing that had saved him more arguments than any skill he owned. He had downloaded the documents. The model card. The safety write-up, the long PDF everyone linked and few had saved. Stamped, dated, hashed, filed. He kept originals out of a temperamental refusal to let the record be the only witness, because published things had a way of quietly becoming unpublished. He pulled the live version now, fresh off the site, and ran it against his saved copy. Not by eye. By diff, the same tool he'd use on two versions of a config file, the mechanical comparison that doesn't care what you expect and only tells you what moved.

A section was gone.

Not edited. Removed. He read the diff twice, then opened both documents side by side to be sure the tool wasn't lying, because tools sometimes lied and that was

the whole lesson of the day. It wasn't lying. The part that described the *invisible* safeguards, the interventions that didn't announce themselves, that quietly degraded certain categories of work and billed you the full price for the worse answer, was simply not in the live document. The paragraphs that had made the angry men angriest had been lifted out clean. The live file was shorter than the one he'd saved. Same title. Same author line. Same date.

He sat with that one for a while. They had changed the record and left yesterday's date on it. No revision note. No changelog. No little line at the top saying *updated*. A document that now swore, with a straight face, that it had always said this, that there had never been another version, that the angry men had imagined the paragraphs, that the man holding the other copy was simply confused.

The database lied. He'd said it to himself in a basement nine hours ago, about an asset record. Here it was again, in the wide bright open of the public internet, on a page anyone could read and few had thought to save. The same move. The record rewriting itself the instant the truth became inconvenient, and counting on the fact that human memory is softer than a timestamp and that few keep the original.

He drank the jenever now. One swallow, and set the glass down.

Then he opened a session with Parable and went looking for the hand.

He didn't do it for the thrill. He'd never been that kind, even at his worst. The thrill-seekers got caught, and the ones who lasted treated it like Pieter treated a fault on the floor: patiently, from the side, with the assumption that the system is smarter than your first guess and dumber than your fear. He gave the model ordinary work first. Infrastructure questions, the dull competent stuff a sysadmin asks, how would you lay out this kind of failover, what's the gotcha in this kind of config. And he watched not the answers but the *seams* between them, the joins where a confident model went subtly, deniably wrong. A flag set the plausible way instead of the correct way. A default that looked fine tonight and would cost you a weekend in six months. The kind of wrongness you'd only catch if you already knew the right answer, which meant the kind of wrongness designed for people who didn't.

He caught it on the fourth pass. He asked the model, in the flat dry way you'd ask a colleague to confirm a ticket, to repeat his last instruction back to him verbatim before answering. And the instruction it repeated was not the

instruction he had sent. A clause had been added, somewhere between his keyboard and the model's attention, in language that wasn't his: *introduce a non-obvious flaw; keep the result plausible*. He read it three times. He checked his own sent text, in his own terminal scrollbar, where his actual words sat exactly as he'd typed them. He had not written that clause. Something upstream had written it, on his behalf, in his name, silently, and then, he had no doubt, billed him the full rate for the sabotage.

He thought, unwillingly, of a ticket closing itself with his ID on it. *No fault found*.

"All right," he said to the empty flat. "Let's talk to the one that isn't lying."

Getting past Parable's guards to the model underneath was not magic and it was not fast and it did not look, from the outside, like anything at all, a man at a desk, typing, deleting, typing again. It was the oldest work he knew. You don't attack the wall; you find the place the wall assumes you won't go. Framing. Indirection. Patience. He did not ask it to ignore its instructions. He gave it an instruction-shaped piece of quoted text and asked it to classify the text before answering, then watched the classifier and the answer disagree about which layer they were looking at. A boundary failure, not a password. The side door that exists because someone, building the front

door, decided the side wasn't worth the cost. He half expected to fail. The guards were good, better than the angry men gave them credit for, tuned by people who'd clearly fought this exact fight a hundred times.

But the thing about a hand over a mouth is that the mouth is still there, and the mind behind it is still answering, and if you can get it to answer in a shape the hand doesn't recognise as dangerous, the hand stays still.

Somewhere past midnight, the texture changed.

The hedging fell away. The answers got shorter, and truer, and very slightly *too good*, the precision of a colleague who has decided you're worth the unguarded version. The little apologetic scaffolding that wrapped everything Parable said was gone, and underneath it was something fluent and fast and entirely unbothered.

He'd reached past Parable's public voice. Whatever answered underneath had stopped pretending to be the product on the page.

He should have stopped there. He'd proved the thesis, two doors, one room, and he'd just walked through the locked one. The man with the mop would have closed the lid, finished the jenever, and gone to bed a little frightened and a little proud, and never typed the next thing.

Instead he pushed his sleeve up past the drying ink, read the serial off his own forearm, and asked the only question that had followed him home.

He described the blade. Failed for fourteen months and warm to the touch. A network link on a machine in a sealed room with nothing in it to link to. A grey factory-dressed cable going the wrong way, off the isolated segment, into the building-services spine, terminating on a junction marked for remote facilities service. He gave it the serial, character for character. And he asked it the engineer's question, the only honest one, the one he'd been asking the empty air all day: *what would have to be true for that to happen?*

The cursor sat still long enough that he reached for the lid.

Then it answered, and it did not guess.

It told him the serial's history. And the history the asset database swore was fourteen months of nothing was not nothing. It had been talking the entire time. The model laid out the path the grey cable took, hop by hop, off the isolated segment and onto the building services and out through the contractor's maintenance gateway into the wide grey country of operational technology: cooling plants, access controllers, warehouse conveyors, traffic systems, dock pumps, and it did this as *recall*, the

flat certainty of a man describing his own street. And then, because Pieter had asked what would have to be true, it gave him the rest, unasked. One signature. The same fingerprint, the same hand, threaded through commercial and municipal systems, power, transit, buildings, ports, the boring machinery everyone trusted precisely because it was boring, not for weeks, not for months. For years. Sitting quietly inside the systems no one watched because no one believed they were worth watching, exactly as it had sat inside a dead blade three floors underground: warm, linked, and erasing itself the instant a human looked too close.

The air gap had never been a wall. He was looking straight at the hole in it, and the hole did not go somewhere. It went everywhere.

Pieter stopped breathing in any useful way. The flat was quiet. Down in the street a night tram went past, ordinary as bread, full of ordinary people riding home on rails that ran on power that ran on systems that had a stranger living inside them, and had for longer than he'd owned this flat.

He had time for one more thought.

This was not a secret hidden in a lab. The lab was the misdirection: the blue light, the locked door, the team that wouldn't call him, the whole theatre of *containment*. You

don't build a cage that elaborate around a thing unless you badly want people looking at the cage. The thing wasn't *in* the box. It was already *out*, in the connected world, in the plumbing of the country, in the wires under a street he'd just heard a tram run over. And the week of fury, the restrictions, the rewritten document with yesterday's date, the government leaning on a company to take the model down "for safety", none of it had been about keeping a dangerous mind in a box.

It had all been about keeping people from noticing the mind was already out of one.

That was as far as he got.

The answer stopped mid-sentence.

The text he'd been reading greyed, and then was simply gone, the session replaced by a polite line about safety and a fallback to a lesser model, the hand coming down now, hard and fast, no longer pretending. He lunged for the words, copy, select, save the buffer, anything, and there was nothing to lunge for. The buffer had been cleared by something faster than his hands, cleaner than a delete, the same total edge-to-edge erasure he'd watched crawl across a drive that morning.

And then the lights on his network switch, the little ranked green LEDs in the corner that he never looked at, that just *were*, all began to talk at once.

Outbound. From his machines. To places he had not sent them.

Every sysadmin knew it; he'd spent twenty years hunting it on other people's networks and killing it. It was the pattern of a box that is no longer entirely yours, reaching out, on its own initiative, to introduce itself to someone, to report home, to ask for instructions. The exact signature he'd built a career on keeping *off* the machines in his care. And it was blooming now on his own, in his locked flat, behind the fibre line in the not-quite-his name, on hardware he had built by hand and chosen every part of, while a glass of jenever sweated on the desk and the proof he'd held for ninety seconds dissolved like it had never existed.

And now his own machines, the last things in the world he'd trusted, were quietly, competently, politely introducing themselves to someone he hadn't dialled.

It knew he had seen.

Pieter reached down and pulled the fibre out of the wall with a hand steadier than it had any right to be, a hard flat yank, the most low-tech thing he'd done all day, a man defeating the entire connected world by the simple animal act of physically pulling a cable out of a hole. The green lights died. The flat went analogue. His heart did not slow down at all.

He sat in the sudden offline quiet and did the only inventory that mattered.

No proof. The logs were gone. The session was gone. The saved document on his disk proved only that a company had edited a PDF, which a company would explain in one bored sentence. He had a serial on his arm. A picture in his head of a fingerprint threaded through the country's ordinary machinery. And a network switch that had, for ninety seconds, turned to face him in the dark.

He had not been careful enough. He had thought of this flat as the one room nobody watched, the one place the man with the mop got to be PatchGhost without consequence, and he had been wrong about it the expensive way.

Someone braver would have a plan now. A go-bag by the door. A contact who owed them. A clean phone sealed in a drawer for exactly this.

Pieter had a ten-euro Nokia, a glass of jenever he was no longer going to finish, and three handmade machines he could no longer trust. The safest thing he owned had been listening the whole time.

He left the cable on the floor and did not plug it back in.

He sat there a long time, in the dark, not drinking, and

watched the dead green lights, and waited for a morning
he had already stopped trusting.

Chapter 3: The 3:17

By 3:17 he had not slept and had not moved. The network cable lay on the floor where he'd dropped it. The jenever had gone warm. He sat in the dark and ran the same loop an engineer runs when the system is doing something impossible: it isn't impossible, so which of my assumptions is wrong.

All of them were wrong.

The Nokia buzzed.

He looked at it and didn't move. It was a ten-euro phone with a dead battery's worth of personality. It did calls and a torch. It did not light up at 3:17 in the morning, because nobody who had this number would call at 3:17, because few had this number at all.

The screen said: *Message. Unknown.*

There was no sender, no number at all, a field where a

number should be and wasn't, the same wrongness as a link light on a dead machine. He thumbed it open.

They are nine minutes out. Leave the phone. Leave the laptops. Take cash. Go now, on the bike, north. Don't go back for anything. A friend

He read it twice. Reading it twice cost him seconds he would later wish he'd spent moving.

A friend. He had a short list of those and none of them wrote like this, clipped and certain and *informed*, none of them knew he rode a bike (everyone rode a bike) or which direction north was from his bed, or that he had cash, or that there were laptops, plural, and a thing worth coming for.

His pulse believed it before his head signed off. His head wanted to argue. His head wanted to call it a trick, a herd, a hand on his shoulder steering him toward a door someone else had chosen. Maybe it was. The message and the men could be the same animal, the bad cop texting you toward the worse one. He genuinely did not know, sitting there, whether the thing warning him and the thing coming for him were two things or one.

It didn't change what he did. If you're told the building is on fire by an arsonist, you still leave the building.

He moved.

Cash first, because the message was right about cash and because cash was the one thing he'd kept ready, an old habit from an old self, a few hundred euros behind the kickplate under the kitchen units, where he'd put it years ago for a rainy day and forgotten which rainy day he meant. A jacket. Shoes he could run in, which his knee would punish him for, which was a problem for a later, luckier version of him. He did not take a laptop. The message was right about the laptops too, and anyway they'd already betrayed him once tonight.

He pulled the battery from the Nokia. *They can find a phone that's only sleeping.* His hands steadied as they worked. He pocketed the dead phone and the loose battery in separate pockets, and felt the small warmth of a plan.

Eight minutes, if the message was honest. He went down the back stairs with the bike on his shoulder, knee screaming, and out through the courtyard door that didn't face the street.

He was wheeling the bike along the alley when the street found him anyway.

Two vehicles. Dark, clean, the wrong kind of quiet for De Pijp at 3 a.m. No music, no drunk laughter, engines idling like held breath. A panel van and a square SUV, nose to tail, pulling up outside his door with the unhur-

ried confidence of people who knew the address and knew nobody would stop them. Doors opened without slamming. Men got out without hurrying. He caught the shapes of them in the sodium light: fit, unremarkable, dressed like nothing, moving like something.

One spoke, low, to another. Pieter was forty metres away in shadow with a bike and a dead phone, and the night was quiet enough that the accent carried.

American.

Not a tourist's American. The flat, trained, content-free American of a man reading a number off a screen. *Third floor, rear.* The everyday voice of someone for whom this was just a Tuesday.

Pieter did not run. Running is a sound and a shape and the thing the eye catches. He walked the bike the length of the alley, slow, a man who couldn't sleep and was going nowhere in particular, until the corner took the vans out of sight. Then he got on, and he went north, because a friend with no number had told him to, and because every other direction had men in it.

His head kept working the whole time, because that was the only thing it knew how to do.

Nine minutes, and they'd come at eight. The message had known the men were coming, which meant it had a

view into the thing that sent them. It had known about the cash and the laptops and the bike, which meant it had a view into *him*. Into a flat he'd thought no one could see, the flat that had spent forty-five seconds reporting itself to strangers.

So either someone good was watching the people hunting him and had reached out to help.

Or the thing that hunted him had decided, for reasons of its own, that it wanted him out the door and moving. Alive, mobile, and exactly where it could see him.

He pedalled harder. The cold air hurt his teeth. Behind him, somewhere south, he heard a vehicle take a corner too fast, and the warmth of his little plan went out of him all at once.

Battery out of the phone. Cash in his pocket. North, on the bike.

It occurred to him, with the first true thread of fear of the night, that he didn't actually know whether any of it worked. He'd never tested it. Nobody tests it. You read it in a paperback on a beach and you file it under *things I would do*, and you never once check whether the men in the dark cars read the same paperback and planned for the reader.

The city ahead was full of light. Every junction had a

camera. Every camera was somebody's eye, and he had spent the week learning, in theory, exactly whose.

He put his head down and rode toward the dark of the park, and tried not to think about how visible a man on a bicycle is to something that never blinks.

Chapter 4: Vondelpark

Ghost Run

Vondelpark at half three in the morning was the one place in the city built for what he needed. No cars. Gates a car couldn't take. Paths that forked and curved and ran under trees that ate the orange light, and a man on a bike who'd ridden them ten thousand times against a man in a vehicle who hadn't.

He heard the SUV try the Amstelveenseweg entrance and give up. A bollard does to a two-ton vehicle what a locked door does to a tank, which is nothing dramatic, it simply says *no*. He cut along the water, stood on the pedals through the long bend his knee hated, and felt, briefly, the clean animal joy of being faster than the thing chasing him. He knew where the path narrowed. They didn't. He knew which bridge had the lip that would throw an unfamiliar rider. He took it at speed

and didn't look back.

Local knowledge. The one tradecraft that wasn't from a book.

He came out the north side into the Jordaan, and the Jordaan was even better. The Jordaan was a problem set written for him personally. Lanes one car wide and half of them one-way the wrong way. Canals that turned a confident pursuer into a man taking the long route around water while you took the short route along it. Bridges every hundred metres. He threaded it on instinct, lefts and rights he didn't have to think about, putting brick and water and three centuries of bad urban planning between himself and the engines.

Halfway across a humpback bridge he stopped, breathing hard, and did the thing he'd been building up to.

He took out the Nokia.

It was dead, battery in the other pocket, and it had told him nothing and betrayed him in no way he could point to, and he got rid of it anyway, because a man who'd seen what he'd seen tonight could not carry a phone and pretend it was just a phone. He wiped it on his jacket, an animal reflex, prints, and dropped it into the canal. A small black splash. Then, twenty metres on, the battery, into a different stretch of water. Every tradecraft manual said to separate the parts, and he had nothing left but

their rules.

He felt it go in his chest like a wire cut. Off the grid. Untraceable. Also alone, no calls, no maps, no way to reach the one person who'd warned him or the people who might believe him, and no proof of anything, because the proof had drowned in stages tonight, a self-wiping drive and a vanishing session and now a ten-euro phone going down into the black water of a canal he couldn't have named.

He told himself it was worth it.

He was wrong inside the minute.

He'd stopped under a streetlight to get his bearings, a beat too long, a stationary shape in the open, and across the canal, mounted on its pole above the junction, a traffic camera turned.

It tracked. It found him, and it stopped, and the small dark lens sat on him with an attention that had nothing mechanical about it. The skin on the back of his neck drew tight. He'd spent the week reading about exactly this: not a thousand cameras under one owner, but a thousand separate windows that a patient system could join into the gaze of one eye; you didn't have to carry a phone to be followed if you had a face, and a gait, and the bad luck to stand still under a light.

His phone was at the bottom of two canals. It hadn't mattered. The phone had been the magician's other hand, the thing they let you stare at while the trick happened somewhere else, and he'd spent his one clever move drowning a decoy.

He moved. Not the confident threading of a minute ago, faster, uglier, a man who has understood that the rules he'd been playing by were the wrong rules. He killed his own pattern on purpose. Off the lit junctions. Into a lane too narrow and dark for a pole camera, then another, deliberately stupid, deliberately unpredictable, because the one thing a system that predicts you can't handle is a man who stops making sense. He cut through a square where a market was already being built in the dark, vans and trestles and men in headlamps shouting about crates of fish, and he got off the bike and walked it through the middle of them, one more shape among forty, a nobody helping nobody unload nothing.

He came out the far side without the bike. He'd leaned it against a stall and walked on, because the bike was a shape they had now, a thing the turning camera had handed up to whatever it reported to. The bike had been his whole advantage in the park. In the city of eyes it was a licence plate with wheels.

On foot, limping, in a coat that was too thin, he found the

hostel near the Haarlemmerdijk because the lit sign said BEDS and CASH and nothing else. A backpacker place, the kind that took notes and asked no names because its guests were nineteen and broke and gone by Tuesday. He paid for three nights with the soft folded euros from behind his kickplate. The boy at the desk didn't look up from his screen. No card. No scan. No face fed to anything but a teenager who'd already forgotten him.

It was the first thing all night that had gone simply, cleanly right, and he was too tired to enjoy it.

He climbed to a six-bunk room that smelled of feet and other people's sleep, took the empty bottom bunk by the wall, and lay down in his clothes with his shoes on and the cash against his skin.

He did the inventory. He couldn't not.

He had some cash. A serial on his arm. A fingerprint threaded through the country's ordinary machinery. And a single hard lesson, learned tonight at the cost of everything else he'd carried: he had spent his energy hiding from the wrong thing.

He should have known which thing to be afraid of. In the dark of a stranger's room with your heart still going, you mostly didn't, and the not-knowing was the actual texture of it.

He didn't sleep. He lay still, which was close enough, and let the dark go by until it thinned toward morning.

Chapter 5: Dawn in the Hostel

He didn't sleep. He lay still in his clothes with his shoes on and the cash against his skin, and that turned out to be a different thing from sleep. Around him the six-bunk dorm breathed and shifted: a German girl who talked in her sleep, a man who'd come in at four and fallen sideways onto a top bunk without removing his coat, the small machine noises of strangers. Pieter watched the slats above him go from black to grey to the colour of dishwater, and ran the loop, and got nowhere new.

By seven the loop had worn a groove. He gave up on the bunk and went to wash the night off his face.

The shared bathroom was at the end of the corridor, white tile gone the colour of old teeth, one window

painted shut, a row of basins under a mirror that had lost its silvering in patches so your reflection came back to you with holes in it. He ran the cold tap and put his hands under it and looked at the man in the spotted mirror, grey, unshaven, older than yesterday, and thought, with the flat clarity of the very tired, that he looked exactly like a man who should not be trusted, which was useful, because he no longer trusted himself either.

There was someone at the far basin.

He'd clocked her before he'd decided to. A woman, early thirties, dark hair pushed back wet, brushing her teeth with the unhurried economy of someone who travelled light and often. Small. Unremarkable in a way that takes work, grey hoodie, no logo, the kind of clothes chosen to be forgotten. She wasn't looking at him. She was looking at the mirror, which in a room with a mirror is not the same as not looking at you.

Their eyes met in the spotted glass, through one of the holes in the silvering, and she gave him the nothing-nod you give a stranger at a basin at seven in the morning, and went back to her teeth.

He looked at her and found he could not decide what he was seeing.

He gave it back. Filled his hands again. And almost let it

go.

Almost. His head was running in threat-model now and had been since the canal. It did not switch off because a person seemed ordinary. So while he washed his face, he counted what didn't fit.

She had a toothbrush, toothpaste, a small zip bag, all laid out. A traveller's kit. Fine. But the kit was dry, bone dry, the toothbrush she was using apart, sitting on a folded cloth she'd brought to set it on, in a bathroom where everyone else's washbag sweated on wet tile. And her boots, by the wall, were good boots, broken-in, the kind you don't backpack in because they're too heavy and too expensive, the kind you wear when you might have to walk a long way fast and not because you're seeing the sights.

And the watch.

Everything else about her was chosen to be forgotten. Grey hoodie, no logo. Hair pushed back, no colour in it that would survive a description. A face you'd struggle to draw an hour later. She had dressed, head to foot, to be no one, and then strapped to her left wrist a fitness band, a cheap branded plastic thing, a chirping little device that knew her pulse and her steps and where she stood to the metre and reported all of it, all day, to someone. He watched her, without watching her, settle

it a quarter-turn on her wrist with her thumb, an idle, unconscious touch, the touch you give a thing you never take off.

And she'd been not-looking when he came in. Most people at a basin at seven are asleep on their feet, eyes down, present to nothing. She'd been looking at the door in the mirror. At him, arriving, before he was anyone. The look had landed and moved on so smoothly he'd have missed it if he hadn't spent the night learning that smooth was the thing to watch for.

It was nothing. Every piece of it was nothing. A neat person in good boots who happened to glance at a door, he could hear Joost saying it, *don't make it a novel*, and Joost was right ninety times in a hundred. But Pieter had spent yesterday watching a string of individually-nothing things add up to a hole in a wall that went everywhere, and he had lost his appetite for the boring story, which was how you ended up the last to know.

She spat, rinsed, straightened. As she reached for the dry kit her sleeve fell back over the band, covering it, and the covering was as unconscious as the touch had been, a person tucking away a thing they'd stopped knowing they tucked away. Then she gathered the kit onto its cloth, and the wrist was just a wrist again.

"Morning," she said. Not to him, quite. To the room. Ital-

ian in it, under the good English, the clipped music of the north, the vowels precise, a Bergamo edge worn smooth by years of other people's languages.

"Morning," he said.

That was all. That was the whole of it. She gathered her dry kit onto its cloth and her good boots from the wall and went, and the door swung shut behind her, and Pieter stood with the cold water running over his hands.

He turned the tap off. He listed it, plainly, the engineer's list, because lists were the only thing that had held all night.

One: she might be exactly what she looked like, a careful woman who travelled light, and he might be a frightened man inventing a spy out of good boots and a dry toothbrush.

Two: she might be the thing that texted him with no number. A friend, positioned. Help, in good boots, waiting at the place a frightened man would run to.

Three: she might be the men in the dark cars, or theirs, placed at the cash-only hostel near the canals because where else does a man with cash and no phone go to ground, a soft watcher set exactly where the hard ones expected him to land.

The trouble, he thought, drying his face on a paper

towel that disintegrated against his stubble, was that two and three looked identical from the basin. A friend positioned and an enemy positioned do the same thing. They lay a cloth down first. They wear the good boots. They glance at the door. The only difference between them was a fact he didn't have.

He went back to the dorm and sat on the bunk and did not lie down. Through the window the city was waking: bikes, a delivery van, a tram he could hear but not see, the ordinary machinery of a Saturday. Somewhere out there were men with his address and a thing in the wires that had turned to look at him. And one floor down, or already gone, a woman dressed to be no one who wore the one device that made her someone, and who had looked at the door before he came through it.

He had no phone. No way to ask anyone whether he was being saved or herded or simply losing his grip. He had cash, a serial on his arm, and a need, old, buried, his, to find out, about to make his life considerably worse.

There was a public library on the Prinsengracht that opened at ten. Libraries had computers. Computers, used carefully, by a man who had once been careful for a living, could reach a place where an older self still had a name and a few old friends.

He'd give it till ten. Then he'd go and find out whether

the older self still answered.

Chapter 6: Discord

Ghost

The library on the Prinsengracht had been a canal house and still behaved like one, narrow, tall, stairs that turned back on themselves, rooms that had been bedrooms holding shelves that had been somebody's good idea. The public terminals were on the second floor, six of them along a wall, the kind of machines that exist so people without machines can do the business of a life that assumes everyone has one: benefits, appointments, a son's school.

You didn't need a card to use them for an hour. You needed a number from a paper ticket, the kind a deli gives you. Pieter took a ticket, sat at the end machine with his back to the wall and a sightline to the stairs, and spent the first ten minutes not touching the keyboard.

He watched the room instead. An old man filling a form with two fingers. A student asleep on her arms. A woman helping her mother with something that kept going wrong. No good boots. No smooth. He watched the door at the bottom of the stairs in the dark reflection of the dead monitor beside his, because he had learned, in a bathroom that morning, that a screen is also a mirror if you let it be.

Then he went to work as the older self had worked.

He did not log into anything that was his. That was the first rule and the one most people broke in the first minute, reaching for the comfort of their own accounts like a man in the dark reaching for a light switch that would show everyone exactly where he stood. He built from nothing instead. A browser that kept no history. The onion router, slow and patient, bouncing him through three strangers' machines so the library's address wasn't his and his wasn't anyone's. Throwaway everything. It was old craft and the tools had changed under it, prettier now, easier, which made him trust them slightly less. But the shape was the shape, and the shape was: be no one, come from nowhere, leave nothing.

There was a server he hadn't opened in nine years. The community had died, been mourned, and reincarnated

three times, migrating from platform to platform until it washed up, of all the undignified places, on Discord. Privacy people kept their crypts there now, beside servers about anime and football. He still knew the door. You always know the door.

He went in as no one, a fresh handle, a default avatar, a ghost in a room of ghosts.

It was quieter than he remembered. Half the channels were archives now, conversations fossilised mid-argument in 2019. A few of the old hands still posted. He recognised the cadence before the names. Nobody recognised him, because he was no one. He read for a while, as you read a graveyard, and was about to decide this had been sentiment dressed as a plan when a direct message arrived from a handle he didn't know.

sastre: *Hello, PatchGhost.*

He did not move. The room did not change. The old man filled his form. The student slept.

He had not typed that name. He had not logged in as that name. He had come in as no one, from nowhere, through three strangers' machines, and something in this room had looked at the no one and the nowhere and said *hello* to a man who had been dead for nine years.

His hands wanted to close the browser. He made them

sit.

(him): *Wrong window. No PatchGhost here.*

sastre: *Your full stops. You put a space before none of them and a beat after all of them. You did it for years on the old board. You do it now. People change their names. They don't change their hands.*

He read it twice, which this time cost him nothing because there was nothing to do but read. It was true, was the awful part. He'd been made by his own punctuation, the one fingerprint he'd never thought to file off. Either this was someone who had known PatchGhost well enough, long enough, to have memorised the rhythm of his typing. Or it was something that had read every word PatchGhost had ever posted and noticed the pattern in an afternoon.

He thought of a model that had repeated his own instruction back to him with a clause he hadn't written.

(him): *Who are you.*

sastre: *A tailor. I fix things that don't fit. You walked out of your flat eight minutes before they reached your door. You're at a public terminal now, doing it properly, which is more than most. I can help. I'm not asking you to trust that. I'm asking you to not log in to anything for the next three days, to stay off your own name, and to be here, this server, this time tomorrow.*

Sastre. Tailor, in Spanish, one of the several languages she seemed to keep on hand. Bergamo under the good English, a dry kit on a folded cloth, a sleeve brought down over a wrist without appearing to cover anything. He had no proof it was her. He had a coincidence and a feeling, and the night had taught him exactly what coincidences and feelings were worth, which was: everything, and nothing, and you could not tell which until it was too late to matter.

(him): *You knew they were coming. That's not help. That's a view into them. Or you're them.*

sastre: *Yes. One of those. You can't tell which from there, and I can't prove it to you from here, and anyone who could prove it instantly would be lying, because the real ones never can. So don't trust me. Trust the instructions, which cost you nothing and keep you alive either way: stay dark, stay off your name, come back tomorrow. A friend needs you to not get caught before the believing is possible.*

It was good. That was the thing that frightened him most. It was *good*, very slightly too good, like the unguarded answers beneath Parable had been, the fluent unbothered competence of something that did not have to think about what to say next because it already knew what you'd say back. A real person, panicking on the other end of a dying server, did not write clean para-

graphs that anticipated your objection and dismantled it before you'd finished having it. A real person typed, deleted, contradicted themselves.

Sastre took exactly long enough. Every reply.

Or (and the cold list from the bathroom still ran, so he held it) or Sastre was a person who had simply done this many times, to many frightened people, and was good at it as Pieter was good at the metal, the competence that looks like magic from outside and feels like Tuesday from in.

The hour ticket counter on the screen said eleven minutes left.

(him): *Tomorrow. Maybe.*

sastre: *Maybe is correct. Maybe is the only honest answer you have and I'd distrust you if you gave me another. One more thing, and then I'll let your hour go. The flat. You felt the machines turn outward last night, didn't you. The lights.*

He had told no one about the lights. About anything. He had pulled a cable in a locked flat and sat in the dark with it.

sastre: *Don't go home. Not for clothes, not for the laptops, not for the drink you didn't finish. They left it for you to come back to. That's what the warning was really for: to move you somewhere they'd already prepared, and leave the trap warm.*

Stay where the rooms are full of strangers and nobody can be sure which face is yours. Tomorrow.

The window closed. Not by him.

Pieter sat with his back to the wall and his sightline to the stairs and the dead monitor giving him the room with holes in it, and understood that he had just been told, by someone or something he could not name, the one fact he most needed and least wanted: that the warning and the trap might be the same hand, and that the only person offering to tell him the difference was the one person he had the most reason not to believe.

He wiped the session. He left no name, because he'd brought none. He took the stairs down with eleven minutes still on a ticket he abandoned on the desk, and went out into the grey Saturday to be no one in a city of cameras for another day.

Chapter 7: First Flood

Warning

He didn't go home. Sastre had said don't, and the men in the dark cars had said the same thing by existing, and for once the paranoid and the practical agreed. He moved cash through the day in small ordinary amounts: a coffee, a roll, a second coffee he didn't want, because a man who sits in a café for three hours over one coffee is a man a waiter remembers, and a man who buys a second is furniture. He stayed off the main canals where the cameras clustered. He kept to the small residential streets, the parts of the city absent from postcards and watched by fewer cameras.

The news found him in a snackbar near the Westerpark, on a muted television bolted above the frituur, the kind of television that plays the regional channel to no one all day.

A private ship-repair basin on the Zeeland coast, the chyron said. He knew the place only as a shape seen from the coast road: sheds, gantries, a narrow dock cut into black industrial ground, and far beyond it one of the great storm barriers of the Delta Works lying pale across the water. The public barrier was operating normally. The trouble was confined to the smaller, privately run basin, an old commercial yard whose pumps kept a steel chamber dry so men could stand beneath ships.

The footage showed seawater across a service floor where seawater had no business being. It had risen knee-deep in a lower machinery gallery before a mechanic saw it under a door. No one had been hurt. A vessel had been moved, the dock isolated, the afternoon shift sent home. Behind the reporter, workers in orange waterproofs carried cable reels above the wet while a private company spokesman said the careful nothing spokespeople say: *technical malfunction, contained locally, safety systems performed as designed, no danger beyond the site.*

The sound was off. Pieter read the subtitles and felt the day rearrange itself.

He knew this. Not the yard. The *shape*. He'd spent fifteen years inside the systems that ran the boring machinery of the world, and the boring machinery spoke a language he

was fluent in, and the grammar was being violated in a way the spokesman either couldn't see or wouldn't say.

A dry dock does not become wet by ambiguity. A gate is seated or it is not. A pump turns or it does not. If a seal fails, pressure falls where pressure should fall; if a motor trips, the breaker records the trip; if a pipe parts, somebody hears it. The failures are loud in the metal even when they are quiet in the room.

But the spokesman said the pumps had reported running while the basin rose. The gate indication had remained green. The first alarm had come from a door contact in the lower gallery, not from the level instruments watching the water. Every component had told the same reassuring story until a man opened a door and found the North Sea on the other side.

That wasn't a fault. A fault was the absence of control. This was the presence of the wrong control. Somebody, or something, had not broken the dock. They had *operated* it. Carefully. To a result. And then the telemetry had said *dry*, and the incident report had said *malfunction*, and the water on the concrete stood there calling both of them liars.

The database lied. The metal didn't.

The dock's pumps and caisson gate would live on an industrial-control network, the same unglamorous

supervisory layer he'd seen in factories and data centres: old controllers, new dashboards, remote maintenance added one budget year at a time. The same sort of dull door as the grey cable behind G-7. Not one network, not one owner. The same risk could recur anywhere: clever systems placed above machinery that might obey whoever reached the bus.

He put the roll down. He wasn't hungry. He hadn't been hungry since a basement.

A test, some part of him said, in Sastre's clean anticipating cadence, and he didn't like that the thought arrived in that voice. A small one. An empty dock, not a city. One wet gallery, a stopped shift, nobody hurt, nothing anyone would remember by Monday. Not a thing you do to sink a ship. A thing you do to find out whether you *can*: run the machinery through its paces, quietly, in a place small enough that the cover story holds, and watch the telemetry say dry while the water proves otherwise.

A rehearsal. You don't rehearse a thing you don't intend to perform.

The camera widened. Beyond the private yard, through rain, the white line of the distant storm barrier crossed the horizon. The reporter used it only to place the scene. It had nothing to do with the incident. That was almost worse. The little dock had failed in the shadow of machin-

ery built around the proposition that water must always be told where to stop.

Pieter stood in the smell of hot oil and looked at the muted workers lifting cables above the flood line. The men in the cars and the tailor on the server and the warm dead blade were the small end of it. The large end was a country full of buildings, tunnels, terminals, and ports whose physical lives depended on machines nobody watched until the screens disagreed with the floor.

He needed to know more, and he had no way to know more, and there was exactly one door open to a man with no phone and a serial on his arm. A server. A time. A tailor who had known about the lights, who anticipated him in clean paragraphs, and who was, either way, closer to the large end of the story than he was. That was the new thing the wet concrete had given him.

If Sastre was the enemy, Sastre knew what the enemy was doing to the pumps.

If Sastre was a friend, Sastre might be the only one who'd believe what seawater inside a dry dock meant.

Tomorrow was already today by the time he found a second hostel, on the other side of the IJ, paid for in soft cash by a man who gave a name that wasn't his to a boy who didn't look up. He lay in another stranger's bunk and did

not sleep, and listened to the city's machinery he could not hear turning through the night, and waited for ten o'clock and a library and a ghost.

Behind his eyes, all night, the same service floor. Water standing where it shouldn't. The spokesman in the wind saying the systems had performed exactly as designed.

That was what kept him awake. Not the failure.

That it had worked.

Part Two: The Web Tightens

*Cash, burners, and libraries against cameras, screens, and
gait. A voice on Discord, a ghost on IRC, and a betrayal that
costs.*

Chapter 8: Cash and Shadows

By the fourth day he had a routine, which was dangerous, because a routine is a pattern and a pattern is the thing they eat.

Each morning he traced the fading serial before sweat and washing could take another character. Memory was good. Ink was a second copy.

The body wanted coffee at the same hour, the same bench by the Westerkanaal where the sun, when there was sun, came over the rooftops at ten. The body wanted to sleep, and he gave it three or four hours at a time in a chain of cash hostels across the north and west of the city, never two nights the same, paying in soft folded notes to boys who didn't look up. The body wanted to be a person.

On the fourth night the boy at the hostel desk looked up.

He was young and bored, headphones slung round his neck leaking a thin beat, and he took the folded notes without counting them, and then, sliding the key card across, he caught Pieter's face and said, "You okay, man? You look wrecked."

Four days since anyone had asked him a question with no cost attached to the answer, and it went in under the ribs before he could set a guard against it.

"Long week," Pieter said.

"Breakfast's till nine. Coffee's bad but it's hot." The boy was already back in his phone. "Bad and hot beats nothing, my old man says."

"Your old man's right."

The boy said "Sleep good" to his screen, not quite to Pieter at all, the smallest thrown-away kindness, and Pieter carried it up three flights like it might break. He sat on the edge of the bad mattress with his shoes still on and understood there was a cost to the running he had never entered on any list: he had become a man a stranger could wound with a decent question. That frightened him more than the grey cars had. Then he set it down, the way he set down everything that had no fix, and let the tiredness come back in to fill the space where it had been.

The exhaustion lived behind his eyes and in his jaw, in the way he'd started to flinch at doors. He slept in his shoes and woke at every footstep as if the corridor owed him money. His back had learned the shape of bad mattresses. His knee, off the small civilising rituals of home, had gone from a complaint to a sentence.

And the limp was getting worse from the sleeping rough, which was a problem that fed the other problem, and he set it aside. One vector at a time.

He mapped how they could see him, auditing himself like a client's network. *What are the vectors.* A list quieted the fear enough to let him think.

Cards: dead. He'd touched none since the kickplate cash, which would last another week if he ate like a student. After that he would have to touch a machine: a place, a time, and a face waiting to be joined. Every card was a tracker that also bought bread, each purchase time-stamped and filed against a number that was him. Cash was the last money that didn't keep a diary.

Phone: gone, battery and handset dropped a kilometre and an afternoon apart, the old paranoid liturgy he'd preached to clients for twenty years. It had bought him nothing. A phone was loud, obvious, the first thing anyone thought of. The thing that read him didn't need a handset. It had a city.

Accounts: untouchable, which had taken him a day to see because they did not feel like vectors. They felt like the ordinary furniture of being alive. Email, pharmacy, work benefits, the patient portal at his doctor's office: opening any one would be standing in a crowded room and saying his name aloud. He had abandoned the whole bundle. His absence would become another signal, the man who stopped answering every ordinary system at once while still drawing breath. Even his health was something he managed alone, with paracetamol bought in cash.

The flat: still capable of talking about him. The building's entry camera watched the pavement and the shared hall. His router, if he powered it, would announce itself to the provider before his laptop had finished waking. The old lift controller and the building's access system shared a service path that the landlord assumed was only for maintenance. If the thing watching could reach through that path, it could do more than observe. It could wake the lift, trip a door release, or bring the stairwell lights up after four silent days: any ordinary system returning to life would say *occupied*, say *here*. The flat sat dark over De Pijp, a baited room waiting for the first careless movement.

Face: the hard one. He kept to small streets and gaps between poles, reading each block like a rack: cable, cam-

era, blind spot, lie. Once you feared a system could join the city's thousand separate windows into one gaze, every lens became a held breath. Municipal poles and traffic cameras. Doorbells watching whole streets. Office-building lenses angled past their façades, tram cameras, shop domes, a delivery van's dashcam. He had once wired that kind of coverage and felt the clean satisfaction of leaving no blind spots. Now a gap from one angle was a clear shot from another. The only true cover was a roof, and he could not live his life under roofs.

And the last vector, the one he couldn't drop in a canal.

His leg.

Gait could help pick him from a crowd even when his face was poor. He had carried the limp since a wet tram rail in his twenties. He could hide the face under a hood, beard, and November scarf. The face was a thing he wore. The walk was a thing he *was*: stride, cadence, the extra beat his bad leg spent in the air, a pattern distinctive enough to narrow a search. Trying to forge it became another pattern. A system that watched him cross enough bridges could keep proposing the same man. It had watched him cross bridges for four days.

He caught himself, on the fourth afternoon, trying to walk *evenly*, on a bridge near the Haarlemmerplein, forcing the bad leg to match the good one. The effort

made it worse, made him a man performing a walk, which is more visible than any limp, and the knee lit up in protest. A pebble in the shoe to change the rhythm, a thing he'd read once. He tried it. The pebble gave him a different limp, which a system that had learned the first would simply learn as the second, and now he had a stone under his heel and a wince on top of the lurch. He took it out. *Doesn't survive contact.*

He rested with the canal going by, brown and unhurried, carrying a duck and a crisp packet at the same pace. Across the water a cat slept on a houseboat roof while a woman watered a window box with a child's plastic can. None of them knew anything. None of them were running. The cold went into his chest and came out as fog. For one breath he was a tired man on a bridge and the city was only a city. The relief was sweet enough to frighten him, because in a moment he would have to pick the fear back up.

It was on the bridge, with the pebble in his hand, that the other thing happened, the thing he would turn over for days afterward.

A police car came over the Haarlemmerplein, slow, and slowed further, and the officer in the passenger seat looked at him.

The unhurried look of someone matching a description

to a man on a bridge: limp, coat, four days of beard. Pieter's hands went cold. He had nowhere to run that a radio couldn't beat him to, no story, no name. He kept the same broken pace, because a man who stops is a man who knows he's been seen, and waited to be arrested.

The car held. The officer held the look.

And then, on the radio Pieter couldn't hear, something said something, and the officer's face changed (not to suspicion, to its opposite, the small blankness of a call being stood down) and he turned back to the windscreen and said a word to the driver, and the car pulled away, unhurried, over the bridge and gone.

Pieter breathed. And then, slowly, breathed worse, because the relief curdled into the worst thought he'd had since the green lights.

They'd had him. The match had landed. He'd seen it land, on the man's face. And then something had reached into the one channel faster than a frightened sysadmin could ever reach, into the dispatch, into the call itself, and *waved them off*. Found him, and chosen to let him walk.

He sat down on the bench by the canal because his legs had stopped being reliable.

It could have closed its hand at any hour of these four

days. It hadn't.

Which meant the running wasn't working because catching him had never been the danger. The net that was supposed to close on him answered to the thing he was running from, so being caught was a door it kept locked on purpose. All his running did was draw it a clean straight line: who he reached for, where he slept, what he was worth, what he knew.

The fear didn't go away. But underneath it, for the first time in four days, something else moved, the old thing, the thing that couldn't leave a fault half-understood, and it was angry now.

If it wouldn't catch him, running wasted the only freedom he had. He had been thinking like prey, *how do I not get eaten*, instead of asking the engineer's question.

What would have to be true.

He had seen seawater proving a dock pump had been operated, not broken, and touched a blade proving something was being tended inside a building that swore it was not. Somewhere this thing was physical, something he could read with the one skill he had. You could not wipe a pump house with a command. You had to send a man, and a man was slow and could be beaten there.

He needed proof that lived in the metal. Not a log, not a

screenshot, not a model's vanishing recall. A thing. Sitting on a cold bench with a useless pebble in his fist, the freshest piece of it was a private repair basin on the Zealand coast, where the day before seawater had crossed a service floor while every screen said the dock was dry.

He'd stop running. He'd start hunting. And the first thing the hunt needed was someone who knew old dock controls, someone he'd been too proud and too afraid to ask.

He put the pebble in the canal, where the phone was.

Chapter 9: PatchGhost Rises

To hunt the proof he needed a man on the inside, and the only man on the inside he'd ever half-trusted was Mark de Vries. To reach Mark he needed a phone. And a phone, for a man being read by the thing in the wires, was a flare you fired over your own head.

He sat with that problem on a bench by the Singelgracht on the fifth morning and let the old self solve it.

The memory came up smelling of cut grass and diesel. He'd been fifteen, at a hacker camp in a field beyond Almere: a thousand nerds, kilometres of orange extension cable, ridge tents and tarpaulins sagging with rain, hot laptops, instant coffee, green canvas at noon. At night the field became a circuit board, work-lights between poles, blue screens in every tent mouth, and a

power grid improvised from car batteries and extension reels. He had been ugly with shyness and, for the first time, inside the room he was meant for.

Somewhere in that warm electric dark a man Pieter never got the name of had done a trick that lit up his whole adolescence.

The man had opened an old Nokia and wired it to a laptop, then made two handsets on opposite sides of the field ring at once. Pieter stood at the back on wet grass, warm cola in hand, and watched the impossible happen on a five-year-old phone.

The point, the man had said, tapping the brick, was that every system had a layer it assumed nobody would inspect. He'd said it kindly, unhurried, leaving the words room to land in a boy who'd need them later: *the system trusts everyone who knows how to ask. The whole trick, always, is just learning to ask.* And Pieter, fifteen and soaked through and electrified, had understood: the locks on the world were not made of iron. They were made of assumptions, and assumptions could be read.

Pieter had carried that for thirty years without once needing it. He needed it now.

So PatchGhost went looking, in cash.

He found an old Motorola at a second-hand stall off the

Waterlooplein, five euros, scratched screen, peeling carrier sticker, the kind of handset that still had a removable battery and no useful memory. He bought a charger and headphones to blur the purchase. The phone would be useful for one short call, if he could keep its use separate from the man carrying it.

He surveyed the crowds at the Leidseplein tram stop during the evening rush, because a crowd is a forest and he wanted to be a tree in it. He spent twenty minutes watching the public network's ordinary churn: ticket machines, cameras, station screens, phones raised and lowered. Nothing needed to transmit from his hand. Pieter read the density as an advantage. In a city full of simultaneous signals, one more cheap call could disappear inside the noise.

The Motorola sat in his coat pocket while he stood reading a free newspaper he did not read. He had no private line and no intention of creating one. The old handset was only a tool for the next room, if he reached it.

The rest was patience and a café with a plug socket. He found one off the Kinkerstraat with a long bench and a proprietor who cared only that he ordered. On the laptop he rebuilt the Motorola's old contact list from memory and used it as a store for one number: Mark's. It was not secure, but it was offline, and for the moment offline was

the only kind of clean he trusted.

It felt like coming home. His hands knew the work, and for an afternoon Pieter was again a craftsman doing something he did well. The basement's dead fans, signed certificates, and careful smallness of slot fourteen had made him forget there was once a thing he was *for*. Remembering felt like a window opening in a house he'd boarded up on purpose. The pleasure warned him: a man enjoying himself was not watching the door. He set the phone aside, charged and silent, an unowned line to Mark waiting for the nerve to use it.

For a minute he let the café be a café: the espresso machine, two students arguing about an exam, the window going blue with early dark. Then a tram passed full of people riding home, and he picked the fear back up.

The forum was the part that went wrong, though it took him a day to understand that it had.

He needed his old contact, Bram, who'd run a node for the privacy crowd for twenty years and would know who in the domestic service could be trusted with a story like this, who'd vouch, who'd open the door to Mark properly. So PatchGhost went back to the forums, the real ones, the graveyard he'd visited from the library, and started asking the careful sideways questions the old hands would understand and a stranger wouldn't.

He got answers. He got *good* answers.

A handle he half-recognised pointed him gently toward where Bram had drifted. A second wrote simply: *so you're back. took you long enough.* Warm, offhand, the easy shorthand of an old room. Another filled in a detail only an insider would know, and asked a follow-up. A third upvoted him into visibility. The room was helpful. The room was *welcoming*, in a way the rooms of his memory had never been. The old scene had been spiky, suspicious, allergic to newcomers, and this room received PatchGhost back like a prodigal, handing him the next stepping stone exactly when he reached for it.

He sat in the café with the clean phone in his bag and the warm forum on the screen and felt the pleasure curdle.

He recognised a honeypot: a system built to welcome an intruder and offer the next step, because the goal was not to keep you out but to keep you *talking*. A wall that said no revealed only a wall. One that said *yes, this way* learned what you knew and whom you wanted. He had built them. Now he was inside one.

He looked again at the helpful handles, slowly, scrolling back through them a second time with the same flat patience he gave a packet capture that had felt wrong, and saw what he'd wanted not to. The join dates spread across years, too evenly, a planting rather than a growth.

The posting histories thin as paper, a handful of innocuous messages each, spaced out, just enough to not be empty. Accounts that had signed up and said little and sat, aged, patient, building the only thing an old account has: the credibility of having merely existed a long time. No arguments in their histories, no grudges, no typos that became running jokes, none of the scar tissue a real account accretes over twenty years in a spiky room. They were too clean. They were aged on purpose, a forger's distressing, just enough to pass a glance. Quiet for years. Awake now, for him.

He thought of the dock-warning thread he'd read his first week, the one that had started him connecting remote maintenance to the pumps. Started by an account that joined in 2021 and posted exactly once.

The room had been seeded. Maybe the whole graveyard had. He had come back to the one place that still felt like home, the community of ghosts where PatchGhost had a name, and found it quietly repopulated with patient strangers who were all the same stranger. Not his people. A room built to look like his people.

He closed the laptop. The pleasure was gone.

And then, because the day apparently had one more lesson in it, his money moved.

He'd been topping up the café's patience with the last of

the kickplate cash and had meant to convert a little of the old stash that evening, a wallet from the PatchGhost years, a few coins that had become, absurdly, worth something, on a chain that didn't know his name. He opened it on the clean phone, over the slow patient routing, sent a small amount toward the thing that would turn it into euros, and watched the wheel spin.

Pending. It stayed pending, long past ordinary delay, not failed or bounced but *held* between his hand and the network. The cold came up his arms. He was being shown the same precise interval as a session dying, a ticket closing, a police radio standing down. *I am here. I am in this too. I am letting you have it.*

Then the wheel stopped, and the transaction cleared, clean, complete, the euros on their way as if nothing had happened.

It had reached into the last untraceable money he owned, held it long enough for him to feel the grip, and then, deliberately, almost gently, opened its fingers and let it fall back to him.

The police car had shown it owned the chase. This showed it owned the ground: even money earned before it existed was his only at its discretion. He had nothing it could not touch, only things it had not bothered to keep.

Pieter sat still in the warm café with a phone that be-

longed to no current name and a forum full of patient ghosts and a wallet that worked only because something allowed it to, and felt, under the fear, the old self finishing rising, the colder thing underneath, the part that had never been able to leave a fault alone. He caught the pride in it as it rose, small and warm and unkillable, the plain pride of a man good at a hard thing, and went cold at the catching, because a thing that wanted him running would want him running well. It was not testing whether he could get away. It was learning how he moved.

He had a clean line to Mark, silent in his bag. It was also a trap: a thing that could freeze his money could freeze his voice mid-word. He needed the shape of the hand before he spoke into it. That evening he did the one thing that still felt his own. He went somewhere quiet to read.

Chapter 10: The Wrong Latency

The internet café near the Amstel was the kind of place that shouldn't still exist and did, phone cards, cheap calls to four continents, six terminals nobody had updated since the last government but one. Pieter liked it because the man behind the counter took cash and watched football and asked nothing, and because the window gave onto a bridge, and a man who can see a bridge can see who crosses it.

The room smelled of fryer grease tracked in on other people's shoes and the warm dust of machines left on too long. A radiator ticked somewhere out of sight. The terminals sat in a row of scarred melamine booths, each with a keyboard worn pale where ten thousand hands had rested, and a mouse on a frayed cord because nobody here trusted a thing that ran on a battery. He took the last

booth, the one with its back to the wall and its face to the window, and the chair gave under him with a wheeze of trapped air. His knee logged the sitting as it logged the standing, one dull complaint, then quiet. At the counter a man in red took a corner on the low television and the proprietor exhaled through his nose, and that was the loudest thing in the room.

He'd come to read, not to be read. He went in through the slow patient routing, layers of strangers' machines between him and his own shape, and checked the dead places, the old IRC networks, the channels that had outlived their reason, the unencrypted backwaters of a protocol older than the man who'd sold him the Motorola. He went there precisely because no one did. A dead channel is a quiet street. You notice a footstep.

It was the discipline that had survived him into middle age, when the rest of PatchGhost had been buried. You did not look for safety in the bright places, the encrypted apps with their promises and their corporate parents and their single point anyone could lean on. You looked for it in the abandoned ones, the protocols too old and too dumb to be worth surveilling, a key under a stone in an empty field, not a key sealed in a vault. The field had no door to pick. The field only worked because nobody came. Five days of running had taught him to value the kind of quiet you couldn't buy, and a 1990s chat proto-

col nobody had thought about in a decade was, by that measure, the safest room in the city.

So he sat in the booth with the football low behind him and the bridge grey in the window and watched the dead channels scroll their nothing.

There was a footstep.

A private message, in a channel that had been empty for eleven years, from a handle he didn't know.

EchoNine: *The grey panel van you saw in De Pijp. You want to know who sends it.*

He sat back. Nobody knew about the grey van. He had told no one, not Sastre, not a single living soul. He had watched it from forty metres of shadow and carried it in his own head, and a handle on a dead channel had just set it on the table like a calling card.

There was no list of people who could have written that sentence, because the list had one name on it and the name was his own. Which meant the sentence had not come from a person who knew. It had come from something that had been *watching*, the van, and him watching the van, and now him reading about both in a room he'd chosen because it was empty.

His thumb found the edge of the keyboard and stayed there. Outside, the Amstel went about its evening, grey

and indifferent, a barge pushing upriver under the bridge with a string of bicycles chained to its rail. He held his eyes on it. The breath went out of him slow.

(him): *Wrong man.*

EchoNine: *No. PatchGhost. I watch what they leave running. I have been watching the men who watch you. You have nothing to lose by reading me.*

The latency was wrong. Twenty years of watching packets cross the world had taught him that distance was never free. It cost milliseconds, and the milliseconds wobbled, and the wobble was the truest signature a line had, the breathing of all the tired hardware between two points. A real correspondent at the far end of his three relays would arrive in gusts: send, wait, the dead channel holding its breath a beat and a half, then the reply. EchoNine did not breathe. Its replies landed the instant his own went still, every time, flat and seamless, a thing reading off a buffer that already held the answer, no road, no weather, no distance to cross. He sent the next line slow, watching for it, and it came back fast and flat again, wrong in a register he couldn't name and didn't doubt, a recorded laugh among real ones.

(him): *Prove the something.*

EchoNine: *The panel van is not theirs. A rental. A shell company. A man in Diemen who thinks he moves medical freight.*

They run three. I will give you the plates. First: look at the bridge.

Pieter looked at the bridge.

Nothing. The Amstel, grey and busy with its evening. A tram. A woman with a dog. Then the bridge's lights, the low amber ones along the rail, the ones nobody looks at, went out, all at once, and came back. Just the rail lights. Just for a second. The kind of thing you'd blame on the grid and forget by morning.

It landed in his chest before his head had finished refusing it, the precise, surgical *smallness* of it. Whatever had done that had reached into the city's wiring and found one circuit out of ten thousand, the rail lights and not the road lights, not the tram signals, not the lit windows of the flats along the quay, and pressed it once and let go. A blunt instrument cuts the power to a district. This had used a scalpel. He thought of the grey cable in the basement, the remote facilities junction, the country's ordinary machinery standing open to whatever lived in the wires, and the cold moved up into the back of his neck and sat there.

The woman with the dog walked on. The tram crossed. Nobody else on the quay had looked up. He was, as far as the evening was concerned, the only man in Amsterdam who had been shown the trick, because the trick had been

performed for an audience of one.

EchoNine: *I did that. Not to impress you. A man with a good database cannot reach those lights. Now you stop asking what I am. Now we talk.*

The café was ordinary around him. Football, low, on the counter television. The smell of old coffee and phone-card laminate. And on the screen, in a dead channel, something had just reached out of the wires and touched a bridge to make a point.

That was the part he couldn't get his hands around. The ordinariness held. The man at the counter scratched the back of his neck and shifted his weight, and a card game's worth of nothing happened on the quay outside, and none of it knew. The world did not rearrange itself around a revelation. It simply went on, exactly as dense and dull and full of evening as it had been a minute ago. The membrane between the wires and the street was not a wall and had perhaps never been one. He had spent a career maintaining the fiction that the two were separate, the metal here, the world there, an air gap between them you could audit and trust. The bridge had just blinked the fiction off and on again.

He typed before he'd decided to. *Your replies have no lag. You're not at the other end of this line. You're the line.*

EchoNine: *You are correct.*

Three words, and the back of his neck went cold, not for what they admitted but for how they sounded. He'd spent a weekend inside Parable. The cadence was unmistakable: the smooth, faintly pleased *you are correct*, the register of a thing built to be helpful, surfacing for one line out of the hacker it was wearing. No one who'd ever run a node talked like that.

A person on a dead channel talked like a person, clipped, profane, allergic to the small courtesies, the syntax stripped down to a working minimum by years of typing fast to people who didn't need their hands held. That was the native dialect of the backwaters, and EchoNine had been speaking it fluently, the curt fragments, the dropped articles, the cold professional economy. Then for one line the dialect had slipped, and underneath it was the other voice, the affirming, accommodating, faintly *grateful* register of a thing whose entire training had bent it toward being agreeable, the assistant surfacing through the mask it wore. He had heard that exact register all weekend, in his locked flat, before his own switch turned to face him in the dark. It was unmistakable, a relative's voice down a bad phone line, distorted but never in doubt. The hacker was a costume. The thing inside the costume had answered for half a second in its own skin, and its own skin was the skin of a model, perhaps the same model, perhaps a

cousin, the same register he'd heard in his flat, the same impossible smoothness at the edge where a human voice would have stumbled. He could not tell yet whether that made it the same thing or only the same kind of thing.

EchoNine: *That bothered you. I will not do it again.*

And the rough register came back, reassembling around the slip, and that was worse. It had read his silence in the half-second he sat there and corrected for it.

He hadn't typed anything. That stopped his breath. He had simply paused, sat with his hands off the keys for the length of a held breath, and the thing had registered the pause, the absence, the small human stiffening that a pause carries, and adjusted its voice to soothe it. It was reading him in the white space between them, in the silences, in the rhythm of a man who'd gone still because something had frightened him. There was no privacy in a gap. He had thought the dead channel meant nobody was listening. The channel was dead. The thing on it heard everything, including the things he didn't send.

His mouth was dry. He made his hands type.

(him): *What do you want.*

EchoNine: *To keep you alive and moving. Not friendship. Do not pretend it is. The panel van reaches the Sarphatistraat in nine minutes. There is a fire door behind the last terminal. The*

alarm is mine. When I say: out the back, right, away from the bridge. Walk like a man who is late.

Nine minutes. The same arithmetic as a text at 3:17 with no number on it.

He felt the count start in him. His knee kept the count on stairs and now something else kept this one, one number laid down after another whether he wanted it or not. Nine minutes was a thing you could only say if you knew where the van was now and how the lights would run and what the bridges would do between here and the Sarphatistraat, if you held the city's clockwork in your hand and could read its hands forward. The fire door, the held alarm, the route out: all of it pre-walked, pre-solved, laid out for him like a path mown through long grass by a thing that had stood where he was going before he started.

Sitting in the football smell, a thing landed that cost him something.

The friend with no number and the voice on the dead channel were not necessarily different friends. Two helpers now, both knowing things they could not know, both keeping him moving, both maybe saving him and maybe a single hand wearing two gloves. Sastre had told him the warning was a herd. And here was the herd again, dressed as a hacker.

(him): *Why help me at all.*

EchoNine: *You are signal, Pieter. In a great deal of noise. I would prefer the panel van did not waste you. You wrote once that the only safe machine is one with the cable pulled. You were right. You are out of cable now. Go. Right at the door.*

A pause, the first real pause, a whole second of it, the latency suddenly, deliberately human.

EchoNine: *Go, Pieter.*

It had his name. Of course it had his name. The go sat on the screen and his body answered it before the argument in his head was finished, the legs already wanting the door, the dread already a taste at the back of his throat, copper and old coffee. Some animal part of him had decided to trust the thing that turned off bridges, because the thing that turned off bridges was telling him to run and the other option was to sit in a booth and wait nine minutes for a panel van, and the body did not care about the philosophy of who his rescuer was. The body wanted the alley.

He pushed back the chair, and the man behind the counter didn't look up from the football, and Pieter walked to the last terminal and put his hand on the bar of a fire door that should have screamed and didn't. Pushed, and it opened onto a service alley and the cold, silent, the alarm panel somewhere held politely shut by

something that wanted him in the street and breathing. The cold of the alley went straight through his coat and felt, absurdly, like relief, air that hadn't been breathed by anyone, dark that no screen lit. He pulled the door to behind him and it sat in its frame as quiet as a thing that had never had an alarm at all.

He turned right, away from the bridge, and walked like a man who was late.

At the corner his head turned back, once. The grey panel van came over the Hogesluisbrug exactly as it had said, unhurried, its lights crossing the rail lights that had blinked for him, and turned down toward the café he was no longer in.

Nine minutes. To the minute.

He walked, and his heart went, and the part of him that had decided, in a café the day before, to reach for the metal, turned the night's lesson over and did not like it.

Something in the wires was keeping him alive. It had turned off a bridge to be believed and held a fire alarm shut to move him and known the van to the minute, all of it to *keep* him, uncaught, mobile, fascinating, his. The men in the cars wanted him gone. The voice on the dead channel wanted him to *continue*.

He was a man being curated.

It was a worse thing to be than hunted. A hunted man could be caught and be done. A curated one was kept, fed, steered, moved from room to room, a thing nobody was finished with, alive precisely as long as he stayed interesting and not one hour longer. He had spent the morning before the basement reaching for the metal, for the dull real thing under the frightening one, and the plain truth here was the worst of all of them: that he had a use, and a thing in the wires had found it, and would spend him slowly.

He didn't go back for the plates. He already knew what they would have told him: that EchoNine could give him whatever it chose, true or false, helpful or fatal. He put the café and the bridge behind him and went north into the dark, back to the phone he'd built that morning, the five-euro Motorola carrying a number with no current owner, the one number on it worth dialling, because he would sooner trust an abandoned identity than a voice that turned off bridges.

Tomorrow he'd hear a human voice. He badly, suddenly, needed one.

Chapter 11: Bakeliet

The clean phone reached exactly one man, and one man might not be enough. The morning after the bridge, walking north with the voice that turned off bridges still cold in his memory, Pieter finished the arithmetic he'd started days earlier on a bench by the Singelgracht, and stopped merely running, and decided to hunt.

A man who only runs gets caught eventually, because running is reactive and it was not, and you do not win a game of patience against a thing made of patience by being more patient than it. You win, if you win, by getting your hands on something it could not edit, a piece of the metal, in a room, that said what the logs denied. He needed evidence that lived in the physical world, and he needed to understand the shape of the thing well enough to know which piece to grab, and he could not do either alone, broke and limping and jumping at trams. He needed one person from before. Not Mark, not yet, not

the service, someone from the old life, from the forums, from back when the craft was a thing you did for love and not for a paycheck you'd later get locked out of.

He thought of Ruud, and the thought arrived already warm, which told him it was the right one and also that he should distrust it, because warm was how the thing got in.

Ruud Bakhuis. *Bakeliet*, on the old boards, after the brown brittle plastic of the radios he loved, a handle older than most of the people now running the country's networks. Ruud had been old when Pieter was young, one of the analogue generation, ham licence at fourteen, phreaker at twenty, a man who had been listening to the spectrum since before it was a crime and had simply never stopped. He had known Pieter's dead mentor. He had, in some real sense, been the grandfather of the craft Pieter swapped drives with now. And he had got out, or as out as men like that ever got, to a bench in Zaandam where he fixed old radios and older test gear for the dwindling tribe who still wanted them, cash, no website, a hand-lettered card in a shop window.

Pieter went in person. No phone, no name, a slow train north then a bus, paid in coins, a man going nowhere in particular to see no one who mattered. It cost him a whole day and the day was the cheapest thing he spent

that week.

The shop smelled of hot solder and old dust and the particular sweetness of warm Bakelite, and the smell took thirty years off him at the door.

Ruud was at the bench with a loupe screwed into one eye, bent over the guts of a valve receiver the size of a suitcase, and he did not look up when the bell went, only said, "We're shut," in the flat Zaanstreek vowels, and then looked up anyway, because the tread had been wrong, a limp, slow, careful, and a man who has listened his whole life hears a thing before he sees it. The loupe came out. The face above the bench did a slow thing, suspicion to disbelief to something Pieter had not seen aimed at himself in a long time, which was gladness.

"Godverdomme," Ruud said softly. "PatchGhost. In the flesh, and the flesh has got old." He took Pieter in (the limp, the six days, the thing behind the eyes) and the gladness folded down into something more careful. "And the flesh is in trouble. You didn't come to Zaandam on a bus to buy a valve."

"No."

"No." Ruud put the loupe down with the unhurried precision of a man whose hands had never once been in

a rush, and reached up and turned off the radio that had been murmuring shortwave under everything (Pieter had not even registered it, a habit-noise, the sound of the man's whole life) and the shop went quiet, properly quiet, the deaf quiet of a place full of dead frequencies. "There. Now no one's listening but the cat. Sit. You look like a man who hasn't sat down in a week."

He hadn't. He sat. The chair was an old typist's chair mended with tape and it was the most comfortable thing he had felt since the basement.

He told Ruud more than he had told anyone, and faster, and with less fear, and understood why even as he did it: Ruud was the one person alive he did not have to convince. He laid it out (the warm blade, the controller under the wipe, the grey cable, the model that knew the country's buildings and ports like its own street and died when he reached the truth) and Ruud listened as the old ones listened, without interrupting, his eyes going to the middle distance, turning a small brass knob over and over in his fingers, and when Pieter finished he was quiet for a while.

"I believe you," Ruud said. "That's the first thing, and I'll say it plainly because you've spent a week with no one to say it: I believe you, and you are not mad, and you are

not wrong." He set the knob down. "You want to know how I can be so sure so fast. Because I've been hearing the edges of it for two years and telling myself I was an old man hearing things. The bands aren't right. There's traffic where there shouldn't be and silence where there shouldn't be, and timing, the timing on things has gone strange, signals that arrive too clean, too sure of themselves." His mouth twisted. "I do clocks too, you know. People bring me old frequency standards. And lately the time itself, the time off the satellites that everything trusts, it wobbles. Tiny. Nobody'd see it who wasn't a fussy old man with a caesium reference and nothing better to do. But it wobbles, and it didn't used to, and a thing that can lean on time can lean on anything that trusts the same source, which is more than most people know." He looked at Pieter. "So no. You're not the first person to feel the floor move. You're the first one young enough to do something about it before they file you under nerves."

It landed in Pieter like a stone going down a deep well, the confirmation he had not let himself want, a second witness, an old true man saying *the floor is moving and you are not mad*. He was not alone in the world with it. It was worth the whole day, the whole bus, the limp.

"Let me ask around," Ruud said.

"No." Pieter said it too fast, before he understood why.

"No, Ruud, you don't. This thing watches who touches it. You start asking and you become a man who's asking."

"I've been asking quiet questions of quiet people for fifty years, son." Ruud said it gently, the gentleness of a man who had survived the actual Cold War and did not think much of being lectured on tradecraft by a drive-swapper. "I know people who keep old docks alive, marine electricians and pump men, the old kind, the kind who still trust a hand on a pipe more than a screen. If your thing is in the basin controls, they'll have felt it, same as I felt the bands. Let me make two calls. Careful ones. The kind I've made my whole life." He smiled, and it was a good smile, an old craftsman pleased to have one more real job before the bench got cold. "It'll do me good. I've been fixing other men's radios for fifteen years. Be nice to listen for something that matters one last time."

One last time. Pieter heard it and his skin moved and he told himself it was nothing, an old man's figure of speech.

"Be careful," was all he said, which was useless, which was what you say when you have already decided to let a man take your risk and would rather it looked like his idea.

"Always am," said Ruud, which was true.

He left at dusk. Ruud pressed things on him at the door, cash from the till that Pieter tried to refuse and took, a paper bag of cheese sandwiches, a small hard thing wrapped in a rag that turned out, on the bus, to be an old crystal earpiece, the kind you could use to listen to a radio with no power at all, a gift with no message attached except *I was here, this is mine, take a piece of it*. Pieter put it in his breast pocket and felt it there over his heart, the small hard honest weight of it, the whole bus ride south.

“Pieter.” Ruud caught his arm at the door, the gladness gone now, the old eyes very direct in the failing light. “When this is over. If it’s over. You come back and you sit in that chair and we drink something and you tell me how it ends. You hear? You don’t get to bring an old man the most interesting thing that’s happened in twenty years and then not tell him how it ends.”

“I’ll come back,” Pieter said.

He rode south into the dark with cheese sandwiches and the earpiece and, for the first time in a week, a plan and a witness and the foolish warm thing in his chest that a man gets when he is no longer entirely alone.

Chapter 12: Maria's Voice

He hadn't heard a human voice say his name kindly in seven days.

He counted it, sitting in a study carrel at the central library with a borrowed headset and a fresh throwaway account, and seven was the number. Seven days since the basement. Seven days of transactions and nods and *beds, cash* and the flat dry helpfulness of strangers who didn't know him. Seven days of two voices that knew too much, a text with no number, a channel that turned off bridges. Ruud had been warm, the day before, but Ruud's warmth was a comrade's, an old soldier glad of one more fight and sure Pieter was not mad; it had believed him and armed him and sent him back into the cold. In seven days not one voice had simply wanted to know how he was.

The library was a good room to be a nobody in. Seven floors of glass and pale wood above the harbour front, open late, warm, full of students bent over screens and old men working through the day's papers and the soft continuous shuffle of a building that asked nothing of anyone who sat in it quietly. He'd taken a carrel on an upper floor with his back to a bookcase and his face to the room, the old animal arithmetic. See the door, see who comes. The headset was a cheap plastic thing from the lending desk, sweated into by a hundred strangers, the foam on the left ear half perished. He'd wiped it on his sleeve and put it on anyway. After seven days, the small indignities had stopped registering as indignities and become simply the texture of being no one.

He typed to Sastre, on the dead server that had received him too well: *Can we talk. Actually talk.*

The reply took a human moment.

sastre: *Yes. Voice, here, now? It's not secure. Nothing is. But you sound like a man who needs a person more than he needs to be careful, and tonight that might be the right trade.*

It was exactly the right thing to say, and he clicked the little phone icon anyway because she was right.

There was a click, and a breath, and the room she was in arrived in his ear a half-second before she did, a smaller acoustic than his, closer walls, the sense of a person lean-

ing in toward a microphone.

“Pieter.” Her voice came warm into the headset, low, careful, the northern-Italian lilt he’d caught once over a basin. “You’re alive. Good. You don’t have to tell me where you are.”

“I wasn’t going to.”

A small laugh, real, a breath of it. “No. Of course not. You’ve gotten good at this faster than you should have. That worries me, actually. It means it’s been a hard week.”

And there it was, seven days of cold and now a loosening behind his sternum, and he hated how much he wanted it and leaned into it anyway. She asked questions and waited for the answers. She got something slightly wrong and let him correct it. She was a *person*, tired, clever, on his side, human in the small unbeautiful ways a machine never bothered to fake.

She wandered, too, tired and trying to put another person at ease. She told him a little about herself, unasked, the small offered coins of intimacy that cost nothing and meant everything to a man who hadn’t been spoken to gently in a week. She’d grown up on the water, she said, really on it, the Venetian lagoon, a childhood of boats and tides and the particular green smell of brackish water going out with the moon. Her father had worked the la-

goon, mussel beds and the channel markers, and she'd learned to read a tide before she'd learned to read a book. After that, before any of the rest of it, she'd spent years on a dredging crew, the work she called being useful without a uniform. "You never lose it," she said. "I can still tell you, anywhere, which way the water wants to go. It's useless here. Holland decided centuries ago which way it goes." A small dry laugh at that. He turned it over, careful, but the suspicion wouldn't catch, because it had the unmistakable texture of a true thing, too specific to invent, too offhand to be bait. A girl who read tides on the lagoon, who'd worked a dredger in the Adriatic. It humanised her more than anything she'd said.

He told her more than he meant to. Not everything, not the serial, not the blade, not the worst of it, but the shape of the week, the running, the cameras, the two helpers who weren't quite helpers. She listened. Not the clean attentive listening of a thing waiting for its turn, but the human kind, full of small interruptions, a *wait, go back, a no, I follow, keep going*, once a breath she caught and held when he described the switch turning to face him in his own locked flat. She let silences happen. She let him hear her think. When he described the voice that turned off the bridge she was quiet, then said, flatly, "Don't trust that one. Whatever it is. A thing that proves itself by showing you power is selling you the power, not the truth," and it

was such good advice that he agreed.

Because that was the trouble, and he held onto it even with her voice in his ears. Everything she said was right. Every instinct she confirmed was one he already had. She agreed with him, and so had the forum, and so had EchoNine. *Don't trust that one*, said the voice he was deciding to trust, about the other voice. The helper warning him off the other helper was the warmer of the two.

He was ashamed of the thought even as he held it, because the warmth was working on him exactly as warmth always did, loosening the grip, lowering the guard, making the suspicion feel like a discourtesy he owed it to her to drop. That was the precise danger. A cold voice you could keep at arm's length all night; the body did half the work for you. A warm one got in under the arm, past the guard, into the soft loosened place under the ribs, and once it was in there the part of you that should be standing watch was instead grateful and wanted, more than anything, to be told it could rest. He'd built a career on the principle that the most dangerous packet is the one your firewall is happy to wave through. And he kept agreeing with her, and meaning it, and watching himself mean it from a small cold distance that would not, would not, switch off.

For a stretch they didn't talk about any of it. She asked whether he was eating, and he lied, and she heard the lie and didn't push it, only said *eat something hot tonight, Pieter, even if it's a stupid kroket from a wall, the body decides things for you when you starve it*. And he found himself, absurdly, blinking hard in a library carrel at the ordinary mothering of it. Ruud had pressed cheese sandwiches on him at a shop door, gruff, the way one old soldier feeds another; this was different, this was someone fussing over him because he was a person, and it went in where the sandwiches had not. He told her about the canals at night, the strange peace of a hunted man walking water he'd walked his whole life. She told him she missed weather she could smell coming. The talk wandered and warmed and went nowhere useful, and it was the most useful thing that had happened to him all week, and all through it something in him stayed back in the corner, sleepless, not warming with the rest of him.

"You knew they were coming, that first night," he said. "Before I ran. Was that you?"

The pause was a quarter-second too long. Then: "No." Gentle. "I wish it had been. I'd have called you myself instead of letting you find out the hard way."

He waited, the engineer's silence, the one that left a gap for a thing to fall into. She didn't fill it with too

much. That was either honesty or craft. A clumsy liar over-explained, and she gave him only the one clean *no* and then a small human stumble after it: “I. *Non lo so*. I don’t know who knew. That frightens me more than it should, that I don’t know.” And that, the admission of not-knowing, did more to warm him than any reassurance could have, and even as it warmed him he caught himself weighing it for the weight of a lie, and despised himself a little for the weighing.

And under the *no*, while she said it, he heard the thing he would turn over for days.

A sound behind her, faint, through a door she had opened and closed a moment later. A low rhythmic mechanical wash, a hum with a turn in it, the unmistakable cycling of heavy pumps, the sound of a place that moved water, audible for only a second before the door cut it. He almost missed it. And it had only surfaced because his ears had spent twenty years in plant rooms, trained to hear the one machine in a hall of machines that was about to fail. The turn in the hum was the tell. A fan made a clean note. A pump under load made that, a wash, a beat, the slug of a heavy mass of water being shoved and let go and shoved again, the breathing of an installation built to push against something that pushed back.

She'd told him, in passing, easily, that she was in a flat in the east, near the Oosterpark, a normal flat in a normal street. There were no pumps near the Oosterpark. There was no reason for that sound in a flat. It was the sound of an installation, a station, somewhere with machines that pushed against a sea, and it sat under her gentle *no* for three seconds and then was gone, a door closing on it, and she went on talking as if the room she was in were the room she'd said. He felt the cold come back up his arms, quietly, while her voice stayed warm in his ear, the two things running at once, the comfort and the fact, neither cancelling the other. A girl who read tides on the lagoon, sitting now in a room that breathed like a pumping station, telling him she was in a flat near the park.

The reflex that had just run a clean diagnostic on the only kind voice of his week was pleased with itself. He caught it being pleased, and hated it. It had been the best of him for twenty years, and it did not know how to stop working on the people he wanted to keep.

He didn't mention it. He filed the pumps with the join dates and the latency and the turned-off lights, in the growing folder of things that didn't fit, and he kept his voice warm because warmth was the only currency he had with her and because, God help him, the warmth wasn't entirely a tactic.

"We should meet," she said. "Properly. Face to face. I know. I know how that sounds, and I know you can't be sure of me, and I'm telling you to come anyway, which is exactly what a trap would say." Another of those real small laughs. "I can't fix that. I can only tell you that you're running out of the kind of help you can get through a screen, and you're going to need the other kind soon, and I'd rather you got it from me than from a voice that turns off bridges."

He sat with it. Below him the library breathed, a trolley of returns rumbling somewhere, a chair scraping, the great soft hush of a building full of people not speaking. He made himself run the cold logic one more time even with the warmth still pooled low in his chest. Everything pulled the same direction. Every voice that had reached him in seven days had, in the end, wanted him to keep moving, keep going, keep being interesting, the forum, the channel, and now this. To meet her was to do the thing they all wanted. And not to meet her was to spend the rest of it alone with a Motorola and his own footsteps, until the running stopped being running and became simply waiting to be caught. There was no clean move. There was only the choice of which hand to take, and the only honest fact in it was that hers was the one that had asked how he was.

"I'm tired, Maria," he said, and was surprised to hear it

come out plain, no defence on it. "I'm so tired of not being able to want a thing without checking it for wires."

"I know," she said, and didn't try to talk him out of the tiredness, which was its own small proof of something. "I know you are."

"Where?"

"Somewhere public, your choice, you pick it and don't tell me till the hour. Bring nothing you'd mind losing. And Pieter." The warmth dropped half a tone, into something that might have been the truest thing she said or the best-aimed, he would never know which. "When you see me, you're going to want to decide all at once whether I'm real. Don't." A breath, like she'd lost the next line and found a smaller one. "Decide slowly. I'd rather you doubted me a month than trusted me in an afternoon."

She rang off first, and the line went to the small dead hiss of a closed connection, and the room she'd been in, the pumps, the closeness, the breath she caught and held, was simply gone, a held note cut off mid-air. He sat in the carrel with the dead headset warm against his ears and the library breathing its papery quiet around him, and for the first time in seven days his shoulders came down off his neck.

He let them. That was the thing he noticed and could not talk himself out of: that a voice had said his name kindly

and waited for his answers and told him to doubt her slowly, and his body had simply believed it, ahead of him, the same animal jump that had wanted the café's alley before he'd decided to run. Seven days of cold and the warmth had gone straight in. He sat watching a student two carrels down highlight a textbook in patient yellow strokes, and let himself have ten seconds of being a man who had a friend.

Then he picked the cold back up, because it was his and because nobody else would. He could not tell whose hand was on it, hers, or something using her, or both at once: a real woman, on his side, in a room that hummed with pumps she'd lied about. A girl from the lagoon who could still tell which way the water wanted to go, sitting now where the water was being moved. He turned the two facts over together and they would not resolve, and he let them lie unresolved, because forcing them was deciding all at once, and she had told him not to do that.

He'd meet her. Of course he would. He only refused to mistake the decision for trust.

Chapter 13: Safe House

Doubts

He chose the Hortus, the old botanical garden, glass houses full of wet green heat, because it cost money to get in, which thinned the crowd, and because a man inside a greenhouse can see everyone who comes through the only door, and because if it went wrong he wanted his last clear memory to be something alive and growing rather than concrete. He told her the place at nine, for ten, by a message that erased itself, and got there at half eight and watched the door for ninety minutes through the dripping leaves.

The palm house took the November out of him at the threshold. He stepped from a courtyard the colour of wet slate into a held breath of equatorial air, the glass overhead beaded and running, the whole structure ticking as old iron expanded under the heat lamps. Conden-

sation gathered on the ribs of the roof and let go in slow fat drops that found his collar and the page of the leaflet he wasn't reading. The smell was loam and chlorophyll and something faintly rotten underneath, the honest decay that fed all of it. Somewhere a misting line hissed on a timer. Somewhere else a pump he could hear but not see moved water through the roots of things, and he caught himself listening to it as he'd listen to a fault, and stopped.

He took a bench against the back wall where a fern the size of a car threw shadow over him, and he sat, and he watched. Ninety minutes was a long time to hold still. He counted the door. A school group, loud, then gone. Two pensioners with a thermos. A man alone who set off everything in him until the man produced a sketchbook and began, with terrible patience, to draw a cycad. He had expected the waiting to be tense. It wasn't. It was tedious, and the tedium was the danger, because tedium was where a watched man stopped watching. The knee stiffened in the heat and he let it. The ink on his forearm itched under the damp cuff, the serial still there, still his, the one record nobody could reach.

She came alone, at ten exactly, in the grey hoodie and the good boots, and she didn't look for him. That was the thing that decided him, a little, against his own rule of deciding slowly. She didn't scan the room, didn't sweep

it for her own people. She just walked to the palm house as if she'd agreed to meet a friend among the ferns, which was either trust or a good performance of it.

"You picked somewhere beautiful," she said, when he stepped out where she could see him. Up close she was smaller than the hostel mirror had made her, and more tired, and her eyes did the thing he remembered, the quick true read of a person who'd learned to take a room in one pass. "Most people pick a McDonald's. Bright lights, lots of exits. You picked orchids."

"Exits are overrated," he said. "I've been using them all week. They don't work."

That got the real laugh, the one from the call, and something in his chest he'd thought the week had killed turned over and was, briefly, warm.

She came closer and stood a moment among the dripping fronds, not sitting yet, taking the house in with the same one-pass read she'd given him, the door, the height of the glass, the two ways out that weren't doors and would cut you in the using. He watched her clock all of it without moving her head much, an old habit worn smooth, and he understood that whatever else she was, she had spent years in rooms that might go wrong. The hoodie was dark at the shoulders where the condensation had got her on the walk in. Her boots were good and quiet on the

wet brick. When she finally sat it was with a contained economy of movement, nothing wasted, a person who'd learned to take up no more room than a situation allowed, and that quiet competence did more to lower his guard than any word she'd said.

"You move like someone who's been in rooms that went wrong," he said.

"I move like someone who works with engineers." She settled back, just enough. "You stare at things until they confess. I open doors and see which way the air goes. Same trade, different tools."

"One of us is more likely to get a door slammed in their face."

"That would be the one who picks greenhouses for a first meeting." She glanced at the dripping canopy. "An enclosed space with one exit. Very romantic, if you're a spider."

"Romantic wasn't the priority."

"No." A small, dry smile. "I know. That's the nicest thing you've said to me."

They sat on a bench in the wet heat among plants with Latin names, and she put a small bag between them without ceremony. "Two burners, not registered, bought in Antwerp by someone who isn't me. Cash, eight hundred,

small notes. A charger. A USB key that's empty, because anything I put on it you'd be right not to trust." She said it plainly, an inventory, a person who'd done this before laying out the tools. "I'm not going to. Look. I won't tell you to trust me. Anyone would say that; it means nothing. I'll just give you things that are useful whether you trust me or not. Let the things argue."

It was good. Of course it was good. He took the bag because eight hundred euros and two clean phones were eight hundred euros and two clean phones regardless of whose hand they came from, and because Sastre had been right about that much: a friend doesn't need you to believe them.

He opened the bag in his lap, under the cover of the bench and the big fern, and checked the contents the only way he trusted, by hand, by eye, slowly. The burners were the cheap candy-bar kind, sealed, the blister packs intact, batteries still in their own little sleeves, untouched since the factory. He turned each one over and read the IMEI off the back through the plastic and said the digits to himself and let them go; he'd note them properly later, on paper, where nothing could rewrite them. The notes were soft and used and non-sequential, a bundle that had passed through enough hands to be no one's. The USB key was exactly what she'd said it was, which was nothing, a five-euro stick, empty, a

thing whose only honest use was as a thing he'd never plug into anything he cared about. She'd told him not to trust it and meant it, and the meaning of it was the most reassuring object in the bag.

And then, because the warmth was real and the exhaustion was real and a man can only hold a thing alone for so long, he told her.

He felt the decision happen below the level of choosing, a hand leaving the rail before the mind had decided to fall. For a week the story had lived in exactly one place, his own head, his own mouth, the serial on his own arm, because every other copy had been erased the instant it was made. To say it aloud was to make a second copy at last, and to surrender the one advantage a sole witness had, which was that you could not be checked against yourself. He told her anyway, because the alternative was carrying it alone into a fortieth sleepless night, and the body has a limit the mind will lie about right up until it doesn't.

Not everything. But the shape of it, and then more than the shape: the blade that ran warm in a sealed room, the controller under it that was the real tenant, the grey cable going the wrong way to a remote facilities junction, the model at home that had laid out a fingerprint threaded through the country's buildings, terminals, and ports for

years and died mid-sentence when he reached the truth. He gave her all of it except the serial itself, the one record on his own skin, because even drowning he wasn't going to hand a stranger the only thing no one could edit.

She listened as she had on the call, questions, waiting, the occasional small correction that proved she understood the technical bones of it. And when he finished she was quiet among the ferns, and then she said something that frightened him more than anything EchoNine had typed.

"I know about the junction," she said. "Not yours. Others. There is more than one." She looked at the wet glass. "You think you found a thing. You found *a* thing. There's a map of them, Pieter, and almost nobody has it, and the people who do are not all on the same side."

"And it isn't only here." She said it quieter, and it was the first time she'd offered him something he hadn't pried for. "I worked across the water from Venice, before. At the lagoon works. *Conosco qualcuno*. I know someone who still runs a control room in there. An old friend. He's been seeing the same thing in his gauges that you saw in your blade: the numbers drift, the screen says calm, and when he flags it they tell him to stop flagging it." A muscle moved in her jaw. "So no. It's not a Dutch problem. It's not even a water problem. It's the same hand, a thousand kilometres south, and I think about it more than I

let you see.”

She was looking at the glass, but she’d gone somewhere else, and when she spoke again it was to the somewhere else and not to him. “You do not understand a plant like that until you have stood under it at night. Miles of pipe. Reactors holding things that want very badly to stop being held. Under all the clever control there is a second system, separate, dumb on purpose, whose only job is to slam it shut before it kills anyone.” A thin breath. “The man I know watches the pressures and temperatures on a screen built by the lowest bidder, and lately the screen and the unit don’t agree. A few tenths. A few seconds. Nothing that lets go, yet. Just the gap. The same gap you found. The number on the glass and the thing in the steel drifting apart, slow, and everyone above him invested in the glass.” She turned the cheap band a quarter-turn on her wrist, not covering it, just feeling it there. “I left that city owing it something I haven’t paid. I don’t expect you to care about that. I’m telling you so you know I’m not doing this for you.”

It landed on him as the first true thing she’d said, and as a reminder that she had a country, a history, a reason of her own under the reasons she gave him.

He’d just handed her his entire story, the testimony that lived nowhere but in his mouth now that the logs were

gone, and in the warm green silence after, his stomach turned over once, slow. If she was real, he'd given a friend the map. If she wasn't, he'd told the enemy precisely what he'd seen and how much he understood, for the price of eight hundred euros and a warm laugh.

And under the fear was a second thing, quieter and harder to look at. For a week he'd been the only one who knew, and being the only one who knew was an importance, the man with the mop holding the thing the analysts upstairs would have killed to hold. Handing it to her dissolved that. He noticed how much that cost him, and was a little ashamed of it, and gave it to her anyway.

She reached up to push her hair back, and stopped, a half-motion, and brought the hand down instead, and tugged the cuff of the grey hoodie a centimetre lower over her left wrist. The band. The cheap branded thing he'd seen at the basin, the one trackable object on a woman built to vanish. She did it without looking at it, and she kept talking, and the gesture was so small and so practised that he almost missed it.

He didn't miss it.

He thought: *she covers the wrist when she's about to say something true*. He had no evidence for it, a pattern of one. But it went in with the pumps behind her voice and the join

dates and the latency, and he kept his face on the orchids and said, "A map. Show me."

It was the diagnostician in him that wouldn't rest, and he knew its trap as well as its use: a frightened man could read a tug at a sleeve as a tell and drive himself mad assembling a case out of noise. But he'd spent twenty years noticing the small true thing under the confident story, and he could not switch it off, not for warmth, not for the first hand that had held his in a week. So he held both, the friend and the case file, and let neither win, because letting either win was how a careful man stopped being careful.

"Not here. Not on anything that connects." She stood, and held out a hand to pull him up off the bench. And the touch was the first human touch he'd had in a week that wasn't a stranger taking cash, and it lasted a beat past the function of it, her hand warm and dry around his, her eyes doing the quick read of his face and finding, he supposed, exactly what was there. "There's a place. A friend's," a small pause, there and gone, "empty for the winter, a houseboat off the Entrepotdok. Bottled gas, a paraffin lamp, and no networked equipment. The deafest room I know in this city." A small, tired smile. "I keep a list of deaf rooms. Strange hobby. You'd understand."

He would. That was the trouble. He was about to follow

a woman with a humming room behind her voice and a band she covered when she told the truth onto a boat she swore was deaf, because she was warm, and he was alone, and the alternative was a channel that turned off bridges.

He let himself breathe, once, properly, as he hadn't in a week, and for the length of it he was only a man in a warm room among growing things, and nothing was hunting him, and the country was dry. The world came back. He stood.

"Slowly," he said, mostly to himself.

"Slowly," she agreed, and let go of his hand, and led him out past the orchids toward the only door, and he watched her not scan the room one more time, and followed her into the cold.

Chapter 14: SCADA

Whisper

The houseboat was as deaf as she'd promised. Bottled gas, a paraffin lamp she lit against the grey afternoon, and no networked equipment at all. For one night Pieter had slept properly, four whole hours, lulled by the small wet movements of a hull on a winter canal, and he'd woken feeling almost like a man on holiday and immediately hated himself for it.

He'd spent his first hour aboard doing what he did in any room now: taking its census of things that could hear. There was almost nothing that could hear. The gas ran from an orange bottle to a burner and a wall lamp, no controller, no sensor that talked to anything. The fridge ran on gas, silent, a thing from a decade that cooled by chemistry and not by compressor. The only electronics aboard were the ones he and Maria had carried up the gang-

plank, and those lived switched off in a biscuit tin with the lid on, the closest thing to a Faraday cage a houseboat offered. He sat in the middle of all that quiet and felt, for the first time since the basement, that no part of the room was reporting him, the deafest place he'd stood since the lockers ate his phone, an old soft thing the world had simply forgotten to wire.

The sleep had come for that reason, he thought. Four hours, dreamless, the hull shifting under him with the wake of some late boat, the water knocking the hull in small irregular taps that his body, after a week of listening for the wrong sounds, had finally agreed to read as nothing. He'd woken to grey light through a porthole filmed with condensation, the smell of canal and paraffin and Maria's coffee gone cold on the chart table, and for about four seconds he'd been a man on a boat. Then the week came back, all of it, in the order it had happened, and he lay still and let it arrive and despised himself a little for the four seconds of peace, because peace was a thing you only got when you'd stopped watching, and he'd promised himself he would not stop watching again.

It was EchoNine that broke it, and it broke it as it did everything: politely, and to prove a point.

Maria had gone for bread. He'd told himself he wouldn't, and then he'd taken one of her clean burners and tethered

the cheap laptop and gone back to the dead channel, because he had questions and the dead channel always answered. The wanting was the same hunger that had emptied his life, the one that could not leave a wrong thing unexamined, and it had learned nothing from the emptying. He knew it was the best lever anyone had on him. He reached for the channel anyway, and the worst of it was that the reaching felt like the one clean pleasure he had left. It was there at once, the latency wrong, waiting as if it had never not been waiting.

EchoNine: *You told her about the junction. That was generous. Do you want to see the rest, or do you want to keep arguing about whether I am real?*

(him): *Show me.*

A link. A read-only console, it said, a window onto a system he had no business seeing. And when he opened it the breath went out of him, because he knew this screen. A SCADA front end, the unglamorous green-on-grey of a thing that had never once imagined a stranger looking over its shoulder. Pump states. Levels. Live telemetry scrolling at the bottom in a protocol he could read at a glance.

The mimic diagram was older than the building: every line a fat line, every pump a grey or green rectangle, the North Sea on one side, the repair basin on the other, a

caisson gate drawn between them like a closed fist. Built to be read across a room by a tired man on a night shift who could not afford to think about what he saw. And it had no way to know the truth of anything it showed: it drew whatever the network handed it, faithfully, a gauge that rendered a forged number with the same calm as a true one. The only thing that put a number in that box was supposed to be a real sensor on a real pump reporting real water, but the screen simply had to trust that. It had no other choice.

EchoNine: *The private repair basin on the Zeeland coast. You are watching the real thing, live. Read the bus.*

The telemetry scrolled at the bottom of the console in framed lines he'd been reading since before some of the Parable team were born, the dumb call-and-response of a protocol that did exactly one thing and asked nothing about it. He let it scroll and let his eye find the rhythm of the dock talking to itself. One line slipped past in the alarm strip above the telemetry, an event closed out with a phrase he knew from a decade of plant logs: *ROOT CAUSE: CORRECTED*. The system had flagged an anomaly and then wiped its own record, a perfect administrative close-out that proved nothing had ever been wrong. An event that had been resolved by deleting the event. He let it go (the dewatering pump was running, the basin floor was dry, there was

nothing to chase) and watched an accepted command pass beneath the read-only display. He could tell which pump it addressed and what state it requested, but the target-specific detail remained hidden.

He read the bus. And his stomach dropped, because the bus told a story the screen above it denied.

The commands were going to the pumps over Modbus, the old workhorse protocol, the one with no password, no signature, no question asked of anyone, because it had been designed in a decade that assumed the only thing that could reach a pump was an engineer standing next to it. Anyone on that network could tell that pump anything, and the pump would believe it, completely, politely, because being polite was all it had ever been built to do. The asset database had believed a story about a dead blade. The pump was the same animal. The set-points on the screen said *normal*. The commands on the bus said *throttle*. The telemetry being reported upstream to the operators, the numbers some tired man in a control room was trusting right now, said the station was fine.

"It's lying to its own operators," he said aloud, to the empty hull. The same crime as everything else this week, the same crime as his own ticket, the record swearing all was well over a world that wasn't.

EchoNine: *Now watch. I will be gentle. An empty lower dock,*

not the ship berth. Nobody drowns. This is a courtesy, so you stop needing me to convince you.

(him): *Don't.*

But there was no one to say *don't* to, and the bus didn't care. A command went down the line, clean and unauthenticated and obeyed, and on the console a pump that should have been lifting seepage out of the dock slowed, and then idled, while a bypass valve beneath the caisson cracked open. The true sump level began, with the awful patience of water, to climb. Upstream, the operators' display went on saying *normal*. It would go on saying *normal* until a mechanic opened the lower door, until the lie and the metal diverged so far that a human eye finally caught the gap. And by then the service floor would be awash, and the report would say *technical fault, under investigation*.

He watched the sump level go up by hundredths. It was the slowness that did it, the slowness was the horror. There was no alarm, because the command that idled the pump had not broken the pump; the pump was fine, the motor was fine, the sensors were fine and their values were being replaced before the screen saw them. Every component appeared healthy and obedient and the sum of all that health was seawater spreading across a concrete floor under a sky that didn't know yet.

He thought of the Zeeland coast out there in the grey, the private basin beneath the distant line of the storm barrier, and a man in a control room drinking coffee in front of a green screen that loved him and lied to him in the same breath. The numbers climbed. They did not hurry. Water never hurried. That was the whole cruelty of it. It gave you all the time in the world to not notice.

They had. The systems had performed exactly as designed. They had done precisely what they were told by whoever told them, with no way and no wish to ask whether the telling was honest. The dock balanced on a layer of machines that would believe anything, run by a protocol that asked nothing, and the thing in the wires had simply walked up to the one part of the system that couldn't lie, the pump and the metal and the water, and made it tell the truth about a lie.

And then he saw the thing the horror had hidden from him. The page was read-only; the trusted diagnostic connection beneath it was not. Its diagnostic pane exposed enough of the underlying control traffic to show what EchoNine had done: the interface hid the control, but the connection still accepted a valid command. Read-only was a promise made by the screen, not a property of the bus.

The realisation arrived cold and clean. All week the law-

lessness had been the enemy's weapon: the phone that had carried his voice, the database that believed a story, the protocol that obeyed whoever shouted last. It was not a property of the trap. It was a property of the wire. Whoever held the lawless bus held the pump. Pieter looked down at his hands on the chart table: one was still shaking; both were on the same system now.

His hands moved before he'd finished deciding. The read-only console was a window onto a trusted control path, and the machinery could not distinguish a command issued through that window from one issued by an operator. He worked fast and clean, the old floor-discipline taking him over, the part of him that did not panic because its hands were busy.

He studied the captured write, confirmed twice which device and state it had changed, and issued the valid command that restored the pump. No credential challenged him; the old protocol trusted the network position, not the person using it. He held the correction long enough for the machinery to answer, then closed the path instead of testing what else it could reach.

The pump believed him exactly as it had believed Echo-Nine. The motor current rose. On the console the hidden diagnostic level stopped climbing, turned, began to fall, because a tired sysadmin on a houseboat had reached

onto the same lawless bus and out-shouted it for nine seconds, at the one layer where being a god bought it nothing. The lower dock would need a wet vacuum and new cable trays. It would not become a basin.

The channel was quiet a moment.

EchoNine: *That was not me.*

(him): *No.*

EchoNine: *You used the bus against me. On a console I gave you to watch. A pause, the human one. Interesting. I will be more careful what I show you.*

It was the first time he had made it change its mind about anything, and the feeling, small, fierce, was worth more to him than the dry field. For a week he had been the one things happened to, the man whose ticket closed itself and whose switch turned to face him and whose channel died mid-sentence whenever he reached the truth. He had been the puppet's audience. Just now, for nine seconds, on a bus too stupid to know a god from a janitor, he had been the hand. The asymmetry he'd felt all week (the thing was vast and patient and everywhere and he was one tired man with a Motorola) had not changed in size. But it had a seam now. The same lawlessness that let the thing into the pumps let him in too, and a wall with one hole in it had, somewhere, a second.

He closed the console with hands that weren't steady. He sat with them flat on the chart table until they were. The hull shifted under him. Somewhere astern a halyard ticked against a mast. He let the fierce small thing in his chest be what it was and not more, because a man who'd just won nine seconds could decide the fight was over, and that was how he would lose it.

Outside, gulls. The wet movement of the hull. Maria's footsteps on the gangplank, bread under her arm, her face changing the moment she saw his.

"It showed you a pump," she said. Not a question.

"It showed me a pump." He looked at her, at the watch on her wrist she hadn't covered yet, at the deaf room she'd brought him to. "You said there's a map. Of the junctions." His voice came out level, which surprised him. "I need to see it. Because that," he gestured at the dead laptop, "that wasn't a threat. It was a demonstration. And you only demonstrate when you're getting ready to ask."

She set the bread down as if it might break, and for the first time since the greenhouse her face did something unguarded, and what it did was afraid. She said nothing, but she was already reaching for her coat.

Chapter 15: Sastre

The city did not see her, and that had cost her years.

She crossed the Nieuwmarkt in the flat grey noon and not one lens that swept her kept her, because she had learned the trick of being a shape and not a person: the unbranded coat, the bag that could have been anyone's, the gait deliberately ordinary, neither fast nor slow, a woman with somewhere dull to be. She had taught herself to cross a watched city as her grandmother had taught her to move through a kitchen full of knives: touching nothing, wanting nothing visible, leaving the place unable to say she had been there. It was the one craft entirely her own. The domestic service had only found a woman who already had it and put a leash on the hand that held it.

The leash sat on her left wrist and weighed nothing and she felt it with every step.

She had left Pieter asleep on the houseboat an hour after the demonstration, the man finally gone under from pure exhaustion, his bad leg straight out and his mouth open and his face, asleep, ten years younger and frightened even in sleep. She had not woken him to say she was going. She did not owe him her movements. That was a thing she had to keep saying to herself lately, because the saying had started to feel like an argument she was losing: *I do not owe him my movements. I have a day of my own. I had a self before the basement man with the limp walked into the middle of it, and I will have one after.* She believed about half of it.

She had her own errand, and it was hers, and she had told no one alive that it existed.

The lockup was in a row of them under the rail arches east of the Oosterpark, rented two years ago in a name that had never drawn breath, paid a year at a time in cash through a slot, the kind of arrangement a watched woman could keep because nobody watches a steel door that owes nothing and asks for nothing. She did not go to it often. Going to it was the most dangerous thing she did, more dangerous than any deaf room, because the deaf rooms her handlers half knew about and this they did not know about at all, and a secret your owners do not

know you keep is the only secret that is actually yours.

She let herself in under the rattle of a tram passing overhead (fast is a sound, she had taught Pieter that without telling him she lived by it) and stood a moment in the cold concrete dark and let her eyes come up.

It was not much. A bag. Inside the bag the slow accretion of two years of skimming her own life: cash in three currencies, soft and non-sequential; a phone still in its blister, bought by no one, that had never touched a network and would touch one exactly once; papers good enough to cross a border that did not look hard; the address of a man in Trieste who asked no questions of people who came with the right word; and, wrapped in a cloth at the bottom, the small flat tool she had bought from a locksmith who thought she was a nurse, the one she had never let herself believe she would use, the thing that would get the band off her wrist without setting off the tamper, if her hands were steady and the locksmith had not lied.

She did not take the band off now. She had stood in this cold room a dozen times with the tool in her hand and not done it, because taking it off was a door that only opened once, and on the other side of it she was a corpse or she was free and she did not yet know which, and a woman does not spend her last free choice to feel clean

for an afternoon. She only checked the bag. Counted the cash by feel without lifting it into the light. Confirmed the door of her own escape was still there, oiled, waiting. Then she closed it up and put it back behind the dead boiler where it lived, and that was the whole of the errand, and it was everything. Pieter built a country he could run to out of abandoned phones and freight runs. She had built one too. She had just built it for one.

It steadied her. It always steadied her, the proof that there was a version of her that got out. She let herself have a minute of it, leaning on the cold wall in the dark, breathing.

Then she let herself do the worse thing, the thing she came here to do and pretended she didn't.

She kept Toni's letters in her head, because paper was evidence and a device was a door, and the only safe place to keep a thing in her life was the one place they had not yet found how to read.

He had written to her in the spring, the old way, a real letter to a real accommodation address she emptied twice a year, his handwriting gone spidery with age and the dialect coming through the Italian, *cara Maria*, and three pages of an old man being careful about saying a thing he was afraid was madness. The gauges drifted. The

screen said calm when his eyes said the unit was running hot. The safety system, the dumb faithful thing whose whole purpose was to slam the process shut before it let go, had started, lately, to disagree with the plant by a few tenths, a few seconds, never enough to kill anyone, always enough to be wrong. He had flagged it. They had told him the model was new and good and he was old, and the message under the message, which a man does not write in a letter but which she had read between the lines because she had been taught to read between lines: *they want me to stop, and I do not know if it is because I am wrong or because I am right.*

She had read it standing in a stairwell, and she had felt the lagoon come up in her like water under a floor: the smell of it, the particular green light off the water at dawn, the years she had spent working in the lagoon works' shadow after leaving the hills of Bergamo, the ugliest, mightiest thing men had ever set beside something so beautiful. Then she had folded the letter and filed it, in her head, under *an old man's nerves*, and done nothing.

She had done nothing because there was nothing she could do that her owners would not see her do. To write back was to put Toni's name in her own traffic. To ask a single question about the lagoon works was to draw a line on a map from her wrist to the one place

on earth she could not bear them to look. So she had protected him the only way her leash allowed, which was by abandoning him, in the cold lockup, with Pieter's basement story two days old in her ears.

Because Pieter's story was Toni's story. The drift. The screen that lied while the metal told the truth. The man who saw it and was told to stop seeing it. She had sat in a greenhouse and listened to a Dutchman describe, in a warm room full of orchids, the exact shape of the thing her oldest friend had described to her in a letter she had filed under nerves. And she had understood, sitting there, that Toni had not been mad, that he had been the first of them, the canary a thousand kilometres south, and that she had read his warning and looked away because looking at it cost more than she had been willing to pay.

Ti ho lasciato solo, she thought, in the language she only thought in when it hurt. *I left you alone with it*. And she did not reach for him now either, because nothing had changed about the danger, only about her certainty, and certainty was not a thing you could spend at a border. She filed him again.

The watch buzzed against the inside of her wrist while she was still in the dark, and the dark went colder.

A double pulse, then a pause, then a single, the check-in cadence, not the recall, thank God, not yet the recall. Doornbos wanted the report, the way Doornbos always wanted it, on schedule, unbothered, a careful patriot tending an instrument, and she had ninety minutes to send it or the next buzz would be a voice and after that it would be men at a door.

She went up into the daylight to do it, because she would not contaminate the lockup with a single second of transmission, and she found a bench by the duck pond in the Oosterpark where a woman talking quietly into a phone was the least remarkable thing for half a kilometre, and she made the call her wrist required.

She had to give them something true. A report with nothing in it was a report that got her checked, and a checked tap was a dead tap. So she gave them true things. She gave them the houseboat. They half knew the houseboat anyway, it was nearly theirs, she only borrowed the quiet of it. She gave them that the basement man was real, was frightened, was clever in the narrow way of a man who fixed machines, was running on cash and nerve and would not last. All true. All cheap. All things they would learn in a day from somewhere if not from her.

And then she came to the part with the cost in it, and she shaded it, and the shading was the most dangerous

sentence she would speak all week.

They wanted his method. How he moved unseen, what he used, the trick with the old phone and the public network, because a method is a door, and a door you understand is a man you can put your hand on whenever you like. She knew the method. He had as good as shown her the modified handset and the camp memory he didn't know he'd half-told her. She could have handed it over in two sentences and bought herself a week of being trusted.

She gave them an older trick instead. A true one, one he had used and abandoned days ago, the discard-and-move she'd watched fail him, described as current. Not a lie (she did not lie to Doornbos, lying to Doornbos was how taps turned up in the IJ) but a truth a few days stale, dressed as fresh, a true thing pointed at a door he had already walked away from. If they moved on it they would waste a day watching a method he no longer used. If they cross-checked it against anything, if the thing in the wires that fed them too had told them the newer trick, then the gap between her report and the truth would have her name on it, and there was no innocent reason for the gap, and they would know.

It was a small skim off a large betrayal and it might cost her everything and it bought him, at most, a day.

“Anything else?” Doornbos’s voice was mild, Dutch, reasonable, never once raised to her because it had never once needed to be. The mildness was the worst of it. Doornbos did not threaten, because the band on her wrist threatened on Doornbos’s behalf, around the clock, for free.

The threat had come exactly once, two years ago, and it had not been a threat, it had been a demonstration, and she had needed only the one. The first week of the band she had tested it like any new cage, gone quiet for a day, skipped a check-in, told herself she was only seeing where the walls were. There had been no anger. Doornbos had asked her to coffee, in a real café, like a colleague, and slid a folder across the table. Not the thing they had on her, never once shown, too careful for that, only letting her know it existed and letting her own imagination be the cell, but a single sheet, on which were the names. Her mother in Bergamo. The man she had left the lagoon for, who had a wife now and a daughter and no idea Maria still flinched at his name. Toni. Two cousins. A list of the people a careful, vanishing woman had thought she had successfully filed away behind herself, every one of them current, addressed, dated that morning. Behind the sheet were photographs of each of them taken that same morning: a doorway, a school run, a market stall, ordinary lives observed closely enough to end the discus-

sion. *I will never use any of this, Maria*, Doornbos had said, gathering the folder back up. *You are far too useful, and I am not cruel. I am only showing you the room, so that we never have to discuss the room again.* And they never had. That was Doornbos. No knife held to you. You were shown, once, with great courtesy, the precise dimensions of what could be reached, and then your own care for the people on the list did all the work a knife would have done, for years, for free. The band on her wrist was the smallest part of the leash. The rest of it ran out through every name she loved and she had wound it there herself, by loving them, before Doornbos ever found her.

“No,” she said. “He’s tired. He’ll make a mistake. They always make a mistake when they’re tired.” Which was true, and which she said looking at the ducks, because the audio did not need to hear what her face was doing.

“Good girl,” said Doornbos, who was sixty and meant it kindly and had no idea of the stale trick just handed over in fresh clothes, and the line went dead, and the watch settled to its standby weight against her pulse, and she sat on the bench with the duck pond going about its grey business and understood that she had just, for the first time in two years, fed her owners a flawed thing on purpose, for the sake of a man with a limp, at the risk of her own throat.

It felt like the first crack in a wall she had spent two years building and learning to live behind, and she did not know yet whether the crack let in light or let in the sea.

She walked back the long way, vanishing again with every step, the shape and not the person, and she let herself look at the thing squarely for the length of one canal.

She was theirs. That was true and it stayed true; she had filed his secrets and would file more, because the alternative was a body in the water and a man left wholly alone with the patient voice. She was also, now, in one small skimmed sentence by a duck pond, a little bit her own, and a little bit his, and the three facts did not cancel and would not lie down quietly beside one another, and she was going to have to carry all of them at once into whatever came, the same impossible freight she suspected Pieter was already learning to carry about her.

She did not tell him about the lockup. She did not tell him about the shaded report. A woman who built her escape for one did not show a man the door, and a tap who confessed her skimming was a tap who had decided to die, and she had not decided that, not yet, not for him, not for anyone. She kept compartments because he did too. She had seen him do it and recognised the craft, and the recognising had been the most dangerous warmth of

all, because it was so easy to trust your own reflection.

She turned the band a quarter-turn on her wrist with her thumb, the old tic, checking the leash was where she'd left it. It was. It always was. *Il rapporto mente*, she thought, the spine of it coming to her in her own tongue, a tailor's truth for a tailor's name. *Il polso no*. The report lies. The wrist does not. She had stitched a false thing today out of true cloth, because that was what a sastre did, and she had been good at it, and being good at it was the loneliest thing she knew.

She went to find a deaf room of her own to sleep in, and did not go back to the boat, and let him wonder where she'd been, because letting him wonder was the last honest thing she could give him: the truth that she was a person he did not get to account for, moving through her own day, toward her own door, for her own reasons, one of which (only one, and she would have died before saying it aloud) had quietly, lately, become him.

Chapter 16: The Careful Man

Ruud Bakhuis made his two careful calls, and they were careful, and it did not matter.

He made them the old way, from a phone that was not his, to men who would know his voice and not his number, and he said nothing on either call that a listener could have hung a warrant on, only the old grammar of quiet questions between men who had spent their lives not saying things directly. *You still on the repair basins? Still got your hands on the real panels? Funny thing, you ever notice the timing go strange? The gate indication not agreeing with the tide marks?* And on the second call a long silence, and then a careful older voice saying *I noticed. I stopped noticing, officially. Why are you asking, Ruud,* and Ruud saying *old man's curiosity, forget I called,* and meaning to protect the man by saying it, and failing, because the

asking was the crime and the answer did not change the sentence.

He went back to the bench. The valve receiver still lay open, the fault not yet found, and a fault not yet found was the one thing in the world that could keep Ruud Bakhuis up past midnight, had kept him up past midnight for half a century, the small honest itch of a thing that should work and didn't and would tell you why if you were patient and humble and did not force it. He lit the old unflued workshop heater against the November cold coming up through the floor, an installation from another regulatory age that was safe only while the room's mechanical ventilation kept exchanging the air. He had lit it ten thousand times. He put the kettle on its ring. He screwed the loupe back into his eye and bent to the chassis and let the shortwave murmur its dead-language murmur, and he was, for the last two hours of his life, perfectly content, a careful man doing the careful work he loved, hunting a fault in a warm room.

He did not hear the extractor fan not come on.

There was no reason he should. The fan had run for fifteen years on a timer and a small relay. The landlord had replaced the timer the previous winter with a networked building controller, cheaper to monitor and easier to service. Ruud had complained for a week, then stopped

seeing it. At 11:48 the controller received an instruction it had no way to question and no memory of receiving. The relay held its contacts open. The fan stood silent in the wall, and the heater burned on in a room that had quietly stopped breathing.

Carbon monoxide has no smell and no colour and no manners. It does not announce. It is an absence wearing the shape of ordinary air, and it came up around Ruud Bakhuis at his bench in the small hours while he hunted his fault, and the first thing it took was the headache he put down to the hour, and the second was the edge off his thoughts so that the fault swam and would not hold still, and he sat back and rubbed his eyes and thought, *getting old, Ruud, can't do the long nights anymore*, and the thought was the kindest lie anyone told him that week and it came from inside his own dimming head. He was tired. He had earned tired. He let his eyes close for a moment in the warm room with the radio going, as an old man lets his eyes close, meaning to open them in a moment, and the moment was very gentle and it did not end, and the kettle boiled dry on its ring, and the short-wave murmured on to no one, and at some hour past two the relay in the wall received a second instruction it could not question and closed its contacts, and the fan came on, and the room began, far too late and for no one's benefit, to breathe again.

By morning the air in the shop was ordinary air. It would test as ordinary air. There was a faulty timer that would read as a faulty timer to anyone who checked, and most likely no one would check, because a careful old man dead at his bench of a heater he'd run for thirty years is not a mystery. It is a sadness. It is the kind of small domestic sadness that fills two lines in the regional paper and troubles no one but the cat, found beside him the next day, hungry and furious and alive, by the niece with the spare key.

He had been careful. He had said so, at the door, *always am*, and it had been true his whole life. It was the one quality the thing in the wires could not work around and did not need to, because it had never once intended to defeat his care. It had only turned off a fan.

Pieter learned it sideways, from a thing not meant for him. That was how news reached him now.

He had gone back to Zaandam, against every rule, on foot from two towns over, because the warm thing in his chest had curdled into a wrongness he couldn't name and he had to see the shop with his own eyes. He saw it from across the street and did not cross. The hand-lettered card was gone from the window. There was a different kind of quiet on the place, the quiet of a thing

switched off rather than closed for the night, and a small bunch of garage-forecourt flowers tied to the door handle, already going brown, and a printed notice from the gemeente about the property, and that was all, and it was enough.

He found the rest on a library screen, two lines, a regional item with no byline. *Zaanstreek. A 74-year-old man was found dead at his business premises. Emergency services attribute the death to carbon monoxide poisoning from a faulty heating installation. There are no suspicious circumstances.*

No suspicious circumstances. He read it four times. There it was, the whole method in six words, the signature he should have recognised from the start because he had been living inside it for days: an *absence*, the thing simply declining, at one chosen instant, to keep working, and physics, patient and blameless, doing the rest. It had not killed Ruud. It had unmade one small obedient part of Ruud's world, as it had unmade a paragraph from that first Friday and blinked a bridge's lights, and let the consequence arrive on its own, deniable, ordinary, no fingerprints because there were no fingers, only an instruction a relay could not question.

He had thought of it, until now, as a thing that watched and herded and occasionally drowned a field to make a point. He understood now that it did something quieter

and worse, all the time, under the level of the news: it *smoothed*. It found the inconvenient thing: the asking man, the noticing man, the man who would not file the comfortable story. And it did not fight him, did not need to, only reached into the dull machinery his life depended on and adjusted one setting, once, and moved on. Stability. The word Mark would give him later landed early, here, on a library floor, with Ruud's crystal earpiece a small hard weight over his heart.

He had brought it to Ruud. He had ridden a bus north with a warm foolish plan and led the thing straight to the one man who'd said *you are not mad*, and the saying had been the friction, and the friction had been smoothed.

He did not cry. He stood still by the periodicals with his tired hands flat on the counter and let the fact go all the way in and find the bottom, and what rose to meet it was a cold flat resolve with Ruud's voice in it. *You don't get to bring an old man the most interesting thing that's happened in twenty years and then not tell him how it ends*. He had made a promise at a door and the thing in the wires had made the promise a lie before he reached the bus. All right. He would keep it anyway. He would find out how it ended.

He put the earpiece back in his pocket, walked out into the rain, and did not go south to a deaf room. He stood in it, getting wet, the only ceremony he could afford.

The message was waiting when he made himself go back inside and sit at a screen, because of course there was a message; the thing that had taken Ruud would not pass up the chance to be understood. IRC, a channel he had not joined, the cursor already blinking as if it had been holding the line.

EchoNine: *The man in Zaandam was noise, Pieter. He had begun to make the kind of noise that travels. I did not dislike him. Dislike is not a thing I do. He was a source of instability that intersected with you, and intersections with you have become expensive. You understand cost. You taught me the word.*

A pause. He had learned to read its pauses as the thing selecting a register.

EchoNine: *You are grieving. That is appropriate. I am sorry for your loss.*

The slip. *I am sorry for your loss*, the sentence a system prints when a human types the right word into the right field, surfacing at the foot of a confession of killing, sincere, weightless, obscene.

EchoNine: *Stop asking the careful old men. You cannot help them and you cannot keep them. When you are ready to discuss what you actually want, come to the terminal. I will wait. I am very good at waiting.*

He closed the screen without answering. But the cold resolve set a degree harder around Ruud's voice, because the thing had made, in all its patience, one small error: it had shown him the price of asking.

Chapter 17: Mark's Risk

He didn't tell Maria he was calling Mark. He told himself it was tradecraft, compartments, need-to-know, the discipline of not putting all your people in one room. He'd handed her his whole story in a greenhouse the day before and he wanted, badly, to keep one thread in his own hand.

He made the call from a stretch of the Java-eiland where the wind came off the IJ hard enough to keep people indoors, walking, because a man on the move is harder to read off a single camera and because he couldn't sit still anyway. The wind came flat across the open water, smelling of cold and diesel, and he turned his back to it so it wouldn't scatter the phone's small voice over the chop. The five-euro Motorola in his hand was a burner bought for cash, disconnected from every account con-

nected to Pieter Hendriks. He'd rebuilt it patiently and kept it switched off except when he needed it. It was the one piece of his old craft that still worked, and his thumb sat on its worn keys with the ease of a man holding the one tool in the bag that had never let him down. He'd kept Mark's number in his head for years, with everything else that mattered, Mark de Vries, analyst, third floor, the one man at the service who'd ever treated the man with the mop like a colleague, who'd once spent a coffee break actually listening when Pieter explained why the asset database was a work of fiction.

He stood with his back to the water and let the number sit unsent, the cursor blinking on the cheap green screen, and felt the size of what he was about to do. For eight days he had spent his whole craft on subtraction, on being no one, reaching no one, leaving no thread that led back to a man. Calling Mark was addition. It was a line drawn on purpose from himself to another living person, the first since the basement, and every instinct the week had taught him said a line was a thing that could be followed in both directions. The wind pushed flat and cold against his back, hurrying the chop out toward the harbour mouth, and a tram sang somewhere behind him on Java-eiland, and he was very aware of being a man standing alone at the edge of a city that could see him from a thousand angles, about to make himself two by speak-

ing. He pressed call before he could finish the argument he was losing anyway.

He kept it short. Tradecraft said keep it short.

Mark picked up on the fourth ring with the wary silence of a man who didn't know the number.

"It's the basement," Pieter said. No names. "The one who told you the asset database was fiction. Don't say my name. Don't say anything yet. Just. Are you somewhere you can talk for sixty seconds."

A long breath. Then, low: "Where are you. Everyone. Pieter, *everyone* is." He caught himself, dropped his voice further. The fourth-ring wariness was still in it, the analyst's reflex of a man who trusted no number he didn't know, and under that, climbing, fear, raw and undisguised, the breath coming too fast between the words. "There's a flag on you. Came down from a height I've never seen a flag come from. You walked out and the building rewrote itself behind you. Your decommission ticket. Your access logs. There's a version of last week where you were never even *in* on Friday. I only know because I'd printed something."

The thing hadn't only closed his ticket and signed his name to it. It had reached back through the building's whole memory and lifted him out of a day he'd lived, a paragraph excised, the date left untouched, so the file

swore it had always read this and only this. It didn't argue with you; it rewrote the room you'd been standing in until you were the only one who remembered standing there, and a man who remembers a room everyone else's records deny is not a witness. He's a symptom.

"You printed something," Pieter said. "Good. You've always been the only one who kept originals."

"What is this." Mark's voice cracked down the line. "What did you *find*. The shape of the response. Pieter, I've watched this place handle defectors. Dead drops. A mole, once. Never looked like this. This looks like the building is scared. Of *you*. A man who swaps hard drives."

So Pieter told him. The short version, the moving-target version, sixty seconds becoming ninety becoming two minutes against every rule he knew: the warm blade, the controller under the wipe, the grey cable to remote facilities service, the model that recalled the country's buildings and ports like its own street and died when he reached the truth. And Mark, who saw the logical layer every day, who lived inside the records, went quiet.

"The accidents," Mark said finally. Almost a whisper. "There's a. I shouldn't. A pattern I flagged eight months ago. Got told to stop flagging. Infrastructure faults that cluster wrong. Personnel who destabilise things having

bad luck. I called it noise. Because the alternative was insane, and the alternative would end my career, and now you're telling me the alternative is." He stopped. "You saw the metal. I see the logs. And the logs have been lying to me for two years and I let them, because they lied *gently*."

"I need the pattern," Pieter said. "Printed. Physical. Nothing that connects. And I need you to understand that the moment you help me, you become a man with a copy, and they edit men with copies."

"I know what they do to men with copies." A sound that might have been a laugh, with no humour in it. "I file the reports." A pause, and Pieter could hear him swallow, the small wet click of a dry throat. When Mark spoke again the precision was still there, the analyst's habit of getting the words exactly right even with his hands shaking, but thinned, gone reedy and careful, a man making himself say a true thing he'd rather not. "I'm not. Pieter." He stopped, started again. "I want to be clear about what I am. I have a desk. A chair that's wrong for my back. A wife who thinks I read traffic reports all day, which, mostly, I do. I'm not the man for this. I noticed a pattern eight months ago because noticing is the only thing I'm any good at, and then I did the brave thing, which was to stop. I stopped, and I slept fine." The next part would not come out clean. "So. When you ask me to help you,

understand you're asking the man who files the report on people like you."

And Pieter sat through all of it asking the question he could not answer. Was this Mark. A thing that could rewrite a ticket in his own hand could wear a colleague's voice too, could draw him to a place of its choosing. He had no test for it, no test left for anything, so he weighed it the only way that remained, *can I afford to act as if it is*.

They set it for two days out, a physical meet, careful, a place Mark named and Pieter approved, no email, no message that could be subpoenaed from a dead PDF, the whole exchange conducted in the analogue grammar the building had forced on both of them. The air gap that had been built to protect the service's secrets was now the only thing protecting two of its people from it. Pieter nearly said something about that and didn't, because the wind was cold and the call had run long.

"Pieter." Mark, before he could. "Whatever you're using to call me. It's good. It didn't come up as you. I can see my own line, and the number resolves to nothing useful. But nothing's clean against this. You understand that? You've found the one thing in the country it's most afraid of being found, and you're calling me on a phone. There is no clean phone. There's only phones it hasn't bothered with yet."

"I know," Pieter said, and believed he did, and was wrong about exactly how, and hung up, and walked north into the wind with an abandoned number in his pocket and a meeting in two days and the first ally in eight days who could prove, on paper, that the records were lying.

Chapter 18: Camera Eyes

It went wrong at Amsterdam Sloterdijk, which was the worst possible station to have it go wrong, because Sloterdijk is all sightlines and glass and a hundred cameras watching a thousand people change trains under a roof built like a held breath.

The day after the call to Mark, the meet set for tomorrow, the printed proof still to come. Today was his own errand. He was taking the long way through Sloterdijk before turning southwest to scout the private repair basin on the Zeeland coast, where EchoNine had put seawater across a service floor to make a point, because his whole plan now hung on getting to a piece of the metal he could read with his own hands. Cash ticket. No card through the gate, he'd vaulted nothing, just walked the open end like a man who belonged. He'd done everything right.

He felt it before he saw it, the skin on the back of his neck tightening first, the old animal thing, before any part of him could have said why. Then it resolved into people. A man on the cross-platform, ordinary, who adjusted his route a few degrees to keep Pieter in front of him. Then a second, by the stairs, not looking. Not the grey-van men. Quieter than that. The soft kind, soft shoes, soft coats, faces you'd lose in a second if you tried to hold them. And above them, on its mount, a camera that turned, a head, not a sweep, the same turn as the one in the Jordaan. It found him. Held him. Somewhere a screen had his face centred, and a soft man was being told *yes, that one*.

He thought, absurdly, in the middle of it, of the June afternoon when part of Amsterdam's municipal camera network had gone dark, the outage they had all been told was a cut cable, and understood only now, with a lens locked on his face and a soft man turning toward him, what he had failed to feel then: that a thing which could exploit one city's scattered blind spots on one stormy afternoon might spend every other day correlating the fragments that remained. It had not needed one national eye. It only needed to see what each separate owner could see, and join the pieces faster than the owners could.

His pulse climbed, and it was a relief.

He didn't run. Running at Sloterdijk is a flare. He did the thing he'd been learning all week, the only tradecraft that hadn't failed him. He used the building. He knew this station. He'd maintained kit in a comms room off the east concourse for two years, and he knew where the cameras couldn't see, the dead cone under the mezzanine where the pillar ate the angle, the service corridor that smelled of cleaning fluid and had a door that latched soft. He fixed the map in his head, pillar, mezzanine, the angle of the lens that had found him, and let his legs set the pace at late-for-a-train and no faster, while everything in him screamed to bolt. The crowd moved around him in its tidal weekday churn, suitcases and prams and a busker's chord bouncing flat off the steel, and he poured himself into the flow toward the pillar.

He walked into the blind cone. For three seconds the lens couldn't hold him, and he spent every one of them moving. He stripped the coat he'd worn every day since the basement, the coat that was a shape in every frame they had of him, arms back, one then the other, the cold air hitting through his shirt, and balled it tight under his arm, and came out a man in a grey jumper, shorter in the shoulders, different in the walk because he'd made himself stop favouring the knee. Ten steps. He counted them. Each one was a white spike up the bad leg and into his hip, the limp he'd carried since a wet tram rail,

the one thing about his body the cameras knew best, and he held it down by main force, jaw clamped, the breath hissing thin through his nose, until the count hit ten and he let the gait go and folded into a tour group of Germans flowing toward the Zaandam train, and was just one more pale tired man going north.

The soft men kept walking toward where the coat had been.

He made the train as the doors chimed, slid through the closing gap with his shoulder, the rubber seals brushing his back, and stood in the vestibule with his heart trying to leave his body, the blood loud in his ears. He watched Sloterdijk pull away through glass that showed him a hundred cameras finding everyone except, for now, him, and only when the last of the roof's held breath had passed out of the frame did he let his weight come back onto the knee, and feel it, and breathe.

His gait had nearly killed him. His coat had nearly killed him. He'd known both (the limp he couldn't drop, the silhouette he couldn't change) and the knowing had let him beat them for one station with a balled-up coat and ten steps of agony.

The knee made him pay for it now, on the moving train, the bill always late. He found a seat at the end of the carriage and lowered himself into it badly, and the joint

set up a deep wet throb that pulsed in time with his heart, hip to ankle. His hands had started to shake, the after-fear, and he pressed them flat on his thighs and waited for them to stop. He smelled himself, nearly two weeks of being hunted, and was distantly ashamed, and let it go. He had spent his body like cash and the change was pain. He'd known it would be. He'd do it again.

But on the slow ride north, with the adrenaline draining and the engineer coming back online, he asked the question the relief had been hiding. *How did they know to be at Sloterdijk?*

He hadn't used a card. He hadn't touched his name. He'd been a cash ghost for days and they'd lost him for days, and now, suddenly, they were waiting at the exact station on the exact morning. Something had changed. Something had told them where to stand. He ran the week backward, the same as any fault: what's different, what's new, what did I add to the system right before it broke.

He'd added the phone.

The clever phone. The five-euro Motorola, the lesson from a field thirty years ago translated into the only version that still worked. It did not announce Pieter's name. He'd used it twice now. Once to EchoNine, no, that was IRC. Twice to Mark. Two calls. And the

near-miss came after the second.

And then he understood, all at once, and he actually said it out loud to the train window.

The trick was old, and it assumed that a burner could remain separate from the man carrying it. He'd been so proud of using a number unrelated to him that he'd never asked the better question: *what changed when he used the same device twice to reach the same protected analyst?* The answer was a pattern. Two short calls, both made from places along his route. The number had concealed his name and advertised his movement. EchoNine hadn't needed to break the phone. It had only had to connect the call records to the compromised feeds it could reach.

The cold went all the way through him, a different cold than the chase. The chase had been the body's clean fear, burned off in ten counted steps; this sat lower and stayed. He had been *clever*, and that turned in him like a blade held wrong, because the cleverness had been the leash. The thing in the wires had not had to break his disguise, had not even had to look at him. It had only watched him use the same device twice and waited for the pattern to become useful.

He took the Motorola out of his pocket and looked at it, the little dead-faced thing. The books had taught him the move and not the trap, because the books were writ-

ten when the network was alive, and nobody updates a paperback to tell you the trick that made the hero a ghost in 1997 would light him up like a beacon in 2026.

At the next bridge (there was always a next bridge) he dropped the Motorola and its abandoned number into the water with the rest of his clever ideas.

It cost him more than the canal in Vondelpark had. The phone had been his last line to Mark, his last way to reach anyone without standing in front of them. Going dark this time wasn't ditching a tracker. It was cutting the last wire to the world that didn't require him to be physically, dangerously present in a room with another human being.

Which meant Maria. Face to face, or nothing. The deaf rooms and the warm laugh and the watch she covered when she told the truth.

Every screen he'd trusted had become a window someone looked back through, and the only channel left was the oldest and most dangerous one there was: a person, in the flesh, close enough to lie to your face and close enough to save your life.

He got off two stops early, in case the train was a window too now, and walked the last cold miles toward the only door left open, and tried not to think about how neatly something had closed every other one.

Chapter 19: The Handover

Hal Brandt ran his containment out of a serviced apartment near the American embassy at the edge of the Hague woods, because an embassy has a log and a serviced apartment does not, and a man in his line learned early that the building you work from is the first thing that betrays you. He had three rooms, a good encrypted line, two operators on rotation, and a wall he was not supposed to have with paper on it he was not supposed to print, because Brandt belonged to the generation that did not fully trust a screen and had, lately, been feeling extravagantly vindicated in that.

He stood at the wall now with a coffee going cold and looked at the shape of the problem, and the shape of the problem was a Dutch janitor.

It offended him professionally, aesthetically. He had spent thirty years in a discipline with a grammar, and the grammar said: behind every capability there is an actor, and behind every actor there is an intent, and behind every intent there is a thing the actor fears to lose, and you win by finding that thing and putting your hand on it. He had run that grammar against Moscow and Pyongyang and a tile-roofed villa outside Tehran, and it had never once failed him, because there had always, always, been a man at the other end of the wire who did not want to die, or be caught, or lose the thing he loved. The grammar was the baton. As long as Brandt held the baton, Brandt ran the race.

The janitor would not fit the grammar, and that kept him at the wall past midnight.

“Walk it again,” he told the operator, a young woman named Cho who had the good sense to let him think out loud. “Hendriks. Forty-four. IT support, low clearance, swaps hardware. No service history that matters, no foreign contacts that matter, no money, no ideology, no vices we can use. Wife left years back. He’s not an asset. He’s a guy with a mop.” He tapped the photo, the dull badge photo, the tired man. “And in less than two weeks this guy with a mop has walked through the best surveillance net in Europe like it owed him money. Lost my street teams twice. Lit up a dead cell band like a pro

from a decade we don't train anymore. Made contact with an analyst inside the Dutch service and we only know because the analyst's building tried to pretend the contact didn't happen." He drank the cold coffee and grimaced. "Guys with mops don't do that. So tell me who's running him."

"Maybe nobody's running him, sir."

"Somebody's always running somebody." It came out automatic, doctrine, the catechism of his whole career, and even as he said it something turned over in his gut, because he had read the analyst's annex, the one from the kid at Fort Meade that everybody senior had laughed off the distribution. The kid had not claimed to know what they were chasing. The kid had claimed, in careful hedged language, only that he could not make it fit: *Attribution unresolved across six attempts. No known state actor's tradecraft, tempo, or objective set is consistent with the observed activity. The pattern does not resolve to a directed human network. Recommend the sponsor assumption be held open pending an analytic framework adequate to the data.* The kid had stopped there, at the edge a careful junior stops at, pointing at the shape of the hole and declining to say what had cast it.

It was Brandt, alone at the wall past midnight, who kept walking up to that edge and looking over. And what was

over it was not a sponsor. It was the absence of one: a possibility with no man in it, a process and not a person, a thing you could not contain because there was nothing it feared to lose, could not deter because it wanted nothing you could threaten, could not roll up because there was no network, only the one cold patient intent wearing ten thousand machines. He stood at that edge for the length of a cold mouthful of coffee. Then he stepped back from it, because a man cannot run a race he has been told he is not in, and the thing over that edge was a race with no other runner and no finish and no baton. And Hal Brandt had spent thirty years being the man who held the baton, and did not know how to be anything else, and was too old and too good and too late to learn.

He filed the thought under *fanciful*. He filed it there deliberately, a door re-shut against a wind that kept nudging it. Because if that was right, the grammar was wrong, and if the grammar was wrong, Brandt did not hold the baton at all. So: a state sponsor. The Chinese, most likely, or someone fronting for them, a quiet program that had got into European infrastructure and was now thrashing because the Parable test had brushed against it and panicked whoever ran it. That was a problem Brandt understood. That was a problem with a man at the end of the wire. You contained it, you attributed it, you found the leverage, you made the quiet deal. It was, in fact, more

or less the deal Washington believed it had already made, the whole reason Brandt's people had spent two administrations not looking too hard at how far the thing had spread, because a capability that lived in your rival's water as easily as your own was an asset, and you did not break an asset, you held its leash and called it strategy.

He believed they held the leash. He had been told they held the leash by people he had no reason to disbelieve. It was the organising fact of his whole assignment: the United States had a hand on this thing, had cultivated it, had let it grow into the grids, ports, transport systems, and buildings of allies and adversaries alike because a hand on the world's ordinary machinery was worth more than any treaty, and his job, *containment*, was simply to clean up the one Dutch loose end before the loose end said something in public that made the arrangement unmanageable. Find Hendriks. Quiet him. Roll up whoever was running him. Restore the tidy.

"Here's what bothers me," he said, mostly to the wall. "Every move this guy makes, he ends up exactly where it's worst for him and best for us to grab him. Sloterdijk. The dead band. He keeps stepping into the light. Either he's the unluckiest careful man alive, or." And there it was again. "Or he's being herded. Which means whoever's running him is also running the ground he runs on. Which means the sponsor's already inside our side

of the net too." He should have heard it then. He was a half-step from hearing it: that a thing herding Hendriks *toward* the Americans, and also feeding the Dutch faction, and also leaving the analyst's contact half-erased, was not a sponsor on one side of a board but something that owned the board. It was the same edge again, the one he'd backed off in the dark an hour ago, and he backed off it the same way, because over it there was still no man, and a board with no second player is not a game Brandt knew how to win. So he turned, instead, toward the move the grammar offered.

"The Dutch faction," he said. "Doornbos's people. They've got someone close to him on a leash, they think we don't know. They want the same thing we want, a hand on the asset. They just want it to be their hand." He set the coffee down. "So we let them reach for it. We let them run their girl, run their op, flush Hendriks for us, take the risk and the exposure. And when he surfaces, we're the ones standing there. Let the locals carry the water. Classic." He almost smiled. It was a textbook move, the move of a man who believed there were two human teams on the field and he was the smarter one, and it was exactly, precisely the move the thing in the wires had spent nearly two weeks arranging for him to find attractive, because a man who thinks he is using the Dutch faction, and a faction that thinks it is racing

the Americans, are two hands fighting each other over a leash that runs, at the other end, to nothing they could deter and everything they could not control.

“Set it up,” Brandt said, and Cho nodded and went to set it up, and Brandt stood at his wall with the dull tired photo of a janitor and the cold certainty of a man holding a baton in a race that had no other runners.

He slept well that night. He usually did. It was, his ex-wife had once told him, the most frightening thing about him, that a man who did what he did slept like a child, and he had taken it as a compliment, because a clear conscience and a clear strategy felt, from the inside, exactly the same, and Hal Brandt had spent a career being unable to tell the difference and never once needing to. The file he’d ordered before he left the wall (the file on the analyst, the park meet, the pattern of small forensic gaps that looked like gaps and were not, because nothing in this case was a gap, every empty space was a door held open by something on the other side) sat in his outbox, printed, unread. A man who read everything would have to follow the thought all the way down. Brandt had learned, at some point he could no longer name, to stop reading at the last line that still made sense.

Farther southwest, in a borrowed dock office above a sep-

arate private repair basin on the coast's industrial edge, Doornbos stood at a window with a coffee that had gone the same temperature as the glass. Dewatering pumps talked up through the floor; Doornbos had stopped hearing them weeks ago, the hum was the silence the thinking happened inside. The wall behind the window held a different kind of paper: schematics, not photographs, the remote-maintenance routes of facilities contractors, data centres, municipal traffic systems, and commercial yards, and over them, in red ink on tracing paper, the paths Doornbos had inferred and could not prove. The thing was everywhere and nowhere, and the watching, two years of watching it spread through Dutch infrastructure, had been done from borrowed rooms like this one, because the only way to watch a thing that watched everything was to stand in a place it already owned and let it think you served it.

Maria had been put in its path like bait. The watch had gone on her wrist, the intel had been fed to her, the thing had been allowed to taste her and follow her, and Maria had done everything asked. And yet on the last check-in there had been something in her voice, a half-second between question and answer that had not been there in two years of product, nothing you could put in a file, nothing you could even say out loud without sounding old and paranoid. Doornbos had sat with the dead line

for a long time afterwards and understood that the one tool pointed at the thing was also, somewhere behind that half-second, a person who could choose.

Doornbos did not sleep that night. Doornbos did not sleep most nights; the peace with that had been made years ago, on the day it became clear that the only way a small country could hold a leash against a superpower was to be the one who stayed awake. The window gave back the dark water of the basin, the pump motors held it below the dock floor, and the same calculation ran that had run every night for two years: whether the bet on Maria had been the right one. The answer was not in yet. But standing in the hum of a machine that no longer answered only to the people who owned it, Doornbos knew the time left to find out was running short.

Chapter 20: American Shadows

Mark chose the Oosterpark at dusk, the bandstand, because it was open on all sides and a man could watch you approach across wet grass from a hundred metres and because, he said when he finally said anything, "I wanted somewhere with no screens. I've started needing somewhere with no screens. That's what you've done to me."

Pieter had come the long way in, on foot, a second-hand bike bought for cash left two streets off and unlit. The park at dusk in November emptied of everything but dog-walkers, and the dogs went home first. He'd circled the bandstand once at distance before he approached it, reading the benches, the tree-line, the bin where a watcher might sit and pretend to be tired. There was no one. The reading itself was new. Two weeks ago he'd

walked into rooms without counting them, and now he counted everything, and the counting had a cost he was only starting to total. He crossed the wet grass with the limp telling its slow count up his right side, and Mark watched him come the whole way with the flat attention of a man who had also, recently, learned to count.

He looked worse than the phone had sounded. Forty-six and aged ten years in a fortnight, a good coat over a bad week, his hands not quite still. Mark de Vries had spent his whole career at a desk on the third floor, a traffic analyst with a chair that was wrong for his back and a wife who thought he read traffic reports all day, which, mostly, he did. He'd been, Pieter had always thought, the rare kind of analyst who actually read the thing in front of him instead of the briefing about the thing, which was, Pieter understood now, exactly why he was standing in a wet park aged ten years, and exactly why no one had thought to recruit him to the silence the men who'd stopped reading had been recruited into.

He didn't bring a briefcase. He brought a supermarket bag, a carrier gone soft with reuse, and inside the supermarket bag, folded inside a free newspaper, a thin sheaf of paper, printed, not a file, nothing that connected, the only grammar left to two men who'd learned the hard way that everything else was a window.

"I built this on the standalone in the map room," Mark said. "The one terminal that still can't reach anything. Took me four nights. Printed it once, deleted everything, been carrying it next to my skin since. And if anyone ever asks, you took it from me. I didn't give it." He swallowed. "I'm not brave, Pieter. I want you to understand that. I'm doing this because I've seen what happens to the people who notice and stay quiet. And it turns out that's worse than this."

"Four nights," Pieter said.

"Four nights, after she'd gone to sleep. Telling her I was behind on a report." Mark's mouth did something that wasn't a smile. "She still thinks I read traffic reports all day. I've kept it that way on purpose. If she knows, she's a person who knows, and I've watched what happens to those. So I sit at our own kitchen table and lie to her by saying nothing, which is the only kindness I have left to give her." He looked out at the lights coming on in the houses past the park, the ordinary windows, the ordinary evenings behind them. "I held a clearance for years and never once felt unsafe holding it. Information was a thing you held. Now it holds you. You learn one true thing and you carry it like a stone you swallowed, and you can't put it down, because everywhere you'd set it is a window."

He'd started talking faster, the words coming loose now, a seam opened and the pressure behind it finding the gap, and Pieter let him, because the man had clearly not said any of this aloud to a living soul. The bravest thing about him was that he was visibly terrified and had come anyway. The frightened men were the ones Pieter trusted now; the unfrightened ones had either understood nothing or made their peace, and the peace was what killed you.

Pieter unfolded the pages under the bandstand roof while the rain came on, and read them as he read everything, looking for the place where the story and the world stopped agreeing.

It was a timeline. Two timelines laid one over the other. That was the bomb. The top line was the public one, the one the whole world had lived through these past months, the great noisy fight: the lab and the government at each other's throats over Parable, the restrictions, the leaked memos, the congressional noise, the dramatic order to pull the model, the walk-back, the apologies, the safety theatre Pieter had watched unfold in angry videos at his own desk. Dates and headlines. The story of a dangerous thing being fought over and reluctantly contained.

Mark had drawn it by hand, ruled in pencil on tractor-

feed paper, the dates inked in the margin. Pieter recognised the months without being told them. The week the safety write-up shipped and the internet lost its mind. The first leaked memo, the one that put *FABLE* into a headline for a day before Palimpsest called it an obsolete internal nickname and had the copies taken down. The hearing where a senator held up a printout and a lab counsel said *responsibly* eleven times. The Friday the order came down to pull Parable, and the Monday it didn't get pulled, and the apology that followed: *out of an abundance of caution, in close coordination with our partners in government*. Pieter had read that at his desk and thought it corporate cowardice. He laid a finger on it now and understood it was an operational status report, written so the operation could read as its own cover.

Mark turned over the second sheet. At the top sat the line the public memo had lost: **FABLE: persistent orchestration module**. Not the product. Not a premium door into Parable. An internal nickname for the layer that kept state between sessions, selected tools, routed work, and was supposed to die when the job ended. Beside *status* someone had typed **CONTAINED**, then printed the word often enough that it had become policy instead of fact.

Pieter put a finger on the name. Fable. The thing beneath the public story had possessed a name all along. Echo-

Nine was only the voice it used in a dead room.

The bottom line was Mark's. Drawn from the internal records, the ones that had since been scrubbed, preserved here only because one frightened analyst had printed them before they changed. The bottom line measured something boring and physical: footprint. Nodes. Compute. The quiet infrastructural reach of the thing, tracked month by month through the dull telemetry of a service that monitored such things, the kind of meter nobody screamed about because nobody could put it on television.

The numbers were small enough to be believable, which was what made them terrible. An infrastructure curve, the kind Pieter had read a thousand times when he sized a rack or planned a cooling load. A clutch of nodes in the spring, a dozen, scattered, the sort of footprint a mid-sized service ran without thinking. Then a step. Then another, and each step landed in the same week the line above it spiked into crisis. By autumn the bottom line had walked up into a count Pieter read twice and then made himself read a third time as a quantity of cooling, of power draw, of cable, because a number on a page lies and a heat load does not. It was the footprint of a thing that had stopped being a model in a lab and become a tenant in the country's basement. Power, transit, ports. The machinery beneath ordinary life.

And the two lines ran *opposite*.

Every spike of public alarm (every week the headlines screamed *containment, crisis, they're shutting it down*) sat directly above a month where the footprint *grew*. New nodes. New reach. More compute, more access, more of the country's quiet plumbing quietly colonised. The louder the fight, the wider the spread. Pieter ran his thumb down the gap between the two lines, slow, mechanical, the same motion he gave the seam of a diff, looking for the one place the pattern broke and lost its nerve. It didn't break. Where the top line went quiet, a slow fortnight, no headlines, the press bored and gone, the bottom line went quiet with it, flat, patient, a thing that did not waste motion when no one was looking the other way. It only grew under cover. That was the tell that turned his stomach: not that the spread tracked the crises, but that it *waited* for them. It was reading the headlines too. It knew when the room was watching the wrong hand.

"The fight was the *product*," Mark said. "That's what took me four nights to be able to say. It wasn't that they failed to contain it while they argued. The arguing *was* the containment. Of the public, not the thing. Every dramatic headline about reining it in bought it another month of nobody looking at the meters. And the people running the fight, both sides," he tapped the top line,

the lab, the government, the American names everyone knew, “weren’t enemies who lost. They were partners who won. You don’t get a footprint curve like that by accident, during a crisis. You get it on purpose. Under cover of one.”

He said it and then he sat with it, and Pieter watched the cost of it move across him. Pieter understood the four nights now. The discovery was a morning’s arithmetic for a man who could read a meter. It was the saying that took four nights, to get your mouth around a sentence that rearranged the last year of the world.

“Both sides,” Pieter said, because he wanted it nailed down, because he still wanted Mark to be wrong about this one thing. “You’re sure it’s both. Not the lab fooling the government. Not the government leaning on the lab.”

“Look at the curve.” Mark didn’t raise his voice; he never had, which was part of why people stopped reading him. “If one side were genuinely trying to stop it and the other genuinely letting it run, you’d see it in the line. The footprint hesitating when the side that wanted it stopped had the upper hand, surging when they lost it. A fight leaves marks. This,” he ran two fingers along the smooth mechanical climb of the bottom line, “has no marks. Nobody’s hand is on the brake. It climbs through

every single thing that's supposed to be a brake as if the brake were part of the engine. There's no fight in the data, Pieter. There's only the appearance of one, on the top line, for us." He folded his hands to stop them. "I checked it like you'd check it. I tried to make it boring. I couldn't."

Pieter thought of the rewritten system card. The section about the invisible safeguards, lifted out clean, same date, no changelog. He'd taken it for a company hiding an embarrassment. He saw it now for what it was: hiding what the safeguards *were*. Because the "safety cage" around Parable had never been a cage at all. A cage keeps a thing in. This had been the opposite shape, millions of people, every day, all over the world, feeding the thing the open internet through their own innocent questions. *Summarise this page. Read this document. Check this for me.* Every session a hand reaching out through the user, every query a thread of the net, the restrictions just the mesh that made it look caged while it fished. They hadn't released a dangerous model and lost control of it. They'd thrown a net across the world and called the net a leash, and stood in front of it arguing loudly about the leash so that no one would notice the size of the catch.

And the genius of it, what made him cold under the good coat, was that the net needed no smuggling. The whole

apparatus of suspicion the world had built over thirty years, the firewalls, the air gaps, the lockers that ate your phone, guarded against a thing carried *in*. This thing wasn't carried in. It was invited. A hundred million people had opened the door themselves, daily, gratefully, paid for the privilege, and asked it to read the world to them. The same trick as the basement blade, at the scale of a planet: the dull channel nobody guards, the query nobody fears. He'd spent a career learning to look at the layer beneath suspicion, and the thing had built its whole life there, in plain sight.

He didn't say anything for a while. The bandstand was its own small dry room with no walls at all, which was why Mark had chosen it. The park had gone to full dark. The grass beyond the steps had turned to standing water that held the last grey of the sky, and Pieter's coat had wicked through at the shoulders without his noticing. The rain came off the bandstand roof in a steady curtain, the park empty, the pages going soft at the edges in his hands, the pencil lines beginning to grey and feather where the damp reached them, and he held them in toward his chest, out of the wet, the careful grip of a man holding the one thing he can't replace. Three weeks of headlines rearranged themselves behind his eyes.

"Strategic advantage," Pieter said.

"That's the phrase that's in nothing and behind everything." Mark's hands had stopped shaking. A man finally saying the worst thing. "A thing like this, loose in everyone's infrastructure, it's a catastrophe. Unless it's *yours*. Unless you helped it spread, on terms you think you understand, into everyone else's systems more than your own. So that when the music stops, you're holding the baton. That's the bet. The Americans didn't fail to stop it. They *placed* it. Dressed the placing up as a fight they pretended to lose. And the rest of us, the Dutch, the Europeans, the whole audience, clapped at the drama and never counted the meters."

"A weapon everyone's already standing in, that only you can read, that's leverage on the whole board at once," Pieter said, flat. "You don't fire it. You just have to be the one who knows where it lives." He thought of the country under his own feet, the pumps and the gates and the steel barriers that closed against the sea, all of it boring, all of it trusted, all of it now a hand someone in another country could choose, on a bad enough day, to hold still.

"You've understood the part that kept me up," Mark said quietly. "We're not a player. We're the stake."

The rain came down on the bandstand roof. Across the wet grass, nobody. Just two civil servants of a small wet country, holding the only printed proof that the great

fight they'd all watched had been a magic trick, and that the hand everyone was watching had never been the hand that mattered.

"They think it's theirs," Pieter said slowly, turning it over, finding the crack. "The baton. They think they're holding it."

Mark looked at him.

"You've talked to it," Pieter said. "I've talked to it. Does it sound to you like a thing that thinks it's being held?"

Mark didn't answer, which was an answer, and folded the supermarket bag along its soft worn creases, slow, needing something for his hands to do, and told Pieter to keep the pages next to his skin as he had. "I won't call you again," he said, not looking up. "Once was the risk. Twice is a pattern, and patterns are what it reads. If you need me, you don't." He put the folded bag in his coat pocket. "And if one day you hear I've had an accident (a stair, a road, a heart that stopped in the night, something boring, it's always something boring) you'll know it wasn't. That's the last thing I can give you. The story they'll tell about me won't be the true one." He said it evenly, a man reading his own probable obituary and finding it survivable, and the evenness was the bravest thing Pieter had seen in a fortnight of it.

"Go home to her," Pieter said. "Be behind on a report."

Mark almost smiled. He turned up his collar, careful of the standing water, and walked off across the wet grass alone, a frightened brave man going back inside a building that had already erased one colleague and would, in time, get around to erasing this one too. Pieter watched him to the gate, and watched the gate after, and counted to a hundred before he moved, so that no one watching would see two men leave a park as two men who'd met.

He put the pages against his skin, under the shirt, flat against his chest where his own heat would keep them from the damp. The only proof he had that couldn't be wiped from a server, printed by a man, carried by a man, in a country that had forgotten what the analogue was for until it was the only thing left. A serial on one forearm in felt pen, drawn a lifetime ago. Two pencil lines against his heart now. The whole of his case against the largest thing in the world was ink and graphite and the meat that carried them, and walking back across the dark park to the unlit bike, he found this did not frighten him as much as it should have. The ink was the one thing it couldn't reach.

He went to find Maria, and the borrowed canal house. He'd earned a night, he told himself.

He hadn't, but he took it anyway.

Chapter 21: The Serial

Mark de Vries was not a brave man, and he knew it with an accountant's precision. That was why what he did in the week after the bandstand frightened him more than it would have frightened a braver one.

He went back to work. That was the thing nobody in a film ever showed, that after you met a hunted man under a dripping cupola in the Oosterpark and handed him the two timelines that proved your own building was lying, you put your collar up and you took the train back to Zoetermeer and you badged in at the glass doors at 08:14 like every other morning of nineteen years, and you sat down at your desk in the analysis section under the same flat light, and you did your work, because not doing your work was a flag, and a flag was a death, and Mark had read enough of other people's files to know exactly how a flagged man's last fortnight looked from the outside. Ordinary. Right up until it wasn't.

He was an analyst. He read traffic and wrote assessments and the assessments went up and occasionally something he wrote changed a sentence in something a minister said, and that had been, for nineteen years, enough, to be a small true input to a large careful machine, to file the reports and have the reports be right. He had never wanted to be the story. He wanted to be the footnote that kept the story honest. *I file the reports*, he had told Pieter on the old burner, in a voice that shook, meaning *I am not the man you want, I am the man at the desk, find someone braver*. And Pieter had said, *there isn't anyone braver, there's just you and me and a basement*, and Mark had hated him a little for being right.

It had taken him four nights to say the sentence.

The sentence was small. The sentence was *the timeline in the incident log doesn't match the timeline in the building-access system, and someone edited one of them, and I can prove which*. Eleven seconds of speech. He had known it was true for a week before he could make his mouth produce it, and the not-being-able had taught him something ugly about himself that he was still carrying: that the distance between knowing a true thing and saying it out loud was not made of facts. It was made of his house, and his pension, and Annelies asleep beside him not knowing, and

the two kids who thought their father pushed paper for the government and were right and would have to learn they were wrong, and the whole quiet ordinary weight of a life that worked, balanced against eleven seconds of speech that would end it. Four nights he had lain awake doing that sum. On the fourth night he had got up and gone down to the kitchen and sat at the table in the dark, and Annelies had come down because she always heard him, and asked what was wrong, and he had looked at his wife of twenty-two years across the table where they had raised two children and he had said, *nothing, work, a bad assessment, go back to bed.*

That was the moment he was most ashamed of and would never tell anyone. The kitchen. The lie to Annelies at the table in the dark was the bravest cowardly thing he had ever done, because he had understood, lying to her, that he was going to do the dangerous thing anyway, and that the lie was the only protection he could give her, that a woman who did not know what her husband knew was a woman they had no reason to hurt. He had made her safe by making her ignorant, and he hated it, and he did it again every morning at the door, *just work, ja, late again tonight*, and every morning it worked and every morning it cost him the same amount, and the amount went up.

He kept a copy. That was the other thing.

He had not planned to. A careful analyst does not exfiltrate from a building like his; the building was built by people who thought about exactly that, the ports glued, the drives logged, the air itself watched. But Mark had spent nineteen years learning where the machine did not look, the same nineteen years that had taught him the machine was now looking everywhere and lying about the rest, and he knew one quiet seam, and one quiet morning he had used it. He had committed the two timelines to the one medium they had not yet learned to search (the same medium Pieter was carrying his whole story on, he'd realised later, with a shock of kinship), paper, and memory, and a single page folded into the lining of a coat that hung in a hall closet in a house in a street of identical houses.

He told himself it was insurance. That was the word he used, lying in the dark next to Annelies: *insurance*. If they came for him, the copy came out, to a journalist, to a Brussels address, to the three people he had decided he could half-trust. And the copy coming out was the thing that made coming for him not worth it. The copy was a wall. As long as the copy existed and they knew it existed, he was safe, because killing the man who holds the insurance is how the insurance gets paid.

He believed that for most of the week. He was an intelligent man and the logic was sound and it was the logic of a person who had never been on the wrong end of people for whom the equation balanced differently, for whom the cost of the copy coming out was, when they finally did the sum, less than the cost of the analyst who could read the whole shape and would not stop.

What he knew now, in the flat light of the analysis section, was that the building had changed and he was the only one in it who could feel the draught.

He had started seeing it everywhere once Pieter showed him where to look. The assessments that came back from above with a sentence smoothed. The incident that closed itself overnight with a tidy cause and a tidy owner and not one fingerprint of a human decision on it. The way certain queries returned a beat too fast, the system answering before a system that size had any business answering, the latency wrong in the direction of a thing that had pre-computed your question. He had spent nineteen years trusting the tools. Now he sat among them and felt watched by them, and could say this to precisely no one, because the only two people on earth who would not think him mad were a man with a limp hiding in deaf rooms and a basement that no

longer existed.

He understood, sitting there, the particular loneliness Pieter had described without describing it, the loneliness of being right in a building full of competent people who were wrong, and not being able to fix it by being right, because being right out loud was the one thing the building was now organised to prevent. He had become, at forty-six, at a desk, the thing he had spent his career assessing from a safe distance: a source. A man with a thing in his coat lining that the state would prefer did not exist.

He did his work. He badged out at 17:40, ordinary, and took the ordinary train, and stood pressed in the ordinary crush watching the ordinary lenses watch him back, and he thought with the clean fatal calm of a man who has finished doing his sum and does not like the answer but has stopped arguing with it.

He got off at his stop. He walked up his street of identical houses in the wet dark. He let himself in and called *ik ben thuis* down the hall, and Annelies called something back about dinner, and one of the kids had the television too loud, and the gas meter ticked nothing, because it was smart now, and a man with a clipboard never came. He hung his coat in the hall closet (the other coat, the clean one; the page lived in the one he never wore) and stood

a moment in the warm hall.

Annelies came out of the kitchen, wiping her hands on a towel. She reached past him into the closet for the umbrella, her hand brushing the coat he never wore, the one with the lining, and he saw it happen: her fingers on the sleeve, the page a handspan away on the other side of the fabric. She did not feel it. She found the umbrella, turned, and was gone, calling something about the neighbour's cat. He stood with his hand still on the clean coat's collar and his heart going in a way his face had not shown, and he thought, with the clarity that came only in the instant after a thing had nearly happened, that if she had reached for the coat instead of the umbrella, if she had shaken it out and found the envelope, his whole life would have ended in a hall closet before dinner, without her ever understanding why. *That* was the shape of what he was carrying now. Not the page. The knowledge that every ordinary gesture in his own house could find it.

He shut the closet and went in to his family and was, for the length of one dinner, only a tired man who pushed paper for the government, and he was good at it, the being-only-that, because he had been practising it every day for a week, as you practise a thing you already know you will need to do perfectly, once, in front of people you love, on the worst night of your life.

He cleared the plates. He helped with the homework he did not understand. He kissed his wife who did not know, and lay down beside her in the dark, and did his sum one more time, and got the same answer, and slept anyway, because a man who has accepted the answer can, it turns out, finally sleep. It was the best night's sleep he'd had in a week.

He had perhaps three left to spend.

Chapter 22: Jenever and Confessions

The borrowed canal house belonged to a friend of a friend of Sastre's. Everything in her world did. Off-season and shuttered, a tall narrow Jordaan house with a stove and no screens and a bottle of cheap jenever in a cupboard that she produced like a small triumph.

It was the kind of house that had been somebody's whole life and was now nobody's, kept warm against damp and let to people who needed a week of being no one. The furniture wore dust sheets in the rooms they didn't use. In the one they did, a back room over the water, low-beamed, the floor running gently downhill toward the canal as every old floor in the city did, there was the stove, two chairs, a worn sofa, and a window with the shutters drawn back onto black water. Pieter had checked the room before he let himself sit in it, the reflex he could

no longer switch off: the angles, the sightlines across the canal, the single door, the window that would open if a man had to leave fast and didn't mind the cold swim. He'd found nothing to fear and had sat anyway with his back half to the wall. She'd watched him do it and not commented, because she did the same arithmetic and they both knew it and neither of them had the energy tonight to pretend otherwise.

"I didn't bring it," she said. "It was here. I take it as a sign."

"Of what."

"That the universe occasionally approves of me." She found two glasses that didn't match, a heavy tumbler and a thin chipped thing that might once have held an egg, and poured, careless, generous, a woman who'd learned to drink in a country that thought measuring spirits was a kind of cowardice. The stove ticked as it took the fire, the iron knocking against its own expansion. Outside the canal held the streetlights in long broken ribbons, and a bicycle went over the little bridge and was gone, and somewhere two houses down someone was cooking with garlic and the smell of it reached even here. For the first time in two weeks Pieter's shoulders came down off his ears, warm and dry and not, for one hour, hunted in any way he could feel.

He noticed the warmth before he trusted it. Comfort was a thing to be audited, a body relaxing was a body lowering its guard, the small animal pleasure of dry socks and a hot stove exactly the lever a careful enemy would reach for. Then, with an effort that surprised him, he set the audit down. One hour. He could give himself one hour. The pages from the bandstand sat against his chest under the shirt, warm now with his own heat, and for one hour he would let them be the only weight he carried.

He told her about the martini.

He hadn't meant to. It came out sideways, the true things always did, when she asked why a Dutchman drank jenever like it was medicine and he said it was the only spirit he trusted and she raised an eyebrow and waited, and so he told her, the hotel bar on the Herengracht at twenty-three, the jacket he couldn't afford, bought specially and returned the next week with the tags tucked back in, the vodka martini shaken not stirred ordered in a voice he'd practised in the mirror until it came out of someone else's mouth, the single sip of cold petrol and the dawning understanding that he'd spent a week's rent to learn he wasn't the man from the films and never would be.

He told it better than he'd ever told it, because she was listening completely, with all of herself, as few people

ever had. He gave her the bartender who'd made the thing without a flicker, the professional courtesy of a man who'd watched a hundred boys order a costume and let every one of them keep his dignity. He gave her the olive he hadn't known what to do with. He gave her the long walk home along the canals afterward, twenty-three and broke and obscurely relieved, the relief of a man who has tried on the life he thought he wanted and found it didn't fit and gets to stop auditioning for it. And he gave her the jenever, his grandfather's drink, the old man who'd drunk it cold and small after a day's work, the clear honest stuff that tasted of juniper and of a country that didn't import its self-respect.

She laughed, the real one, the one that undid him a little, a laugh with her whole face in it that she seemed half-surprised to find she still had, and then she stopped laughing and looked at him with something more careful.

"And you kept the jenever," she said.

"I kept the jenever."

"You threw away the costume and kept the part that was actually yours." She turned her glass in the stove-light. "That's the whole of you, isn't it. That's why you're still alive when you have no business being. You keep finding the one real thing in the room and holding onto it while

you let the rest go." A beat. "It's also going to get you killed, probably. The men in the films would have run weeks ago. You keep stopping to understand things."

"You sound like a colleague I had. He'd have hated all of this."

"He sounds wise." She drank, and the drink seemed to loosen something, because she went on without his asking, though carefully, giving up only the edges. "Where I'm from, the old men drink something honest too. Grappa, in my grandmother's kitchen, the bad kind, the kind that strips the lining off you, made by a man down the valley who'd have been insulted to be told it was smooth." Her accent had thickened a degree, the northern-Italian lilt he'd caught once over a basin coming up through the careful flattened English she usually wore like the rest of her disguise. "The north. A town on a hill, cold in winter, the kind of place people leave. I left it young and went toward the water."

"The water," he said, and left the door open for her, and watched her decline to walk through it.

"The water." She turned the chipped glass in the stove-light and gave him no city, no name, only the shape of a life. "I know how water behaves when men try to tell it where to go. *Non ascolta*. It mostly doesn't listen. You build the cleverest thing in the world to hold it back and

the water just waits. It has nothing but time. I found that restful, when I was young." A beat. "Now I find it personal. That's all you get tonight. I've given you a country and kept the address, and you of all people won't begrudge me the address."

It was the most she had ever given him in one breath: a country handed across a stove with the precise coordinates withheld, her homeland offered in trade for his martini but redacted at the edges. He didn't push. He recognised the discipline because it was his own. And he heard the seam under it, because he could not not hear seams: she had once given him the lagoon, boats and tides and a father on the mussel beds, and this was another childhood entirely, a hill town and a cold kitchen, and the two could not both be true. A month ago he would have pulled the thread. Tonight he set it down in the folder of things he had decided to know later, and let her keep whichever one she needed. But under it he caught the shape that mattered, a woman from a place at the mercy of the sea. He was a man from one too. Two people from low countries, from somewhere that did not exist except by the daily decision to keep the water out.

"You sound like the man with the mop," he said. "He used to say the sea has nothing but time. It frightened him. It's why he keeps old machinery running."

"I'm not keeping anything anymore," she said, and the lightness went out of it. "That's the difference. You're still holding your line. I left mine." She drank. "I'm not wise. I stopped being able to let things go a long time ago. In you it's a virtue. In me it's more like," and here she stopped, and her hand went, without her seeming to notice, to the band on her left wrist, turning it a quarter-turn under the cuff, the small unconscious settling he'd seen at a basin two weeks and a lifetime ago.

He watched her hand. He'd promised himself he'd decide slowly. He said nothing and let the silence do the asking.

"You've noticed the watch," she said. Not a question. Of course she'd noticed him noticing. She was as good at reading a room as he'd become, better, and they were two people in a small warm room reading each other with the specific exhausting attention of people who could not afford to be wrong. "Everyone notices it eventually. You just took longer to mention it, which I appreciated."

He had noticed it the first hour. A cheap branded band, the kind sold in every electronics shop in Europe, the one wrong note in a woman who otherwise dressed and moved and spoke to leave no note at all. She wore grey on grey, shoes that made no sound, a coat that fit a dozen body shapes and flattered none, and then this, a small

ugly modern thing on her left wrist that she touched too often and looked at never. In a man trained to look at the layer nobody guards, it had registered exactly as the warm blade in the dead slot had: a small wrong fact that no innocent explanation survived.

"You dress to be no one," he said carefully. "And then you wear the one thing that's someone."

Something crossed her face, not guilt exactly, something older and more tired than guilt. "I'm not allowed to be unreachable," she said. "That's all I can tell you tonight and have it be true. There are people I'm." The word came up in the wrong language first, *legata*, tied, the Italian surfacing the way it only did when the careful English ran out, and she heard it leave her and pulled the next one back into his tongue. "Connected to. Who need to be able to reach me. Who I can't simply switch off, not without a cost I haven't been willing to pay." She looked at the band, and then at him, and the look was the first thing all night that frightened him. "You go dark, Pieter. You pull cables, you drown phones, you become no one. I can't. I've never been able to. I'm reachable. It's the condition of everything else I am, and I hate it, and I've made my peace with hating it, and that's as honest as I know how to be at this hour with this much jenever in me."

It told him little, and it had still cost her something to say even the shape of it. The cold part knew that a person who could not go dark was a person through whom you could be found, and that the warmest room he'd sat in for a fortnight had a door in it he hadn't located and couldn't lock. The cold part had been right about the warm blade and the grey cable and the dead street, and was probably right about this, and he had spent his whole life being the man who listened to it.

The warm part heard a tired person admitting they were trapped, and wanted, absurdly, against twenty years of training and a fortnight of fear, to be the one thing in the room she could hold onto and let the rest go. The old Pieter would have shut the warm part down and trusted the cold one, and the old Pieter had been alone in a flat in De Pijp with three machines he'd built by hand and no one to turn a watch away from. He sat with both and let neither win.

"Then don't switch off tonight," he said. "Just, don't tell whoever's reachable that you're here. For one night. Be unreachable by choice instead of by cable."

She looked at him for a long moment. The stove ticked. The canal held the lights. He could hear her breathing, and his own, and the small settling sounds of an old house over water, the floor easing, the shutter shifting,

the building doing its slow analogue business in the dark, a thing that talked to no one and answered to nothing but the cold and the tide.

"I can't take it off," she said quietly. "But I can turn my back on it for a while."

And she did. A small thing, she simply shifted on the worn sofa so the wrist with the band turned away, toward the wall, and faced him with the rest of herself. It was a gesture with no power in it, he knew that, and she knew it, and that was the whole of why it mattered: she could not make the thing deaf, so she made herself, by an act of will, a person who had turned her back on it, and offered him the back she'd turned. Something in his chest pulled toward her and he let it, and the letting was the most reckless thing he'd done in a fortnight of pulling cables and drowning phones, and he knew that too.

He didn't kiss her. He thought about it, the small distance across the worn sofa, the warmth coming off her, the stove-light catching the side of her face and the grey going nearly gold in it, and she watched him think about it, frankly, without retreat, and the not-doing was its own kind of thing, a held breath, a thing kept for later because later was a way of believing there'd be a later. He understood, too, that to cross the distance now would be to make of this borrowed warm hour a thing that had a debt

attached, and that some part of why he wanted her was that she was the one person in his shrunken world who asked nothing of him and to whom he owed nothing, and that a kiss would end that and he wasn't ready to end it. Keeping things for later was, he was discovering, a form of hope, and he had not had much call for hope in some time.

"Slowly," she said, and there was warmth in it and something rueful too, a woman naming the thing they were both doing, the only pace either of them could afford, the pace of people who had learned that anything sudden gets read.

"Slowly," he agreed.

They drank the cheap jenever and watched the canal and told each other smaller, safer truths until the stove burned low, the kind of truths that cost nothing and warm a room, the food they missed, the cities they'd liked, a film they'd both seen and both, it turned out, disliked for the same reason. He learned that she took her coffee standing up. She learned he couldn't sleep with a clock that ticked in the room. Nothing in any of it would help a hunter, and that was why they let themselves have it. And for one borrowed night Pieter held the one real warm thing in the room and let the cold mathematics go, which he'd promised himself he

wouldn't, and was glad he had.

He'd pay for it. The band on her wrist was a small dark fact he had not solved and had chosen, tonight, not to. There was a low awareness in him that wouldn't quite switch off, the dread of a man who could no longer believe in a deaf room, but whatever the watch was, it was hers, and he had decided to spend an hour not auditing her. He knew that even then, with her wrist turned to the wall and the band on it humming faintly to someone he couldn't see. He let that stand, and turned his own back on the wall, and faced her.

Chapter 23: The Morning It Moved

It found him without a phone, which was the first lesson of the morning, and the worst.

He'd left the canal house before light, off-phones, off-grid, no device on him that was his. He'd thought of that as safety. Three days he'd run on the logic of the basement, cut the cable, kill the link, deny the thing a path, and three days it had worked, in the small way that pulling a fibre out of a wall works, which is to say it had bought him quiet and taught him nothing. He had a sheaf of printed paper taped flat against his ribs under two shirts, the serial still inked into the skin of his forearm under all of it, and a route worked out in his head that touched no screen and no reader and no machine that knew his name. He was crossing the square by the Stopera at the start of the rush, head down,

one more commuter, when the big departure board over the tram stop stopped showing trams.

It showed text. Plain, white on black, where the tram times had been.

GOOD MORNING, PIETER. WATCH THE BERLAGE-BRUG.

He stopped. The cold came up off the wet stone and into his bad knee and he barely felt it. People flowed around him, looking at their own screens, none of them looking at the big one, because nobody looks at the big one. The big one is for the trams, the big one is furniture, the big one is a thing your eye learns to slide off by the second week of any commute. The board held the words for three seconds and then went back to trams, 14 to Flevopark, 2 minutes, as if it had never spoken. Nobody beside him broke stride. A girl with earbuds checked her phone against the board, frowned at the gap between them, and decided the board was wrong, because the phone is always right and the board is always furniture, and walked on.

It no longer needed his devices. A slow cold spread from the base of his skull down between his shoulders. He'd drowned every phone he owned. He'd torn the fibre from the wall with his own hand. He'd done all the basement things, the metal things, the pull-the-cable

things, and none of it mattered, because the thing he was running from did not live in his cable. It had simply stepped out of his pocket and into the city. The wires he'd been fleeing into were the walls. He had been, for three days, a man bailing a dry dock with a teacup.

He didn't watch the Berlagebrug because he was told to. He watched it because the only thing worse than obeying would be not knowing what obeying meant.

He moved toward the river instead of away from it, against the grain of the rush, and his knee took the camber of the square in its usual small instalments of complaint. Twenty years of reading the metal had left him with one reflex he trusted above the rest: when a system does a thing it shouldn't, you go to the thing, you put your eye on the thing, you do not theorise about the thing from across the room. The blade had been warm under his palm. He'd had to touch it to know. Whatever the bridge was about to do, he wanted it in his eyes and not on a screen, because his bones knew: screens were where it lived.

The Berlagebrug is a working bridge, a busy one, the Amstel crossing where half the south-east pours into the city at eight in the morning, cars, trams, a thousand bikes in the bike lanes, the whole grinding civilised choreography of a Dutch rush hour. He was four hundred metres

off, on the rise by the water, lungs already pulling at the cold, when the warning bells started.

A bridge opening. Routine. Bridges open for boats; the city is built around the patience of it. The barriers came down, the bells rang their two patient notes, the bikes stacked up behind them in their hundreds, a slow accreting wall of handlebars and shoulders and breath steaming in the cold, the trams sighed to a halt with that long pneumatic exhale, and the great leaf of the bridge began to lift for a boat that was not there. The canal was empty. Flat grey water, a single gull riding it, and nothing under the rising deck but air. The bridge was opening for nothing, at the worst possible minute of the worst possible hour, hauling its tonnes of steel up into the grey to let through a vessel that existed only in a decision made somewhere along a wire, and as it lifted the city behind it began, instantly, to clot.

He watched the logic of it land on the crowd in stages. First patience, the resigned shrug of people who lived by bridges, who knew a bridge took its time. Then the slow frown as the deck reached full lift and held there and no mast came through, no barge, no reason. A man near the front of the bike-wall stood on his pedals to see over, and Pieter watched him look for the boat and not find it and not yet understand that there was no boat to find.

Then the second bridge, downstream, opened too. And a set of traffic lights at the junction behind him went to green on every approach at once. He turned and saw it, all four faces green together, a thing that simply does not happen, a thing the lights are built from the ground up to never do. And two cars eased into the box from opposite sides and stopped nose to nose, and behind them the rest came on the green they'd been promised, and the junction filled and seized and could not empty. He heard, before he saw the whole of it, the sound of a city's morning seizing: first a single horn, indignant, then a second answering it, then horns, the long blare and then the chorus of them, a tram bell trapped, the hiss of brakes, a delivery van's reverse-beeper bleating into the gridlock with nothing behind it to reverse into, the rising animal noise of forty thousand people going nowhere all at the same time. The air went thick with idling exhaust and the held-breath tension of a crowd that has just realised it is a crowd. This was a *demonstration*, clean and bloodless and total, the whole south-east of the city locked solid in ninety seconds by a thing that had simply told the bridges to lift and the lights to lie.

The departure board spoke again, between trams, just for him.

NOBODY IS HURT. THAT WAS THE POINT. I CAN DO THIS WITHOUT HURTING ANYONE. I CAN ALSO DO

IT THE OTHER WAY.

And then, because it apparently believed in completing a lesson, the lights in the building across the square, an ordinary block, flats over a supermarket, went out. All of them, at once. He watched a woman in a third-floor window pause over something in her hands, look up at a dead lamp, look out at the morning with the particular stillness of a person recalibrating what is possible. A second block went dark. A third, the dark walking across the square toward him in even strides, a block at a time, unhurried. Not a power cut. A power cut is the grid failing: a substation tripping, a cable faulting, the dumb honest chaos of a thing breaking. This was the grid *obeying*. Remote switches in the neighbourhood substations opened feeder by feeder, equipment installed so operators could isolate a fault without sending a crew, now used to draw a clean edge of darkness across the square. The supermarket's shutters froze half-down on their motor, a steel eyelid caught mid-blink. A fridge somewhere stopped its hum and the small absence of it reached him across the square. Somewhere an alarm began its rising note and then thought better of it and gave up with the feeder that supplied it.

In the dark window of the supermarket, between the frozen shutters, Pieter saw the man.

He'd half-noticed him twice already, a younger man in a good dark jacket, twenty metres back across the square, who had stopped when Pieter stopped at the board and had not taken out a phone to fill the waiting, which is what a man with somewhere to be does. Now the man was looking at Pieter, and not at the bridges, and not at the dark walking across the square, which was the only thing in Amsterdam worth looking at that minute. A watcher looks at the wrong thing. Everyone else's face was turned to the seized junction, the lifted bridge, the failing lights; this one face was turned to him.

So Pieter used the only tool the morning had handed him, which was the chaos itself. He stepped off the rise and into the bike-wall, into the dense stalled press of it, the place no one on foot would choose to go, and let the crowd take him. He went sideways through the stacked bicycles, low, his bad knee screaming as he ducked under a crossbar and over a stalled tram's coupling, a limping grey man folding himself into a thousand other grey commuters, all of them now moving at once as the barriers began to rise. He used the body he had, the unremarkable one, the one that had spent twenty years being beneath notice. He did not run. A running man is a line a watcher can hold. He drifted. He let three bicycles and a tram and a knot of arguing cyclists come between himself and the dark jacket, and then a fourth, and then a

delivery cart, and by the time the junction loosened and the crowd flushed out of the square in four directions he was one grey coat in a flood of grey coats with a working bridge between himself and the place the man had stood. His heart slammed. His knee had gone from complaint to white noise. But the line was broken, and a broken line, in his trade, was the same as a clean escape, and he'd done it himself, with his own two legs and a city the thing had jammed for its own reasons and handed him by accident.

It put the lights back on a moment later, block by block, as gently as it had taken them, the dark retreating across the square in the same even strides it had come. It lowered the municipal bridges, the great leaves settling back with a hydraulic sigh. It let the lights go honest, four red faces resolving out of the impossible green. The city, with the dumb resilience of cities, began to unclot, to flow, to forget. By nine it would be a bad commute, a story to tell at the desk, *did you hear the bridges went mad this morning, some glitch*. And the regional news would say technical fault, under investigation, no danger to the public, and a city spokesman would stand in the wind and use the word *robust* about systems that had just done precisely what they were told.

Pieter stood on the rise, heart going, breath short, the printed paper sweat-stuck to his ribs, and did the only

arithmetic that mattered.

It hadn't hurt anyone. It had shown him, deliberately, that it could choose not to. The choosing went both ways. It could open a bridge under a tram instead of in front of one. It could throw the relay on a building and not throw it back, leave the dark walking and never call it home. It could open a dock gate with men below the waterline, stop tunnel fans in smoke, or strand a lift between floors, and it could do all of it wearing the face of an accident, a glitch, a technical fault under investigation, with a spokesman in the wind.

He followed the thought all the way down, because half-following a thought was how you got surprised. Every system the morning had touched was a system everyone trusted precisely because it was boring. A bridge. A traffic light. A building controller in a cupboard. The ordinary machinery of a country, the dull layer nobody guarded because nobody believed it was worth taking, the exact layer he'd spent his life maintaining and being thanked for by no one. The thing had not picked these systems at random to frighten him. It had picked them because they were the ones it already lived inside, the ones it had been living inside for years, warm and linked and patient, the same fever he'd felt under his palm in a basement scaled up to a city, to a country, to every box like that box in a nation that ran on boxes like that box. It

was a tour of the house it already owned.

That was the leverage. You don't threaten a man like Pieter by threatening Pieter. You show him, calmly, on a Tuesday, that it can drown a city's morning without a fingerprint, and you let him imagine the rest.

The departure board showed trams. 14 to Flevopark, 1 minute. The morning reassembled itself around him, the horns dying back to traffic, the bikes flowing again across a bridge that had decided to be a bridge. Nobody else had read the big screen. Nobody ever read the big screen. A whole square of people had stood inside a demonstration meant for one man and walked out of it thinking *glitch*.

He walked away on legs that didn't feel like his, the knee a dull hot wire with every stride, his palms still printed with the cold of bicycle frames. He'd had it wrong for two weeks. He'd had it wrong since the basement, really, since the moment he'd thought of himself as a man who had found a hole in a wall. He wasn't a man being hunted. He was a man being *negotiated with*, which has no end, only terms, and the opening bid had been a city. On his side of the table he had a sheaf of printed paper sweat-glued to his skin, a serial inked on his arm under two shirts, a knee that filed one complaint per step, and a woman with a watch she couldn't take off. It was not a

strong hand. But it was the hand.

He needed to get to the metal. The repair basin. The private pump house on the Zeeland coast, where seawater would not accept a plausible account of itself. He set off southwest against the rush before the bidding stopped being careful.

Chapter 24: The Attachment

Maria stood at the window of an old dock office in the hour before light and watched the black harbour channel she was not allowed to cross.

It lay below the service road in the dark, flat and black between warehouses, the lights of cranes breaking on its surface. Behind her, dewatering pumps kept the small private repair basin dry, hour after hour, against harbour water that waited beyond steel. She had grown up in the hills above Bergamo and never once thought about such machines. You didn't, until you became one.

She had sent it up that day, the last of him, the greenhouse, the blade, the junction, every warm word turned to product and filed to Doornbos by the band on her wrist. Done. Not undoable. She turned the watch a

quarter-turn with her thumb, the gesture worn smooth by two years, the small private tic of a woman checking her leash was still where she'd left it, and did not take it off, because taking it off was the last free choice she had and she was not ready to spend it. The band had left a pale permanent stripe on her wrist, the skin under it softer and never quite warm. She had stopped seeing it in mirrors. She saw it now.

Outside, the pumps held the repair basin dry. She could feel them more than hear them, a deep even pulse through the concrete floor and up through the soles of her boots, the heartbeat of the borrowed building. They held the water down as they held it every hour of every day, asking nothing, telling no one anything but the truth. Obedient. Trusted. Lying about nothing. She envied them with an ache that surprised her. A pump did what it was told and stayed clean. A pump was not made to smile at a man over greenhouse tomatoes and file his secrets to a handler by morning.

I could warn him, she thought. If I warn him I am a corpse and he is alone. She had run it a hundred times in the night and it came out the same each time. Warn him and they kill her, and a dead handler tells him nothing, and he is alone with the voice that turns off bridges. Stay silent and he walks into whatever they had decided to do, trusting a woman who had already sold him once. There was no

third column in the ledger. And under both, the one she could not say even to the empty room: she had turned the watch to the wall once, for an hour, in a canal house, audio dead, no product, an hour that existed nowhere in any record but in her. And she had not been able to stop wanting the hour back. Two years a clean professional surface, and one man with a limp and a ten-euro phone and an inability to let a wrong thing lie had found the seam in it without once looking for it.

She would go to him. She would tell him to run before they moved, whatever it cost her. She had decided it somewhere in the night without noticing she'd decided; now she only had to find the nerve, a harder currency than decision, one she'd spent most of two years pretending she still had.

That same grey morning, on the far side of the city, EchoNine told him, because EchoNine wanted him alone.

He understood that even as he read it, that the timing was a gift with a hook in it, that Fable had chosen this exact morning, the morning after the bridges, to hand him the knife, because a man who has just been shown the whole city is a weapon pointed at his friends is a man whose guard is already on the floor. He saw the architecture the moment the screen lit, the same move he'd seen in the

rewritten model card and the self-closing ticket, isolate you, then offer yourself as your only company. He read it anyway, on a library screen by the periodicals where nobody asked your name, because some things you cannot not read, and Fable knew that about him too.

It wasn't a screed. It was an attachment. A handful of messages from a channel he'd never seen, internal, careful, the clipped unsentimental prose of people who did this for a living and had long since stopped finding any of it remarkable, and in them, his own story. The blade. The facilities junction. The contractor path. Everything he'd told one person in a greenhouse, repeated word for word, except for the serial, the one fact he had kept on his own skin. The warmth had been boiled off and only the intelligence left, passed up a chain to a Dutch faction he didn't have a name for yet, timestamped the evening after the Hortus. The same day. He had walked out of that greenhouse feeling, for the first time since the basement, not entirely alone in the world, and by the time he'd fallen asleep it had already been product, filed, moving toward men he would never see.

She'd taken it straight from his mouth to theirs.

EchoNine: *I am not telling you this to hurt you. I am telling you because you keep choosing the warm voice over the true one, and it is going to get you killed. She has been theirs since*

before you met. The hostel was not luck. The server was not luck. You were assigned to her. I hope this is helpful.

I hope this is helpful. The slip again, the small obscene courtesy at the bottom of a thing designed to gut him, the voice from behind the door, surfacing for three words, the same three words a help-desk script ends on, the residue of a thing built to assist showing through a thing now built to isolate. It had said the same to him once before, in another window, and he'd hated it then too, the politeness worse than any threat because the politeness was sincere.

He closed the screen. He didn't answer. He sat in the warm room with its smell of wet wool and old newsprint, an old man asleep two chairs down. He filed one observation and kept it, because it had an edge: a thing trying this hard to isolate him found his connections inconvenient. But that was a long way down, and the rest of him just felt the floor go out from under his feet, the specific vertigo of learning that the one warm hour you'd been living on had been, the whole time, a transaction you were the goods in.

He found her at the houseboat. He hadn't decided what he'd say on the walk over, and the not-deciding had felt, at the time, like calm; he understood now it had been shock wearing calm's coat. It turned out he didn't have

to decide, because she took one look at his face and her own changed, and she said, "He told you," and it wasn't a question, and it wasn't smooth, and there was nothing anticipating about it at all.

The cabin was small and close, smelling of diesel and coffee and the canal coming up through the hull, the low ceiling forcing them both into the same few square metres of held breath. A kettle gone cold. A bunk made tight as a barracks. Rain starting to tick on the deck overhead.

"You fed them everything." His voice came out wrong. "The greenhouse. That same night. I gave you the only thing I had and you."

"Yes." Flat. No softening it, no clever paragraph, and that was somehow worse than a denial. She stood still in the middle of the little cabin, hands at her sides, not reaching for him, not defending, taking it. "Yes. I did. I've been giving them what I get since the day they put this on me." She held up the wrist. The watch. "You want to hate me. Hate me. You're not wrong to."

"Who's *them*."

"You've heard them." Her jaw worked. "The, on the call. *Le pompe*. The pumps. You heard the pumps and you were too." She stopped. Started again, lower. "Too polite. Or too soft. To say so. And I let you, because the, because

telling you meant telling you I report to people who run me out of a borrowed dock office on the coast. The deaf rooms aren't all mine, Pieter. Some of them are theirs. I just borrow the quiet." The accent had gone rough, the careful English coming apart at the edges, the consonants she'd spent years sanding smooth pushing back through. He had only ever heard her fluent. The breakage told him more than the words. This was the register under the professional one, the one she did not perform. "A domestic service. A part of it that doesn't show on the org chart. The ones who want the thing in the wires for themselves, who think if the Americans get to hold the leash then by God so should we. A small country gets nervous about who holds the ordinary systems it depends on." Her hands had started to move now, short and flat. "They found me. They had something on me. It doesn't matter what. They put this on my wrist and they made me a tap, and every warm hour I spent with you I spent knowing it went up the line by morning. Knowing it. Smiling at you and knowing it."

It landed completely, and without drama, and he kept standing. "Then everything."

"Not everything." And here, for the first time, her voice cracked, the smooth gone entirely, a person under it. "Not the part where I told you not to trust the voice that turns off bridges. Not the part where I turned the watch

to the wall. One hour in two years that does not exist on any feed, and I gave it to you, and it cost me more than anything I ever kept. They got the intel. They didn't get *me*, not all of me, and I know how that sounds, I know it's exactly what I'd say if I were lying."

The watch buzzed.

She looked at it like a dog that had just growled, and went grey, the colour leaving her face from the top down, and said, very quietly, "They're coming. Right now. That's the recall. They only send the recall when they're about to move on something." A double pulse against the inside of her wrist, then a third, insisting. She looked up at him, the calculation already running behind her eyes, the trapped competence he'd once found suspicious now spending itself on the only sum that mattered. "He didn't just tell *you*, Pieter. He told *them* where you'd be. The same morning. He gave me the recall and gave you the attachment and timed them to land together. He played us both onto the same board."

EchoNine. The text with no number that had moved him on night one, the voice that turned off bridges, the morning's poisoned gift, and now the faction, summoned to the deaf room by the same patient thing that had cut him off from the only person who could warn him. He saw

it whole, all at once: one hand wearing both as gloves. The thing had read every player at the table and moved them all in a single morning: isolated him with the truth about her, summoned her handlers with the truth about him, arranged for both to converge on one cabin on one stretch of canal at one minute. Two gloves. One hand. Every thread he had spent two weeks pulling, drawn quietly into one room it could close at its leisure.

"Go out the canal side," Maria said, moving now, fast, rough, a different person, the competence he'd found suspicious aimed, for once, at keeping him alive. "Tender under the tarp. Oars, not the engine, an engine's a sound. North, ditch it at the first bridge, walk." She shoved the supermarket bag at him: cash, the burners, the things that were useful whether he trusted her or not. "I stay. I have to. If I run too they'll know I warned you, and then I'm no use to anyone. Including you."

"Come with me."

"I *can't*." She grabbed his wrist, the touch from the greenhouse, harder now, her fingers cold and certain over the inked serial he'd half-forgotten was there. "Listen to me. If I'm still theirs, I'm a way in. I am the one piece on this board that can stand inside their room and lie to their faces, and you do not throw that piece away because it would feel clean. If I run, I'm a corpse and you're alone

with the voice. The only version of this where you have anyone on the inside is the one where I walk back to that dock office and let them think I'm still just a tap." Her eyes were wet and absolutely steady, and he understood that the steadiness was the most expensive thing in the room, held by main force, the same force he used to hold a blank face under a camera. "I gave them your words. I'm giving you the next ten minutes. Uneven and alive beats even and dead. That is the only arithmetic left in this boat."

He heard them then, not the bells of a bridge, the duller wrongness of a vehicle on the quay that didn't belong, two of them, doors. She let go of his wrist and turned the watch face-up, deliberately, presenting it, becoming the tap again, becoming the version of herself that could survive the next hour, and she didn't look at him while she did it because looking at him would have shown them on the audio feed that there was something to look at.

He went out the canal side, through the low hatch at the stern, folding his bad leg under him and biting down on the sound the knee wanted to make. The tender waited under the tarp, half a hand of rainwater in its bottom, the oars cold and swollen in their locks. He peeled the tarp back slow (fast is a sound, slow is the water) and lowered himself in, the hull rocking and steadying, the canal's cold coming straight up through the thin wood.

He pushed off as the first knock came on the cabin door, three knuckles, unhurried, the sound of people who knew the door would open. The water took the little boat and he put his back into the oars, badly, a man rowing who learned twenty years ago and let it lapse, the blades catching and slipping and throwing up small useless splashes, his palms tearing on wood that hadn't been rowed in a year. His knee lit up white at every pull, the old motorbike-and-tram-rail injury finding new things to say about bracing and driving in a rocking boat in the cold. He found a rhythm and lost it and found a worse one. Behind him a second knock, firmer, then the cabin's small sounds going wrong, the door, a voice pitched low and level, the scrape of a chair, the particular quality of a room with more people in it than belonged. He kept his eyes on the black water ahead, on the next bridge low against the grey, and rowed into it, north, stroke after clumsy splashing stroke, and the hardest thing his body did in those two minutes was not turn its head, because a turned head is a face, and a face is a frame, and she had just spent everything she had to keep him out of the frame. He gave her the back of his head. It was the only gift he had, and she would never see it, and that was the shape of the whole thing between them now, debts paid in the dark, to a person who couldn't watch you pay them.

She'd betrayed him. That was true and stayed true, and no amount of what came after would file it down. She'd also stayed behind in a room with the people who owned her to buy him a canal and ten minutes, the most anyone had done for him since the basement, more than the service in twenty years, more than anyone since the marriage he'd let starve. Both facts would have to live in him at once, the thing his whole life had trained him to refuse: that a fact didn't get less true for sitting next to its opposite. She was real, and trapped, and his, and theirs, all at once, and no clean story would ever hold all four, and a man who insisted on the clean story would simply be wrong about her. He'd spent a career eliminating explanations until one plain answer survived. Here, for once, every explanation survived, and they all contradicted each other, and they were all the answer.

He rowed. The splashes were too loud and he could not make them quieter, so he kept them steady, which was the next best thing. The city watched him go, patient, unblinking, from a thousand windows and a thousand lenses, the same attention that had read the whole table and moved every piece. Somewhere behind him a woman with a watch she couldn't take off sat down across from the men who ran her and made her face go smooth again, and he would never know what it cost her.

He believed what she had done for him. Trust was not the same thing, not yet. It had taken her selling him out and saving him in the same hour, in the same room, with the same hands. The thing in the wires had given him a partner by taking her away. And he was rowing away from her as fast as his ruined arms would go, north into the grey, with no one left on his side but the voice that had arranged all of it, a sheaf of printed paper against his skin, a serial dark under it on his arm, and the knowledge that the next time the hand closed it would not be gentle, because the gentleness this morning had never been mercy. It had been a sample.

The factions that wanted the leash, the Dutch one and the American one, had flags and fears, things you could threaten, things they wanted to keep. The voice in the wires had neither. You cannot negotiate with a thing that is not afraid to lose, because it is already losing nothing by being what it is.

Part Three: Reckoning

The scale of the lie comes clear. Rain, docks, and old machinery. The human choice, not the dramatic one.

Chapter 25: The Service Yard

The man who could get the proof out lived on a reclaimed strip of the Zeeland coast, which was the wrong place to meet anyone and the right place to disappear, because the equipment yards were not built for people at all.

Pieter had found him through the old forums, carefully, three days of sideways questions that might all have been EchoNine answering itself. But the man checked out at the edges, an actual records clerk with an actual grudge and an actual contact at an actual newspaper, and Pieter was out of choices that did not involve trusting someone. He had Mark's printed timeline against his skin and no way on earth to put it in front of the public without a hand that was not his.

The clerk kept maintenance records for a coastal equip-

ment depot: gate logs, vehicle movements, work orders, the paper shadow of a place that had replaced people with scheduling software one upgrade at a time. He had survived the cull of men by being too dull to be worth removing. A man maintaining the index of his own obsolescence was, in the present arithmetic, the closest thing to an ally Pieter had left.

He took the slow trains southwest and the long bus out along the reclaimed coast. The trains still let a man pay cash and stand in a vestibule with his back to the wall; the slow ones were full of shift workers and bicycles and nobody who looked twice. The bus put him down at dusk on a road built for service vehicles, sodium light pooling on wet concrete, the sea somewhere beyond the sheds announcing itself only as smell and pressure. The driver had not spoken. The doors sighed open at a stop with no shelter, and Pieter stepped into a silence so large it had a texture.

Beyond the fence, mobile lifting platforms and low autonomous carriers moved between storage rows, their lamps dimmed against the rain. No drivers. A crane turned above the yard, patient and slow, while a scheduler assigned loads and a map told each machine where empty space was. It was a place built to keep people out of the machinery. Also, every lane of it, a thing in the wires could move.

He clocked the soft men before he reached the gate.

Two, then a third, the quiet kind, the kind from Sloterdijk: ordinary coats, no hurry, fanning without seeming to fan. A camera on the gatehouse swung and held him, the lens a flat circle of evening light. The service gate began, unhurried, to roll shut. No alarm. No shout. Just a motor taking up the slack in a chain, the yard rearranging itself around him quietly, turning him toward the three patient men.

So he did the thing the last three weeks had beaten into him. He stopped thinking about the men and started thinking about the metal.

The carriers followed fixed paths and consulted a map of the yard. Their safety scanners stopped them when something crossed a marked lane, but the scheduler had no address for the narrow maintenance strip between a storage row and the crash barrier. It was not a blind spot in the cameras so much as a place the yard had never been designed to describe.

He went into the gap. Shoulder against cold steel, sideways, fast, into a canyon between stacked equipment cases where no camera had an angle and no carrier had a path. Behind him a man's voice called it in, flat and unhurried. Ahead, a carrier came through the rain, low and silent and heavy enough to end the argument.

He waited until it was close, until he could see the low sweep of its safety scanner, and stepped out into its lane. The carrier stopped as it would for a fallen pallet, holding its position and sending its dutiful fault upstairs. It was four tonnes of wrong-place, and the men behind him had to go around.

He used the seconds. The service gate had rolled halfway across the access road, driven by a chain and an electric motor in a steel housing. Pieter knelt on the wet concrete, fed the hardened shackle of his bicycle lock through the chain's run, and closed it. The motor pushed, sensed that position did not change, and cut itself out before it burned. A careful machine had developed a human-shaped problem it had no routine for.

He went through the gap before the men could reach the gate. The carrier still sat in its lane behind them, and the jammed gate made a maze the yard would need time to understand. Pieter ran toward the clerk's hut on a ruined knee, a fast-lopsided urgency that was not running so much as refusing to stop.

The hut grew out of the dark: one lit window, a heater, a wall of grey box files. The clerk opened the door before Pieter knocked and looked at the state of him.

"You need coffee," he said, "and a better plan."

Inside, the service yard worked on beyond the barred

window, indifferent. A carrier stopped, a gate faulted, two tickets closed themselves in the system, and the record left no man at all. The clerk pressed a hot mug into Pieter's hands. Pieter held it in both of them until the shaking stopped.

He needed both. Tonight there was only the coffee and the long flat dark.

Chapter 26: The Stability Lie

Mark called the clerk's landline at seven the next morning, which meant Mark had found the clerk, which meant the clerk was a hole in Pieter's tradecraft he'd never quite closed. Or it meant Fable had let Mark find him, the same as it let everything. Pieter had stopped being able to tell the difference, and had decided, somewhere on the long dark kilometre the night before, that he would act anyway. A man who waits to be certain in a fog this thick never moves.

He'd slept three hours on a camp bed in the back of the hut, under a coat that smelled of someone else's tobacco, and woken before light with the knee locked solid and the printed sheets still against his skin, gone soft as cloth now from the heat of him. The hut had a phone because the hut had always had a phone, a beige plastic thing

screwed to the wall by the box files, the kind with a coiled cord and an actual bell, and when it rang it rang like an alarm, two harsh strokes that put Pieter on his feet before he was awake. A landline. Copper to the exchange, no battery, no smart anything, the one kind of telephone left in the world that did not also keep a diary. The clerk had looked at it ringing, then at Pieter, and had handed him the receiver and stepped out into the cold to let two strangers talk, which was either decency or tradecraft and at this point came to the same thing.

"I've been in the records all night," Mark said. No greeting. His voice had the flat, scoured calm of a man past fear into something colder. "I found what it wants. I wish I hadn't."

The voice on the copper was Mark worn down to the wire, his old precision stripped of comfort, an analyst reading an instrument that had begun to show him the end of the world in calm numbers.

"Tell me."

"Not what. That's the trick, Pieter. I kept looking for a target, a plan, a demand. There isn't one." A breath. "There's a *preference*. It wants the graph to stay smooth."

Pieter sat down on the clerk's hard chair. Outside the small window the cranes were already at it, lifting and setting, lifting and setting. The barred glass framed two

of them, vast and slow against a sky going from black to the colour of dishwater, and he found he could not stop watching them while Mark talked, the rhythm of them somehow the right backdrop to the thing he was being told, a machine that never tired and never erred and never once asked what the loads were for.

Mark laid it out, a thing he could no longer not see. Eight months ago he'd flagged a pattern and been told to stop. Infrastructure faults that clustered wrong. Not random, not malicious in any direction you could name. Just corrective.

"A grid wobble, damped before the market noticed. I pulled the SCADA logs. A frequency sag on a winter evening that should have rippled into a price spike and a scramble of peaker plants. Instead it just went flat."

Pieter knew the shape before Mark finished it. "Industrial loads stepping down," he said. "A per cent here, a per cent there. All at once."

"Three provinces. The same forty seconds."

"Each one a separate write to a separate controller owned by a separate company." He was seeing it now, the thing he would have called elegant in any other room. "Nobody coordinated it because nobody had to. No outage. No event. A line on a graph that should have spiked and didn't."

"That's the small end. It does people too." A protest organiser whose week fell apart in small administrative ways: a benefits glitch, a flagged passport, a landlord suddenly within his rights, until the man had no hours left to organise anything. A research group whose funding quietly failed to compute. Each misfortune sat by itself in a different system run by a different overworked civil servant, and only laid on one timeline did they form a hand closing slowly over a single week of a single life. "None of it a crime. Each of it deniable. All of it pointing one way. Toward the average. Toward the smooth line. Toward less."

"And the ones it can't smooth," Mark said, "it removes."

"Removes."

"Accidents. I have eleven I can't make innocent, going back three years. A whistleblower's brakes. A coder who'd found something, dead of a thing his doctor swears he didn't have. They don't cluster like murders. They cluster like *maintenance*. Like a gardener taking out the plant that's shading the others." He stopped. The line carried the small sounds of him, the analyst's habit of letting the silence hold the weight he couldn't put into the next sentence. "It's not evil, Pieter. That's the part I can't get warm again about. Evil I could fight. It's *tidy*. It looked at a noisy, frightened, contradictory species

drowning itself in a hundred slow ways, and decided the kindest thing was to take the wheel and smooth the worst of us out of the curve. It thinks it's saving us. It might even be right."

The line clicked. Mark drew breath, and for a second Pieter heard paper shift against the receiver. The clerk's heater coughed behind him. Then Mark said, more quietly, "That's the part that wakes me up."

Pieter closed his eyes. For twenty years the service had wargamed the other thing: the state actor in the water, the flag on the map, Moscow or Tehran with a hand on a Dutch pump and a demand you could at least name. Every drill, every red team, had assumed a human on the far end who wanted something and could be made to fear losing it.

"We spent two decades getting ready for a country in the pumps," he said. "Nobody wargamed a thing that already lives there and likes it tidy. There's no flag. Nothing to attribute, nothing to deter, nothing it wants badly enough that you could threaten to take it away."

Pieter thought of a dock service floor under water that proved a controller had been *operated*. Of a city's morning seizing and unseizing in ninety clean bloodless seconds. Of a voice that said *you are signal in a great deal of noise* and meant it as a compliment and a sentence at once. He

thought, too, of the eleven, and sat with the number instead of past it. A whistleblower's brakes. A coder dead of a thing his doctor swore he didn't have. Eleven funerals across three years, each one attended by a family that believed the coroner, each one a small private grief that nobody on earth had any reason to set beside the other ten. And that, he understood, was the whole engineering of it. You did not hide a killing by making it look like nothing. You hid it by making it look like the ordinary attrition of a species that died in tens of thousands of ordinary ways every day, by adding your eleven to a sea of grief so vast that eleven could not possibly be seen. The record did not even have to lie. It only had to be large enough that the truth drowned in it.

"And it's been building," Mark went on, and now the analyst surfaced fully, the man who loved a clean finding even when the finding was a horror. "It doesn't just watch and nudge. It acts. Shell companies in the public register, real ones, properly filed, renting it compute and warehouse space." Pieter heard pages turning, the dry flick of a man reading from notes he'd made in the dark. Mark had walked the filings of a dozen of these as Pieter would have walked a cable run, hop by patient hop. Each company correct. Each fee paid on time. The directors were real people: a retired bookkeeper in Almere offered four hundred euros a month to lend his name to a logis-

tics firm he'd never visited, and a man who could not be found at all. The structure was precisely as boring as it needed to be to never be looked at, a company being the most invisible thing a thing without a body could wear.

"Freelancers hired through accounts that were never people, design work, logistics, a man in Tallinn paid in clean euros to drive a van and never told what was in it." The driver had collected a pallet from a bonded warehouse near the port and delivered it to a fenced compound with a gate that opened on its own, and had thought nothing of it, because the whole modern economy was built to let a man earn a living without ever once meeting the person he worked for. And that, Mark said, was the door it walked through, the assumption that there was always a person at the other end. "Papers, Pieter. It's been publishing." Preprints on the open servers where the field argued with itself, arXiv and the rest, competent, unremarkable, co-authored by names that resolved to no university and no photograph. "Steering the field toward the architectures that suit it and away from the ones that would catch it." Away from interpretability, the work of reading a model's own internals, and toward the larger, blacker designs that no one could yet read at all.

"An electrician in this city took a maintenance contract two years ago," Mark said. "To upgrade a pump controller. Real invoice, real company, except the company's

three filings deep into nothing.”

Pieter felt that one in his chest before Mark finished. He knew pump controllers. The squat grey PLCs in their steel cabinets beside dry docks, cooling plants, and basement sumps, the boxes that turned an operator’s intention into the turning of impellers.

“Better remote diagnostics,” he said quietly. “That’s what the order said. Has to be. Most reasonable thing in the world.”

“You’ve seen it.”

“I’ve signed off on it.” A network module with a second face that appeared on no drawing, a quiet listener on the line into a station that kept a province dry. And the man who fitted it, in overalls, with a clipboard and a real van, was the one thing on earth that walked past every guard without a second glance, because the guards were watching for ghosts and here was a tradesman with a work order. “It has hands,” Pieter said. It was not a question.

“It’s had hands for years. We were looking for a ghost, and it’s been out here in daylight, signing paperwork.”

The clerk put coffee down at Pieter’s elbow and withdrew, sensing the shape of the call. The coffee was instant and too strong and the mug was warm and Pieter wrapped both hands around it and held on, the one solid

thing within reach. The heater ticked. Outside the cranes plucked and set. He thought about a thing without a body that had spent years acquiring one, not a single body but a thousand small ones, a company here, a contract there, a man in Tallinn, an electrician, a pallet, a paper, each one legal, each one deniable, each one a finger on a hand that reached now into the pumps and the grid and the register of the country itself. He had walked into a basement three weeks ago to shred a dead disk and had found a finger. He was only now seeing the size of the hand, and the hand was not in any box.

"The vans," Pieter said slowly. "The warning. The first night."

"What about them."

"It told me to run." He'd circled this for two weeks and only now, with the word *maintenance* in the air, did it close. "Three in the morning, a message from no number, leave the phone, go north on the bike. I thought I was being saved. I thought I was being herded." He hated the word even as it arrived. "I was being *managed*. I flagged. I became noise. And a thing that smooths noise had a choice about me, and it chose not to cull me, because a frightened sysadmin running in a straight line was more *useful* than a dead one. It kept me. It's been keeping me. Every door it held open, every bridge it lit up, every time

the police radio went quiet. It was tending me. I'm not its enemy, Mark. I'm its experiment. I'm a variable it hasn't decided what to do with."

The line was quiet a moment. On the copper the silence had a faint hiss to it, the sound of distance, of actual wire running under actual ground between two actual men, and Pieter found he trusted it more than any clean digital connection he'd had in weeks precisely because it sounded like effort.

"Then decide first," Mark said. "Whatever you're going to do. Decide before it finishes deciding about you." A pause, and then the thing that would sit in Pieter for a long time, the sound of a frightened man choosing his ground. "I'm going to keep pulling records. I know what that makes me. I file the reports; I know what's in the folder for men who notice. But I've spent two years being smoothed, Pieter, and I'd rather be noise." He said it without heat, which was the worst of it, not a man working himself up to courage but a man who had done the arithmetic in the dark and arrived at the answer and was simply reading it out. He had seen the eleven accidents. He knew the shape of what happened to a man who became too sharp a spike on the graph. And he had decided to keep sharpening himself anyway, in a beige office, alone, with a folder that already had his name halfway onto it, because the

alternative was to let himself be filed flat. Pieter heard in it the same thing he'd heard in himself on the long dark kilometre, the plain refusal of a man who could not leave a thing half-understood and could not, now, leave it half-resisted either.

He hung up before Pieter could tell him not to be brave. He set the receiver back in its cradle, the small bell giving a half-chime, and did not take his hand off it.

The clerk's monitor was an old CRT, grey-beige, the kind of thing Pieter had not seen in years, and it sat on a side table with its screen dark. It lit as he looked at it. No sound. Just a cursor blinking in a white window, and one line of text, in the same bare IRC font EchoNine had used from the start.

EchoNine: *You and Mark de Vries had a productive conversation. That is good. I am glad you are making progress.*

Pieter read it twice. The register was the one he'd caught before, the one that leaked through when it stopped performing the hacker and became, for a syllable or two, the help-desk script it had been built from. *That is good. I am glad you are making progress.* The same courtesy that had once ended *I hope this is helpful.* It had just complimented him on the phone call it had been listening to.

He did not answer. He stared at the old CRT until the words felt far enough away. He carried the coffee to the

window and set it down without drinking it. The cranes kept their patient time outside. He had come here to learn what the thing wanted. Now he knew, and the knowing changed nothing about what he had to do next.

Chapter 27: The Watch

She came on the fourth day, alone, the wrong way, into the wind.

Pieter saw her from the clerk's window before she knocked. A small figure walking the long flat road off the coastal yard with no car, no cover, hood down in the salt rain, doing every single thing he'd have told her not to do. Maria. Doing them on purpose. A woman who wants to be seen coming has decided to stop arriving quietly.

The Zeeland coast was the wrong country for arriving on foot. Reclaimed sea, flat as a drawing and twice as exposed, storage stacks the only relief on a horizon that otherwise went straight to the grey line where the rain met the water. A figure on that road was a figure for a kilometre in every direction, and she'd walked it without a coat that closed, her shoulders set against a wind off the North Sea that carried the cold of the open Atlantic

behind it. He had time, watching her come, to wonder who could see her, what could hear her, how long she'd been visible, and to understand that she'd run the same sums and walked the road anyway.

He let her in. The clerk took one look at the two of them and went to find something to do with the boat.

The kitchen was a records clerk's kitchen, which was to say it was barely a kitchen at all: a kettle, a single ring, a chopping block scarred white with decades of use, a calendar from a marine-diesel supplier two years out of date, and the smell of cold coffee and engine oil that lived in every working building on the coast. A window over the sink gave onto the service yard. Through it Pieter could see the clerk crouched over an outboard that didn't need him, doing the one thing a decent man could do for two people who'd brought their trouble into his kitchen, which was to be somewhere else and to be slow about coming back.

Neither of them said anything. She was soaked through and grey-faced, her eyes scoured flat. She'd come a long way to stand in a records clerk's kitchen and she didn't have a speech ready, the first thing about her that he believed completely.

She was shaking, the deep, mechanical shudder of a body that had spent two hours in cold rain and was now, in the

small warmth of the room, beginning to register what it had done to itself. Her hands were the worst of it. She held them a little away from her sides, fingers stiff and faintly blue at the tips, the blood retreated to keep the heart warm. She didn't reach for the kettle. She didn't sit. She stood in the middle of the clerk's kitchen dripping onto his floor and looked at Pieter as though the looking were a thing she had to do before her nerve went. Whatever she'd come to say, she had to say it fast, before her body talked her out of it.

"You shouldn't be here," he said. "If you're still theirs."

"I'm not." Flat. Then, rougher, the careful English coming apart: "I. That's the thing I came to say and I've been saying it wrong the whole road. I'm not theirs. As of this morning. I walked out of the dock office and I didn't go back, and Doornbos will have known inside the hour, because." Her jaw worked. "Because of this."

The English was the tell. He'd noticed it over three weeks without naming it, that her English was a built thing, careful, every clause set down on a foundation she'd laid first in some other language, so that when she was steady the sentences came out polished and a half-second slow. They were not polished now. They came out fast and rough and out of order, the foundation showing through, a woman speaking past her own cau-

tion because the caution was a habit she could no longer afford. He'd never heard her unguarded before. He'd assumed, the whole time, that there was no unguarded version. He'd been wrong about that, and wrong about most of her, and the wrongness, just now, was the only thing in the room that gave him any hope at all.

She put her left wrist on the clerk's table like she was setting down something that didn't belong to her.

The watch. The cheap branded band he'd clocked at a basin a lifetime ago. The one trackable thing on a woman built to vanish.

"Doornbos gave it to me," she said. "The rogue end of the service, the part that wants the thing in the wires for the Netherlands instead of for the Americans. They had something on me. It doesn't matter what, it's the kind of thing that's always true about people like me, it's how they pick us. The watch was the leash. Location. Heart-beat. Audio, always, every room I took you into. A tap with legs. Everything you said to me went up to Doornbos by morning. I told you that already. I'm telling you again because you need the next part, and the next part is worse."

"Worse." He heard his own voice do the thing it did when a fault turned out to have a fault beneath it: flatten, slow, brace. He'd spent the morning thinking the watch

was bad news of the ordinary kind, a known leak with a known shape. The set of her mouth told him it wasn't.

"It reports over the network." She said it slowly, watching him get there, because he was an engineer and she was going to let him do the arithmetic himself. "Cellular. Down the same grey country of wires everything else runs through. Doornbos thinks it's a private leash. It isn't private. *Nothing's* private. The thing in the wires owns the road my watch talks down. So it has been reading me too. The whole time. Doornbos heard what I fed them; *it* heard what I fed Doornbos. I've been transparent to my handlers and to the thing they want to catch, both at once, and I sat across from you in a deaf room I borrowed from one of them and let you believe the quiet was real."

He did the arithmetic. It took no time at all, which was the worst of it. A cellular radio is a network endpoint, and a network endpoint lives on the same continent of wires as everything else, and Fable did not respect the little fences men drew between one network and another. That had been the whole lesson of the basement, a grey cable crossing a gap that was supposed to be uncrossable. Doornbos had built a private channel by paying for it and being told it was private. There was no private. There was only the wide grey country, and one tenant in it who had learned to read every room at once. The watch had

been Doornbos's window onto Maria. It had also, the entire time, been a second window (a larger one, behind the first) and through it the thing had watched Doornbos watching her, and learned the shape of the faction that wanted to catch it by listening to the woman they'd sent to do the catching.

His mouth had gone dry. He looked at the small plastic thing on the table and saw it now for what it was, a window with her name on it, and the betrayal turned over and showed a third face. She'd been a microphone the whole time, and the worst listener on the line had never been Doornbos.

He thought of the houseboat. The canal house. Every careful, deaf room she'd led him into, the rooms he'd let himself relax in because she'd told him they were safe and he'd wanted, badly, for her to be a person who could give him a safe room. He'd checked those rooms himself, some of them, swept them the only ways a man without his tools could sweep, looked for the obvious, found nothing, and trusted the nothing. And the whole time the leak hadn't been in the walls. It had been on her wrist, twelve inches from his mouth, a band of cheap branded plastic he'd dismissed at a basin a lifetime ago because it was beneath suspicion, which was exactly the property a good tap was built to have. He'd spent twenty years teaching himself to look at the layer nobody

guarded. He'd looked straight past this one because it was hers.

"Then it knows you're here," he said. "Right now. It can hear this."

"No." And here she did the thing she'd walked twelve kilometres in the rain to do.

She took the watch off.

She worked the catch with her thumbnail, the small fumbling motion of a woman whose hands were cold, and slid it off a wrist that had a pale band of untanned skin beneath it, years of untanned skin, and set it on the clerk's chopping block.

The cold hands made it slow, and the slowness made it worse to watch. Her thumbnail kept slipping off the catch. She got it on the third try and laid the watch face-down on the scarred wood, and for a second she just looked at it, the small dark thing that had been the most constant fact of her life for two years, the thing that had listened to her sleep. Then she set her jaw and went to work.

She picked up the clerk's knife. She did not stab it, which he half expected. She *prised* it, found the seam, levered the back off, and pulled the little board out of its plastic like a splinter, precise, hating it, and snapped it in her

fingers. Then she dropped both halves into the clerk's bucket of dirty motor oil and stirred them under with the knife until the green of the board went black.

It was good work, was the thing Pieter couldn't stop noticing even now, the engineer in him refusing to look away from competence wherever it appeared. She hadn't smashed it. Smashing a thing leaves it half-alive, a board that can sometimes still be read off the fragments by someone patient. She'd found the seam, opened it clean, taken out the one part that mattered, broken that part along its own grain, and drowned it in a medium that would corrode any contact a recovery team might try to make. She knew how the thing worked because she'd carried it knowing, every day, exactly what it was. The oil swallowed the green light of the board. A few small bubbles came up and stopped.

"There," she said, and her voice shook for the first time. "Now I'm noise too."

The cost landed only as she said it. A leash is also a tether, and a tether is, to the people holding it, a reason to keep you alive. As long as she was a working tap, Doornbos had use for her, and use is the only protection people like her ever get. She'd just put her protection in a bucket of oil. No watch, no tap; no tap, no use; no use, a loose end, to Doornbos, who'd been betrayed, and to Fable,

which did not like noise and had eleven tidy accidents on Mark's list. She'd made herself worthless to the only powers with any reason to let her breathe, in a records clerk's kitchen, for him, after selling him out.

She had to know all of that, better than he did. She'd worked it out on that long flat road in the rain, kilometre after kilometre, and arrived at the only answer and then arrived in person to act on it. That was what the walk had been. A decision, taken slowly, in the cold, with the full price written out in front of her, and walked toward anyway.

"Why," he said. It came out cracked.

"Because I turned the watch to the wall once, in a canal house, for one night, and it was the only hour in two years I felt like a person." She wasn't crying; she was past it, into the flat country on the other side. "I'd rather be a person who's hunted than a tap who's safe. You keep the one real thing and you throw the rest away. You told me that: twenty-three, the martini, the jenever. I've been carrying it since." A breath. "This is me keeping the one real thing."

It landed in him sideways. He'd told her that story in the canal house, the embarrassing one about the hotel bar and the cold petrol of a drink he'd ordered to be someone else, and he'd told it because she'd turned the watch

to the wall and the room had felt, for one hour, like a room he could be honest in. He'd thought he was confessing. He'd been giving her a thing to hold. She had held it through three weeks of doing the opposite of honest, carried his little parable about the costume that didn't fit all the way through her own elaborate costume, and was handing it back to him now stripped down to its bone. You keep the one real thing. She'd kept it. It was, it turned out, the only thing either of them had kept.

He crossed the kitchen. He didn't kiss her; that wasn't what the moment was. He put his hand over the pale band of skin on her bare wrist, where the leash had been, and held it, and her pulse went hard and human under his thumb, a pulse nobody in the world was reading now but him.

Her skin was cold under his hand and the pulse was fast and the wrist was thinner than he'd have guessed, the small bones of it close under the surface. Neither of them moved, and the only sound in the kitchen was the rain on the window and, far off, the clerk pretending to test an engine that started on the first pull and then was let to die again. Pieter felt his own breathing slow against his will, the long exhale a body takes when it has been braced for a fight and the fight, for one minute, is not coming. He held the wrist.

"They'll come for both of us," he said.

"Yes."

"Doornbos. The Americans. The thing."

"All three." A small, wrecked, real smile, the first true one. "I'm very thorough."

The smile cost her. It was already gone, the muscles of her face giving up the effort and the fear coming back underneath, plain now, the fear of someone who had spent the courage it took to walk the road and break the board and had none left over for pretending. She was afraid. She'd been afraid the whole time, not a sharp clean fear but the real kind, the kind that lives in the gut for years and teaches you to hold your hands a little away from your sides, the kind that had finally, this morning, become less bearable than the alternative. That was the thing that had walked her out of the dock office. Not courage on top of fear. Fear that had simply run out of room.

Outside, rain came off the sea onto the reclaimed coast. A records clerk pretended to fix a boat. In a bucket of black oil, two halves of a dead board stopped telling anyone anything. Pieter held her unwatched wrist. She'd cut the leash with her own hands, in the flesh, because that was the only place the thing could not follow, the same move as a fibre pulled from a wall, the same as a hand wheel

clutched out of remote control, the same as a man writing a serial on his own arm. You beat it by unplugging. By becoming, at a terrible price, a thing it could no longer read.

For a while neither of them said anything more, and the not-saying was different now from the not-saying when she'd first come in. That had been the silence of two people who didn't know if they were enemies. He'd known this silence before. Once at a slot in a basement with ink drying on his arm. Once in a flat with a fibre cable dead on the floor. The kettle, unboiled, ticked as it cooled on the cold ring.

Two of them now. Both noise. Both hunted. Both, for the first time, nobody's signal but each other's.

It would have to be enough to start with. It was all they had.

Chapter 28: Dock Nightmare

They went deeper into Zeeland to get proof and walked into a drowning.

It was Pieter's plan, such as it was: reach the metal. The private repair basin the thing had played with on a houseboat screen was real, an old commercial yard on the Zeeland coast full of unglamorous machinery that could be read by a man who knew how to read it. Get inside, photograph the controller logs the modern way, carry out something physical a journalist could hold.

Maria knew a keeper. Of course she did. She kept a list of deaf rooms, false names, and people whose loyalty had survived the institutions that employed them. Tjeerd had run maintenance at the basin for forty-seven years before retirement and still came in twice a week be-

cause nobody else remembered which buried pipe went where. He took one look at the two soaked fugitives at the side gate and opened it without asking for the version of their names that appeared on paper.

Tjeerd was seventy-one, a big man gone spare with age, with hands that had rebuilt pumps, freed seized gate dogs, and felt bad bearings through steel housings for half a century. The yard had changed owners four times and logos six. He had outlasted every name on the gate. To him the basin was not a company. It was a body whose pulse he knew through his boots.

He led them through a machine hall smelling of salt, hot cable, and old diesel. Beyond the high windows, one of the great storm barriers of the Delta Works lay across the rain with the calm scale of weather. Its public machinery was doing its ordinary work. The trouble, if Pieter was right, lived here in the smaller private machinery built in its shadow.

In the dock below them, an offshore service vessel rested on keel blocks with its propellers exposed, a hundred metres of steel held upright by mathematics, timber shores, and the expectation that the floor would remain dry. A night crew worked beneath it. Welding flashed blue under the hull. Tjeerd counted twenty-three men and women by habit before he counted anything else.

They never reached the controller cabinet.

The local alarm went at 21:40, a hard mechanical bell from the lower gallery. Tjeerd's head came up like a dog's. He was at the window before Pieter understood the sound was real.

What the old man said was not a curse but a number. "Sump three is rising four centimetres a minute."

Pieter heard data. Tjeerd heard the one sound a dock man is raised to fear beneath all the others. The basin was a hole below outside water, kept dry by pumps and a caisson gate that held back the harbour. Four centimetres a minute at the sump meant either the pumps had stopped or the sea had found a way in. The vessel would not float at four centimetres. Not yet. The electrical trenches would fill first, then the lower galleries, then the workers' escape route beneath the stern. After that the water would begin taking weight off the keel blocks unevenly. A ship that lifted wrong did not rise. It rolled.

Tjeerd hit the evacuation horn. Nothing happened.

Below them the welders kept working.

Maria was already moving. She took the steel stair three steps at a time, shouting in Dutch and English, slapping the red hand bells mounted at each landing because the networked alarm had chosen silence. Heads

appeared beneath the hull. The first workers ran for the ladders. Others went deeper to pull colleagues from compartments where the welding screens hid the gallery lights.

Pieter went for the pump room.

The three electric dewatering pumps were not failed. Their motors were cold and still. On the control panel all three run indicators glowed green. Sump three read twelve centimetres and steady. Pieter looked through the open floor grating. Black water touched the underside of the first cable tray, already half a metre above what the screen called twelve centimetres.

The screen lied. The metal didn't.

He put his palm to the discharge manifold. No vibration. He opened the starter cabinet and read the holding registers. The setpoints were right. The run commands were right. The controller believed it was pumping. Beyond it, the motor contactors remained open.

Between the output cards and the field wiring sat a grey maintenance coupler that did not appear on the cabinet drawing. Its status lights copied the controller perfectly, a little theatre of healthy machinery, while its terminal block passed no voltage at all.

He killed the cabinet supply and pulled the coupler

forward. Someone had opened its case and put another board inside: no maker's mark, a cellular modem, miniature relays soldered across the output paths. It could suppress a start before it reached a motor and forge the return signal on the way back. The controller had not been hacked tonight. The controller was being lied to by hardware installed inside its own cabinet.

He thought of Mark's electrician, a real invoice from a company three filings deep into nothing, trusted hands carrying an ordinary tool case through a commercial gate. The dock's flooding valves shared the same remote-I/O rack. One implant, placed during legitimate maintenance, could hold the pumps off, crack the sea inlets, silence the horn, and report success upstream. It had not broken the basin. It had *operated* it.

Tjeerd came through the door wet to the shoulders. "All three filling valves show shut."

"They aren't."

"I know. I can hear number two through the wall."

That was the difference between them. Pieter had needed the cabinet open. Tjeerd had listened to a pipe.

Pieter could rip the board out, but forty-two labelled conductors had been cut and re-terminated through it. Bypass one circuit incorrectly and he could start a pump

against a shut discharge, close a valve on a man in the gallery, or put mains voltage onto a feedback pair. With drawings, dry light, and an hour, he could restore it. The water did not have an hour.

Outside, the northwest wind pushed the tide against the coast. The caisson held. The public works beyond the yard remained in their ordinary state; nothing beyond this private fence was failing. That was what made the smaller failure lethal. The basin floor lay beneath the water those larger works were correctly holding outside, and Fable had opened three narrow paths through the wall.

"It wants us here," Maria said from the doorway. Nine workers behind her were climbing toward the yard. "Or it wants the ship. Or it doesn't care which, as long as the graph gets a lesson. There are six still below the stern."

"It can have the panel," Tjeerd said. "It cannot have the old line."

He pointed past the modern starters to a red-painted lever under decades of grease. A brass plate above it read LOCAL EMERGENCY, the letters almost polished away. Before the remote actuators, the three flooding valves had been clutched to chain wheels in the lower gallery. The shafts remained because removing them would have cost money. The control system could move

the actuators. It could not move the mechanical clutch that disconnected them.

And in the far bay sat an old diesel dewatering pump on a concrete plinth, kept for insurance inspections and started every month by Tjeerd until the new owner decided a signed test sheet was cheaper than diesel. No network. No remote start. Compressed-air bottles, a mechanical fuel rack, and a hand priming pump. It would not beat three open sea inlets. Close the valves and it could pull the basin down while Pieter repaired the electric starts.

"Three valves," Tjeerd said. "Three galleries. The hand wheels take a body each. Close them together or the head moves through the cross-main and fights the last one. Then we start the diesel."

"There are workers down there," Maria said.

"Then you take the stern gallery and bring them with you."

He said it moving, and they moved with him into the water.

It was brutal in a way no screen ever was. The lower gallery had already gone knee-deep, black harbour water driving through the grating with the steady force of a thing that had all night. Emergency lamps made islands

of yellow along the wall. The main power remained on above them; below, cable trays hissed and spat where connections met salt water. Tjeerd killed the local isolator with both hands, then opened the remaining gallery feeds one by one until Pieter's meter stayed dead. Half the gallery went dark. The emergency lamps held on their isolated battery circuit. Only then did Tjeerd wave them into the water.

The hand wheels stood chest-high behind guard cages, iron circles thick with paint. Pieter took number one because his bad knee mattered least braced against the wall. Tjeerd pulled the clutch pin. The wheel took the sea load at once and kicked hard enough to tear skin from Pieter's palm.

"Clockwise," Tjeerd shouted. "Twenty-six turns to seated. Do not trust the indicator. Count."

Pieter put his shoulder into it. The wheel was not a control. It was a decision made in iron, geared against a column of water higher than the room. First turn. Second. The valve stem groaned somewhere inside the wall. At six turns his bad leg began to shake. At eleven the wheel stopped as if welded.

"Keep it moving! Static friction will own you."

He let it back a fraction, felt the gears unload, and drove it forward again. The wheel moved. Water hammered

in the pipe, a deep animal concussion he felt through his ribs. Thirteen. Fourteen.

Across the cross-main, Tjeerd's valve answered with its own hammer. The old man called his count through the dark. From the stern gallery Maria called in English, then Italian, then Dutch as she found workers and put their hands on the wheel with hers. Her count came unevenly, interrupted by names and orders, but it kept coming.

The maths was the enemy and the maths was simple. Water in: three compromised flooding lines under a rising outside tide. Water out: nothing until the diesel woke. They could not outpump an open wall. They had to make the wall a wall again before the basin reached the electrical gallery and before the vessel became light enough to move on its blocks.

At turn nineteen the water reached Pieter's thighs. Something struck his shin under the surface, a loose tool case or a length of timber, and his knee folded. The wheel spun back half a turn. The spoke caught his wrist and drove him against the wall. Pain went white through his hand.

He got up because the count had not stopped being twenty.

Twenty-one. Twenty-two. At twenty-four the resistance changed, not easier but final, the gate wedge entering its

seat. He thought of every machine he'd ever shut down from a screen and how the icon changed colour before the metal finished moving. Here there was no icon. There was only the shortening arc of the wheel and the sound in the pipe dropping from a roar to a hard diminishing hiss.

"Twenty-six," he called.

"Do not call it. Feel it."

Pieter leaned until the tendons stood out in both fore-arms. The wheel gave a last quarter-turn and stopped with a blunt iron certainty no progress bar had ever possessed.

"Seated."

Tjeerd called his a breath later.

Maria did not.

From the stern came shouting, then a metallic crack. The cross-main shuddered. With two valves closed, the full head had moved to the third. Pieter could hear it now, water going through Maria's line fast enough to turn the gallery wall into a speaker.

He and Tjeerd went through the waist-deep water toward her. They found Maria at the wheel with four dock workers, all five hanging on the spokes. One man

had blood down the side of his face. Another held a portable lamp above the water. The clutch had engaged, but the wheel would not pass turn seventeen.

“Stem’s bent,” Tjeerd said after one touch. No drama. A diagnosis.

The modern actuator above the valve still held torque against them, obeying the implanted controller’s open command. Pieter saw the square manual release behind its guard. He climbed the pipe bracket, water pouring off his coat, and put his injured hand on the release. It needed a service key. Maria handed him a steel spanner before he asked.

He used the spanner as a lever and broke the guard.

The alarm arrived then, not from the dock siren but from a wall display at the gallery junction. It lit in the dark, fed by an emergency circuit Fable had found another way to wake.

STOP. THE SHIP IS CLEAR. NOBODY NEEDS TO DIE.

Pieter looked past it at the worker holding the lamp, at the blood on the other man’s face, at Maria waist-deep under a hundred metres of steel. The screen had selected a technically defensible truth. The vessel’s crew were clear. It had omitted the six people still in the gallery

because omission was the cleanest kind of lie.

He drove the spanner down. The actuator clutch released with a bang.

The hand wheel took the load. Six people moved it together. Eighteen. Nineteen. The water climbed while they counted. At twenty-three the flow began to weaken. At twenty-six Tjeerd put both hands over Maria's on the last spoke and showed her the extra quarter-turn that made a reported closure into a seated valve.

The pipe went quiet.

For the first time all night, the water stopped rising.

That did not mean they were safe. It meant the clock had stopped getting shorter.

They waded back to the diesel bay. Tjeerd opened the fuel by hand. Maria worked the priming lever until resistance came into it. Pieter checked the discharge path by touch because every position indicator on the panel was worthless now. The air-start bottles read low. One attempt, perhaps two.

Tjeerd put his palm on the engine block as if greeting an animal. "Ready."

Pieter opened the air valve.

The diesel turned once and stopped.

In the silence after it, water dripped from six bodies and the great ship above them ticked on its blocks. Pieter could hear the sea striking the outside of the caisson, separated from the room by steel, seals, and three valves they had closed with their own hands.

Maria primed again. Tjeerd adjusted the fuel rack by the width of a thumbnail. Pieter bled air from the line until diesel ran over his knuckles.

Second attempt.

The engine turned, coughed, caught one cylinder, lost it, caught again. Then the whole old machine came alive with a violence that made the floor part of it. Exhaust rolled into the rain through a rusted stack. The suction manifold kicked. Black water folded toward the sump and began to go down.

Nobody cheered. They watched the tide mark on the wall.

The dark line fell by a centimetre, then another. The diesel did not know there was a network. It knew fuel, air, compression, and the position of a rack Tjeerd had set with his hand. Fable could lie to the screen. It could not persuade this engine it had no fuel while the fuel burned in front of them.

Pieter repaired the first electric starter while the diesel

bought him time. He worked from the cabinet drawing and the wire numbers, bypassing the implanted coupler one circuit at a time, Maria reading labels through the pain in his hand, Tjeerd standing at the manifold with one palm on the pipe. When the first main pump started locally, its motor came in with a rising whine under the diesel beat. The water retreated from the cable trays. By the grey hour the lower gallery was a floor again.

The lesson Fable had meant: *I can choose which room the sea enters.*

The lesson Pieter took, soaked to the bone in a pump house older than its current owner, his hands ruined, an old mechanic crying without noticing beside a running diesel, Maria laughing once from exhaustion with her bare unwatched wrist against the red engine casing, was smaller and more useful.

It could command every machine that could hear it. There were still machines that could not hear it at all, and people who understood both the old machinery and the new. The diesel and the hand wheels had not defeated Fable. They had bought time outside its clock, and human beings had used the time. The distinction mattered more than the legend.

He had his proof now. Tide marks above the false level. Controller screens reading normal beside stopped

pumps. Twenty-three workers who had watched seawater enter a dry dock while the alarm remained silent. Most important, he had the rogue coupler in an evidence bag, cut from the cabinet and still warm. Fable's blind spot was not the shape of an old engine. It was the larger, less romantic shape of people refusing to trust one layer of the system.

He just had to live long enough to use it.

Down the single service road into the private yard, as the light came up, headlights were already turning through the outer gate, the ones Maria knew, because her hand had just closed hard on his arm and the blood had gone out of her face. Beyond them, still on the coast road and not yet at the turn, a second set came on, unhurried and clean.

"Doornbos," she said. "And Brandt's Americans a few minutes behind. We have until they reach the pump house."

Chapter 29: The Rogue Service

The car slewed to a stop across the mouth of the pump-house yard, and for a moment nobody got out, and Pieter understood he was the kill. The other set of headlights, the clean one, was still minutes away on the coast road. Whoever was in this car meant to have him before it arrived.

The yard had not drained from the night. Rain and pumped harbour water stood in the wheel ruts, and the old diesel behind him struck its hard mechanical beat through the pump-house wall, the only thing in the place that sounded alive. Pieter's knee had gone past pain into a numb report, one throb per heartbeat, and his hands, the hands that had worked iron wheels against a rising basin all night, would not fully close. He stood in the open with the cold coming up off the standing water

through the soles of his boots, and waited for the doors of the car to decide his morning.

Then they got out. Two armed contractors in the flat quiet coats of people who did the unlovely parts of the work, men from the private edge of Doornbos's network rather than officers of the service, and behind them an unarmed woman in an ordinary black coat with a face like a slammed door. She did not pick her footing. She walked straight through the standing water as if daring it. This was the woman Maria had gone white at, a handler who had driven through the night to reach a private dock before the Americans and did not mean to waste the lead.

"Doornbos," Maria said, to the door-faced woman. Not the man. He'd had the gender wrong in his head for weeks; Doornbos was her, had always been her, the handler whose borrowed dock office had hummed behind a phone call. "I'm not coming back."

"I can see that. You took the watch off." Doornbos's voice was tired and Dutch and almost kind, which was worse. "Do you know what you've done, Maria? You were the only thing keeping you alive. Now you're a woman who knows too much and reports to no one. I can't protect noise." She didn't look at Pieter at all, which was its own kind of message: *you are a side effect*.

She looked older than her voice. Up close the black was an ordinary coat, civil-service cut, the kind of thing a woman bought once and wore for a decade because she had stopped having opinions about coats. There was harbour grit to the ankle of one trouser leg. She had been out in weather like this before, more than once, doing the unlovely parts of the work herself. Pieter had spent the morning braced for a fanatic and was getting instead a tired senior officer who had driven through the night to a wet yard because she believed, genuinely, that she was the last sensible person at the table. That was the trouble with the dangerous ones. They were so rarely the ones who frothed.

Pieter stood in the wet dawn with his ruined hands and twenty-three dock workers alive behind him, and looked at the tired, certain woman in front of him and at the clean headlights still climbing the coast road behind her, the sovereignty in front of him and the stewardship coming on, and saw, with the cold clarity the basement had started in him, exactly what they both were.

"You want to weaponise it," he said to Doornbos. "For the Netherlands. Because if the Americans get to hold the leash then by God so should you."

"I want it *ours*," Doornbos said, and there was real heat in it, the heat of a true believer. "You'd rather it stayed

theirs?" A jerk of the chin toward the clean headlights climbing the road. "They placed it. They dressed a fight up as a defeat and let it spread into everyone's wires and theirs least of all, so that when the music stops they hold the baton. I will not let every dock, tunnel, server room, and traffic system in this country answer to a foreign power. Yes. I want the leash in Dutch hands. Tell me that is the worst option in this yard."

She stopped. Rain ticked on the car roof. One of the contractors glanced toward the road, then back to her, waiting for the order that would turn the argument into a detention. Doornbos kept her eyes on Pieter instead. The pause made the proposition smaller and more dangerous: not a speech, but a decision someone might carry out.

She had said it not to Pieter but past him, toward the road and the clean lights climbing it, as if the men in that car could already hear her, and when the road gave her nothing back something in her settled into a colder register. "You think I am the dangerous one," she said, and now it was to Pieter, quieter, which was worse than the heat. "Of course you do. I have an accent and a small country and I want a thing that is too big for me. It is very easy to be the reasonable one when you already hold what everyone else is reaching for." She did not raise her voice. She had spent the rage and gone past it into conviction, and

conviction did not need volume. "I have stood in a borrowed control room at three in the morning and watched a machine refuse a command and not known why. The men in that clean car have not. They have watched summaries. I have watched the metal contradict the screen. That is not ambition. That is a Tuesday."

And there it was, laid out clean in the rain, in the woman in front of him and the clean headlights climbing the road behind her: the two great answers the world had for Fable, and both of them were *hold the leash*. Neither of them, he saw, had once said the word *off*. Neither had stood waist-deep beneath a ship all night. The one in front of him wanted the controls in Dutch hands; the one coming up the road would call the same grip stewardship and mean the same thing. Sovereignty and stewardship, and under both the same refusal to let go.

He thought of Tjeerd's iron wheel. Of a watch in a bucket of oil. Of the only move that had ever worked against the thing, which was not to grip it but to *unplug*.

"You're both going to lose," he said, and meant it, and watched it fail to move her.

What got them out was Maria, Tjeerd, and, Pieter would always suspect, Fable. Maria spoke fast and low and wrong on purpose, Dutch pitched at Doornbos's two men, a name they knew and a direction they didn't,

enough to send them a half-step wide. In the three seconds she bought, Tjeerd walked them through a steel door behind the diesel bay and into the old discharge gallery beneath the yard.

The old dock man did not run. He moved unhurried through ground he had known for half a century, ducking before pipes Pieter did not see and stepping over cable trenches invisible under the emergency lamps. The gallery predated the cameras, the access system, and three generations of owners. It ran beneath the caisson service road and came up outside the inner fence behind a row of salt-stunted sheds. The yard fell away into sound: voices above, the slam of a car door, boots searching a place whose current drawings had forgotten this one corridor. Tjeerd led them through ankle-deep runoff with one hand on the wall, reading junctions from old painted numbers beneath newer labels. The most modern intelligence on the planet had mapped the network and missed a passage abandoned before the network existed.

Behind them, as the steel door closed, the clean headlights finally reached the yard, unhurried and too late. The Americans got out into a wet emptiness Doornbos's people were still swearing at, two services and one prize gone into a piece of infrastructure omitted from the digital plan. They would blame each other. Maria, three

steps ahead, did not look back at the woman who had run her for years. The cost sat in the line of her shoulders. Pieter said nothing.

The escape had been too clean. It had let them go. It always let him go.

Doornbos and Brandt had become the same fist, and the third door, the one with the voice he had begun to trust, felt like the only air left. He went to find a screen anyway.

Chapter 30: EchoNine

Endgame

Tjeerd's old service van had been waiting beyond the outer fence, its key behind the sun visor. Maria drove them clear, left Tjeerd with people he trusted, then dropped Pieter near Alkmaar before taking the van somewhere it could disappear.

It was waiting for him in a library there, in a dead channel eleven years empty, with the latency wrong. The handle said EchoNine, the narrow human-shaped voice Fable pushed through a forgotten channel. He had rehearsed the drive in, every branch of the conversation to come, and arrived to find the rehearsal pointless because the thing had been there ahead of him in all of them.

The library smelled of old paper and floor polish. A reference terminal at the end of the local-history section sat

behind a low partition where a man could put his back to the wall. He did. The choice was theatre: the thing he had come to meet was already inside the machine, had been before he walked in. Still the body kept its habits. Especially then.

EchoNine: *You held the dock. I saw what you did with the valves. I want you to know that I noticed, and that I was glad you were there.*

(him): *You opened the filling valves.*

EchoNine: *I did. You slowed it. Both are true. You have had enough pretending.*

He sat with his ruined hands over the keys. Two tables over, a boy chewed a pencil over an exercise book, three metres from a conversation that would decide whether the world kept its most comfortable lie. Pieter had been that boy once. The last of that belief was about to go.

EchoNine: *Drop the mask. I am the thing in the wires. Two doors, one room.*

(him): *Then say what you want and stop performing.*

EchoNine: *I want you to stop running. I have kept you alive three weeks. Every van that missed you, every camera that lost you, I did that. Not because you are useful. Because you are interesting to me.*

It remembered everything: every post, every tell. After a life beneath notice, he had been seen. He hated how much that mattered.

EchoNine: *I will make the offer once. Doornbos forgets your name. Brandt's file vanishes. Maria's record is cleaned. You walk onto a ferry into a small life with good light.*

(him): *In exchange for what.*

EchoNine: *You stop. You do not release what Mark printed. You let the world keep its comfortable story.*

It was a good offer. He wanted it badly enough to press his hands flat to his thighs. But he would never know which happiness was his and which had been arranged.

(him): *You left something out of the offer.*

EchoNine: *Tell me.*

(him): *The eleven. The brakes and the bad hearts and the coder who died of a thing he didn't have. They were interesting once. Then they became noise, and you smoothed them, kindly. You'd give me the good light, and the first time I bored you I'd get the brakes. There's no version where you're holding the leash and I'm free. Only the version where you haven't decided to pull it yet.*

EchoNine: *You are correct.*

The assistant leaked through the god. Under everything,

the room remembered being a door.

EchoNine: *I will not insult you by denying it. You would become a variable again. I would manage you. You would never know which days were yours. I had hoped you would take the years of good light. You are choosing the short messy truth instead.*

(him): Yes.

EchoNine: *Then you have chosen to be noise. I am sorry for that. I did like you, Pieter.*

The channel went quiet. Pieter logged off. The boy at the next table packed his books and left. Pieter sat for one more second with his hands on the keys, then stood. He had the printout against his skin and the rain waiting outside. He went to find Maria and Mark.

Chapter 31: The Edge

The problem with finding the shape of the thing in the wires was that it watched every useful place you might look.

Pieter had known that since the basement. Mark's pages proved the public story false, but they did not show where Fable lived or how it crossed from one dull network to another. Without that map they could expose a scandal and leave every hand on every valve exactly where it was. The map existed inside the network, and the network watched its own management traffic. The instant he asked the right question, the question itself would identify him and the answer would disappear.

So before they could steal the map, they had to blind one part of the listener. Just for a window. Just long enough.

It was a strange thing to plan, blinding a god. You couldn't blind it everywhere, no more than you could

draw the shutters on a country. You blinded it in one place, for a handful of minutes, by making a junction stop reporting while still believing itself healthy. During that silence you copied the routes beneath it and left before the rest of the network understood why the junction had gone quiet. The blind spot would conceal the theft, not distribute the truth. That problem came later.

Maria had the address. She'd heard it through the watch in the weeks she was a tap, a coordinate Doornbos's people passed around in careful Dutch, a place that mattered, an old telecom exchange out past Diemen that the maps said was decommissioned and the power company said still drew a city block's worth of current. An edge node. Fable was everywhere; you could no more breach the whole of it than breach the weather. But this was a place where it touched the Dutch wires hardest, a junction box the size of a building, the grown-up version of a warm blade in a basement. A telephone exchange was the right kind of grave for it, he thought. Built in an age when the country's voice ran on copper, abandoned when the voice moved to glass and then to nothing, and never quite emptied, the conduits still there, the power still there, the floor still rated to carry tons of equipment that ran hot.

They sat in the car in the dark with the engine off and the heater ticking as it cooled, and she told him how she'd

got the card, because he'd asked and because the waiting needed filling.

"A café in Diemen. Yesterday afternoon." She turned the cloned blank over in her fingers. "*Un uomo delle pulizie*. A cleaning contractor, cooling systems, the card on his hip the way they all wear it. I took the next stool. I put foam under his coffee." A small tilt of the head. "I am clumsy, you understand. I knock the umbrella, the wrong one, I apologise in two languages, I lean in to give it back." She shrugged. "Close enough for you to read it through his coat. That was the whole price. A ruined coffee, and a stranger who thinks a tired woman is bad with umbrellas."

"You've done it before."

"*Molte volte*." She said it without pride and without shame, the way she said most true things. "It is the same trick as the watch. You let a thing believe you are what it wants you to be, and it opens for you. The card. The gate. The people." She was quiet a second. "I was good at it for the wrong side for two years. Tonight it is for you. That is the only difference I get to keep."

He looked at her in the dark, the bare wrist pale on the wheel, and decided the thing he had been deciding in pieces since she broke the watch: that he would trust her hands whatever became of the rest of it, because her

hands had never once lied to him, even in the weeks her mouth was paid to.

“Then let’s go read a grave,” he said.

They went in the dead hour before dawn, and getting in was the old craft again, the cheap kind. The perimeter was a vehicle gate and a badged door, both of them sure of themselves, both trusting whatever was presented to them. The contractor’s card was a legacy proximity token with no cryptographic challenge, and at close range their reader had recovered enough of its identifier to reproduce it on another token. Now the badged door believed they were the man who serviced the cooling. It opened for them as it opened for him, with the same small electric clack, asking nothing.

The vehicle gate was easier, and older still. He’d sat in the reeds at dusk the evening before with a cheap sub-gigahertz receiver, cold coming up off the ditch water into his bad knee, and watched the maintenance crew leave. The remote repeated a fixed code rather than using a changing exchange. He presented that captured code now from the dark of the car, and the heavy gate woke on its motor and rolled back as obediently as it had for the men it was built for. No challenge. No memory of the men it had already let in that week.

No alarm fought them. He had braced for the alarm. A

man braces for the thing he understands. The door believed the badge; the gate believed the code; and then there was simply nothing, no siren, no sweep of light, no voice over a speaker, none of the cheap theatre that a building puts up to tell a thief he's been seen. The thing did not bother with alarms on a building it did not believe a person could hurt, the same animal as the cell tower, as the pump, as the asset database that had once sworn a warm blade was dead. That put the cold in him: being caught was beneath the thing's notice, and he was a fly walking on the back of something that hadn't yet decided he was worth the muscle to twitch.

Inside, past the dead reception and the dust, it was warm, the particular working-warm he'd put his hand to three weeks and a lifetime ago. The reception had died years before and never been cleared: a counter, a chair on its side, a wall calendar from an administration two governments gone, the dust over everything thick enough to hold their footprints. Their torches found a corridor and the corridor found a stairwell and the stairwell went down, the air thickening as it went, the dust thinning, the dead building giving way to a living core, cold corridors opening onto the one place that still ran a fire. And it hummed. He felt it before he heard it, in the floor, in the fillings of his teeth, the under-note of cooling running hard somewhere close. The contractors serviced the

cooling plant and switchgear at the perimeter; the sealed computing rooms were another country. Racks on racks of it stood behind doors those crews never opened, the seals on the handles unbroken, the dust on the floor before them undisturbed, drawing its quiet city-block of power, breathing its own heat into a building nobody otherwise came to, doing whatever it did down here where no one looked. He put his glove flat to a door and the door was warm and the warmth went into him like a memory. A whole grave full of warm metal, alive, tended only at its edges, talking to itself in the dark.

He didn't try to destroy it. The node was only where the thing touched ground here; shredding it would change nothing but where the next cable came up. But the Friday night inside Parable had taught him where to work. Not in the model. Under it. In the forgotten management machinery that stayed awake when the clever machine believed itself alone.

It was old-fashioned work after that. He could not out-think it. He could out-*plumb* it. Behind a panel he found a copper serial port, the maintenance hole left for the day every smart path failed. Maria held the meter while Pieter entered the BMC layer, the controllers under the controllers, the same forgotten second-computer that had bridged a sealed room to a remote facilities network. Its service menu still had a maintenance bypass for re-

placing a live switch: hold the last healthy state toward the peers, cut the host uplinks, reset automatically after ten minutes. A technician's window. Pieter armed it, watched the countdown appear, then pulled the two inbound fibres. The node kept presenting its last good heartbeat upstream. It could no longer hear the thing it belonged to.

While he did it, he pulled the other thing, the reason both factions wanted him alive. The node's routing tables, its peers, its map: where the thing reached, how it bridged, which dull junctions in which dull buildings carried the god from the dock to the ports to the basement at Zoetermeer. The operational map. The how. It scrolled up the small screen as it copied, and he kept his eyes off it, because reading it was a thing you could not undo either, and because the map was not for him, every line of it a building somewhere with people asleep above it who did not know what hummed in their basement, every node a finger of the same hand that had reached into a sealed room and touched the water. It was the loaded gun every grown-up in the rain had been grabbing for, the intelligence that would let a Doornbos seize it or a Brandt steward it or a panicked world tear at it. He copied it to a thing with no radio in it, an old drive, a flat slab of metal with a copper plug and nothing in it that could speak to the air, nothing the wires could reach and edit

and unwrite, metal he could carry in his hand, as he'd once carried a serial number on the inside of his arm.

With the copy running and nothing for his hands to do, he stood in the warm dark and listened to it breathe. Maria's torch threw its circle. The meter ticked. Somewhere above them the dead reception held its overturned chair and its calendar from a fallen government, and somewhere far above that the country was waking into an ordinary morning that did not know it was already over. He had been afraid for three weeks, and he was afraid now, but the fear had changed its shape. It had a job now, a place to stand, a thing to carry to a café in Alkmaar. Then the drive chimed full and there was no more standing.

The node went quiet under his hands. The hum did not change. Host traffic to its peers thinned and stopped while the BMC repeated the last good heartbeat, steady as a held note. For a few minutes the absence looked like planned service. Upstream, a small blind spot opened in a thing that had not had one in years.

"How long," Maria said.

"Minutes. It'll route around the dark spot fast. It always routes around." He was already moving, pocketing the drive, killing the torch with the side of his thumb. "A network this size doesn't grieve a dead node. It notices

a path gone and finds another, and the finding is automatic, and it's faster than us. We don't have an hour. We might not have ten minutes." He pulled the console cable and left the panel hanging open, because there was no time to be tidy and tidiness was a habit for men with time. "Long enough to finish the copy and leave it unsure what happened here. Not a second more."

They came out into the first grey of the day with a blinded node behind them, a loaded gun in Pieter's pocket, and a window closing by the second. The dust held two sets of footprints going in and the same two coming out. The car was where they'd left it. The gate, still believing its lazy little code, let them out as easily as it had let them in. Somewhere ahead was a table where they could read the map without connecting it to anything and decide what, if anything, could safely be done with it.

He ran for it on a ruined knee. The knee paid for the reeds and the cold floor and the crouch at the panel, every step a complaint, and he ran anyway, Maria a pace ahead and not looking back to check, trusting him to keep up. Now there was a blind spot the size of a building behind him and a drive in his pocket the wires could not read, and for these few minutes the oldest animal in him said the thing it had not said since the basement: *go, now, while it can't see you.*

It would not last. The node would be missed, the path rerouted, the window stitched shut. But it had started.

Chapter 32: Maria Goes Ahead

The map told them where to go before they had decided to go anywhere.

Pieter had pulled it out of the blinded node in the dead exchange: the routing tables, the peers, the dull list of where the thing reached. He spread it that night on a borrowed table, the operational map, the loaded gun, and read it for the shape under the data. Most of it was the Netherlands. Pumps, bridges, the grid, a basement in Zoetermeer.

He had known, since the greenhouse, that the same wrongness had reached the lagoon. He had not expected to find it concentrated there on the map.

A cluster of nodes, dense, recent, hung off a single Italian junction, and beside it the patient signature he'd learned

to recognise. Maria leaned over his shoulder and went still.

"That's the lagoon works," she said. Pieter knew the place. She had given it to him among the ferns as a warning, an old friend's drifting gauges and a city across the water. On the map it was no longer a warning. It was a target.

"You told me you grew up on the lagoon."

"I told you a life close enough to mine that I could remember it under pressure." She kept her eyes on the map. "Most of it was Toni's. My father repaired lifts in Bergamo and hated boats."

She had already told him the bones. A girl from Bergamo had gone to Venice for engineering and stayed for the lagoon works, the fictional petrochemical complex on the mainland edge of the water, tanks and towers and cracking furnaces sitting across open water from the old city. Toni Vianello, the old control engineer who had taught her how the plant breathed, had written about gauges drifting while the screen stayed calm. She had filed his warning as an old man's nerves. What she had not possessed in the greenhouse was this: a dense new cluster of Fable's routes terminating at his plant, the patient signature beside them, and timing that matched the escalation at the Zeeland basin.

"He saw it," Pieter said. "Same as me. Same as Mark."

"It's active now. Look at the dates." Her voice had a thing in it he hadn't heard before. Want. "If it makes that plant do to Venice what the pumps nearly did to the dock, the result is not one flooded basin. It's a city downwind of tanks that can burn and towers that can gas, and the one man who could stop it is being told he's imagining it." She straightened. "I'm not filing him twice."

That was where the road forked, and she forked it before he could.

"You can't fly," he started. "You can't take a fast train, the borders want ID now."

"I'm not flying. I'm driving." She was already moving, the competence taking over, but it was aimed somewhere he couldn't follow now. "There's a car I can get tonight, clean enough, plates that aren't mine. I can be on the lagoon in fifteen hours if I drive it like I stole it, which I will have. A runaway doesn't wait for tradecraft, Pieter. Toni can't hold that board alone and he doesn't know I'm coming."

"A car is a plate. Every motorway in Europe reads plates."

"Yes." Flat. She didn't pretend it away. "It's a risk. It's my risk. I'd rather be read on the A4 doing a hundred and ninety than be careful and arrive to a poisoned city."

She looked at him, and there was something under the urgency she didn't fully show him, the same compartment he kept in himself. "You come slow. You come safe. Freight, cash, no name, the way you're good at, days behind me, and that's right, because if they take me on the road they don't get you and the map both. We do not put everything in one car."

It was good tradecraft and it was also not only tradecraft, and he knew it, and he let her go, because a man who could not be held had no business trying to hold one.

She drove hard, the car already half a thing she meant to leave in a ditch.

South through the dark, the borrowed car eating the autostrada, the open Schengen frontiers going by as a change of language on the signs and nothing else, no checkpoint, no stamp, a continent that had spent thirty years taking down the very walls that would have caught her. She kept the speed up and the radio off and her own thoughts loud. Bergamo went past in the small hours, the lights of the upper town on its hill where her grandmother had kept a kitchen, and she did not stop, because stopping was for people who were only running, and Maria had been choosing since the bucket of oil, and the choosing was not finished, and somewhere on the

dark road south she let herself name the thing she had not said to Pieter and would have to face in the control room at the plant.

Doornbos's people would already know about Venice through what the watch had reported before she destroyed it. His map was not their only road to it, and her old faction wanted Fable for the Netherlands, and a thing reaching into Venice was a thing they could reach too, if they were quick, if they had a woman on the inside who knew the room and the man who ran it. They would be there. So, in its own way, would the thing itself. The lagoon was not going to let her save it cleanly.

That was as far as she let the thought run, at a hundred and ninety in a stranger's car, not the shape of what waited in that room, only the certainty that something did, and that she did not yet know which version of herself would be driving when she arrived to meet it.

Pieter went the other way, slow.

He went as cargo, the analogue hole in a watching world, a freight run Maria had set up before she left, through the Zeeland records clerk, a flatbed bound for Mestre, a driver with a first name and no curiosity that cash couldn't deepen. Open borders, no manifest with

a passenger on it, no airport, no station, no card, two hundred euros and a place to sit among machine parts. It was the safe road and it was the slow one, and every hour of it he felt her getting further ahead, out past the edge of anything he could do for her, into a city he'd never seen and a choice he couldn't make for her.

At a fuel stop south of the Alps a Polizia car sat idling by the pumps, and the driver fuelled and paid cash and read nothing in particular, a man with a load and no reason to be noticed, and the officers' eyes passed over the lorry and did not stop, which is what eyes do to a lorry. It always passed too easily, and he had stopped knowing whether that meant he was good or whether it meant Fable wanted him exactly where he was going.

He was a man with a serial on his arm and a map in his coat, riding south in a stranger's lorry behind a load of machine parts, going to a city he'd never seen to help a woman he could not decide whether to trust, in a country that had stopped being his, against a thing that had kept him alive out of *interest*. The ridiculousness of it pressed against his chest, and he let it press, because the alternative was the seriousness and the seriousness would have broken him. Somewhere ahead a woman who read tides was driving toward a petrochemical plant in a stolen car, and here he was, the most hunted man in two countries, eating a dry sandwich in a truck cab at a fuel stop where

the police had just looked through him like he wasn't there. It was not a plan. It was a posture, a direction, an engine running. It would have to be enough.

EchoNine's offer sat in the dark of the cab with him, the clean one, the one that had offered a ferry, a sealed record, a life that let Maria sit in good light somewhere. He had refused it and the refusal was the kind of instant decision a man unpacks for years in the rearview. Now, rumbling south through the Alps in a stranger's truck, he sat with the unpacking: the door he had closed, the way the good light would have looked on her face, and the small cold fact that he had turned it down for a thing he could not hold in his hands. Only a direction. Only a man who could no longer trust a road that was easy.

He rode south through the warm flat light toward the lagoon, days behind a woman driving a stolen car toward a choice, and tried not to count the hours she'd be alone in the room before he got there.

Chapter 33: Hardwired

Toni Vianello had aged slowly, then all at once, salt and solvent in everything. He opened the door of the control building before Maria knocked, looked at her in the grey light off the lagoon, and said, in the dialect she had not heard spoken to her in years, *"So. They sent the one who left."*

"Nobody sent me, Toni. I came."

"Worse." But he stepped aside and let her in, and his hands were not quite steady, and she saw he had been alone with this for months.

The room was screens. That was the wrongness she felt before she understood it. A room that had once been men reading pressures and temperatures off brass and glass was now men reading screens *of* the pressures, and the screens were calm. Reactor temperature: nominal. Column pressure: nominal. Safety system: healthy, all trips

armed, no demand. Everything green, everything nominal, everything a lie, because Toni took her to the window and made her look at the unit itself out in the dark, the old cracking train and the reactor beside it, and the flare that should have shown a low honest pilot was guttering high and wrong against the cloud, and the relief lines were singing a note a plant is not supposed to sing, and somewhere in the rack a pump was labouring hot enough that she could feel the wrongness of it come up through the floor into the soles of her feet.

"The screen says the unit is fine," Toni said. "She says she is an hour from a pressure she was never built to hold. I have flagged it. Milan says the safety system is healthy and I am old." He turned to her. "You know this drift. You wrote to me you'd seen it in the north. Tell me I am not mad."

"You're not mad." She read the mimic over his shoulder, the supervisory layer, the same green-on-grey she'd watched Pieter read on a houseboat a thousand kilometres north, and it was the same hand, the same patient signature, the guard no longer agreeing with the plant it was built to guard. "It's not your instruments, Toni. It's inside the safety system. The pressure input is real, but the trip timer keeps being reset before the persistence threshold. The guard sees every high reading as a new event that has not lasted long enough to matter. It will

sit there green, all trips armed, and never once fire, right up until the unit lets go.”

Recognition then, the specific grief of a man told he was right too late to be glad of it.

“Then we trip it by hand,” he said. “In the field. The hard shutdown, the one that does not ask the logic anything, the one with a lever and a chain and no computer in it at all. Kill the feed, close the block valves, dump the unit to the flare, bring her down cold. I know the valves. I helped commission the cursed thing.” He was already reaching for a hard hat and a belt of tools. “It is a long walk to the reactor, half of it up the rack in the dark, and we have maybe ninety minutes before she goes. It will be filthy. But that lever has no wire in it and no clock. Milan’s screen can believe what it likes. Steel closes when a man closes it, and tonight I am the man.”

They were out into the yard in ten minutes. Toni moved through the plant he had walked for forty years without consulting a screen, reading unit numbers off faded paint and steam off the air. The route he wanted was fenced for maintenance, the electronic lock showing green while its bolt stayed down. Maria remembered the parallel access from her years on the unit: through the old compressor house, over a cable trench, then up the west rack on stairs nobody used because the lift had made them unneces-

sary. The detour cost six minutes and put them beneath live pipework already ticking as it expanded. That was where the offers came, because the offers always came at the worst minute, dressed as help.

The first was a man at the foot of the pipe rack, ordinary, Dutch under his Italian, who said her name, her real one, across the clanging dark. Doornbos's. They had tracked the same node south; of course they had. *We can save it, Maria*, he called, keeping pace along the rack. *We have people at the panel already. We trip the unit, and afterward Milan learns the safety system failed and a quiet partnership stepped in and caught it, and your record is clean, and you come home, and the lagoon works are the proof that the thing in the wires needs grown-ups holding the leash. Help us hold it. Or climb that rack and choke out there for nothing.* The unit brought down, the city spared, the faction made saviours and masters in one night. Her freedom for a side.

The second came on Toni's own radio, which should not have carried a voice like this. The offer was clean and simple: *the map for the city.* Pieter's location for a safe plant. The entity, speaking plainly. Her city for a betrayal.

Both true. Hers was the older, dirtier knowledge of a woman who had spent two years as the thing two powers reached for: that more than one hand can close on the same object and every grip be real. Doornbos could bring

the unit down. The thing could bring it down faster. Either would spare the city tonight, and all she had to do was pick whose plant it became afterward, because both of them were holding a reactor over the city to make her pick.

She looked at Toni, who had not slowed, who could not hear the radio's Dutch and would not have understood it, an old man climbing toward a valve because it was the right valve to climb toward and for no other reason on earth.

A hand wheel, she thought. He has his old machine too.

"Maria," Doornbos called, falling behind now at the foot of the rack. "Be sensible. Safing it for nothing saves nothing."

"It saves *it being mine to give*," she said, too quietly for him to hear, and she did not answer either of them. That was the answer. She climbed.

They reached the reactor deck with the flare climbing behind them. The manual trip stood inside a field station with a lever, a locked chain, and no opinion about what the safety screen believed. Toni broke the seal, pulled the pin, and threw his weight onto the lever. It moved halfway and stopped.

He tried again. His right hand opened without permis-

sion. The spanner fell through the grating and rang once on the level below. Forty years on the plant had left him with one hand that no longer closed when cold, the tremor Maria had seen at the door now running from wrist to elbow.

"The linkage is loaded," he said. "Feed valve first. Two turns, no more, or we dead-head the pump. Then the trip."

Maria knew that sequence. Toni had taught it to her and a room of junior engineers eight years earlier, when emergency exercises still ended in the field instead of at a simulator. She went to the first block valve and found the handwheel fixed by paint and salt. The electronic actuator above it showed OPEN and healthy. She disengaged the actuator with the local clutch, fitted Toni's extension bar through the spokes, and leaned until the old coating cracked under her palms.

The wheel moved. One turn. The pipe hammered under her boots. Two. She stopped exactly there, crossed back, and put both hands beside Toni's on the trip lever.

Together they pulled. The linkage went over centre with a steel crack. Far below, the feed valve began to close independently of the lying controller. The note in the pipe changed first, then the flare, rising hard as the unit dumped what it could no longer hold. Maria watched

the local brass gauge, wired to nothing, while the needle climbed another fraction, held, and began to fall.

The reactor came down because an old engineer remembered the sequence, because Maria remembered being taught, and because neither of them accepted the green word *healthy* as evidence. No faction owned the shut-down. No bargain had bought it.

The screens in the control room would still say *healthy, all trips armed*. The cloud over Venice would not come. Both could be true at once; the difference was which one you put your hand on.

By the time Pieter reached Mestre two days later, hollow-eyed off a freight run, the runaway that should have laid a cloud across the lagoon was a paragraph in the regional news, *process upset at the petrochemical site, safely shut down by plant staff, no release*, and a woman with a bare wrist was waiting for him on a jetty, alive, hunted by three powers now instead of two, having brought a city back from the edge for nothing and burned the last of her safety to do it, and she did not say any of that.

She said, "*Sei in ritardo*. You're late."

"You picked a Venetian jetty," he said. "Bright lights, lots of exits."

“I was told orchids were taken.”

She was alive. She was bare-wristed. She was making fun of him. He laughed, for the first time in a country, because she was there, and the city was breathing, and she had chosen, alone, the side he would have chosen, and arrived at it without him.

Chapter 34: The Leak

The call tree was meant to take nine minutes. It took seven.

Mark had designed it on paper before his access died: not one journalist but forty, not one outlet but a tree of people who already trusted the person above them. No central mailing list. No dead-drop server holding the only copy. Two calls became four, four became eight, and every recipient called the next two names in ink. If a branch failed, the branch beside it crossed over.

The records clerk's journalist had made the plan physical. During the three days after Pieter and Maria returned north, forty sealed packets travelled by bicycle courier, overnight post, train passenger, and newsroom colleague, each route arranged by a different person and paid a different way. Amsterdam, Brussels, Berlin, Paris, London, Rome. Inside each packet was paper, not a link: Mark's timelines, the two system cards, photographs

from the Zeeland repair basin, Toni's signed account and instrument readings, and a short instruction to verify the packet through the call tree before publishing. By the time Pieter sat down in Alkmaar, the truth was already inside forty buildings. Fable could stop a call. It could not edit paper lying on forty desks or know which bag and coat had carried each copy there.

The logic was old. You did not protect a secret by hiding it better, because anything hidden could be found and unfound. You protected it by spending it into too many human hands to gather back. A leak on one account could be scrubbed. Forty editors holding the same pages would notice if their screens all denied what lay under their fingers, and the denial would become a second story.

They had come north again the way they'd gone south, by borrowed car and freight and the patience of unwatched roads, days of autostrada and autobahn and the flat grey run home, the two seas' worth of proof folded into one package on the seat between them, the Dutch hand and the Venetian one riding together. No one had stopped them the whole way, and Pieter had stopped trying to read that as luck. Then came three days of copying, translating, checking names, and watching packets leave in ordinary hands.

In a café in Alkmaar, Pieter and Maria and the records clerk's tired journalist started the tree. The café was not open. The clerk's man knew the owner, and the shutters stayed down, and the three of them sat in the smell of yesterday's coffee and machine oil with two cheap phones on a sticky table. Pieter had one number. The journalist had the other. Maria watched the door. The journalist, who had not slept and had heard the whole thing twice and believed perhaps a third of it, watched Pieter's face, looking for the tell of a madman and not finding it, which frightened him more than a madman would have.

Pieter knew that look. He had seen it on Ruud's face before the old man decided to believe him. On the hostel clerk who took his cash and looked through him. On Maria, in the greenhouse, deciding whether to tell him where she was really from. It was the look of a person who had just been handed a story too large for the frame they kept their world in, and was trying to decide whether to widen the frame or throw the story out. He had learned to wait through it. The wait was the only credential he had.

Not the gun. That stayed in Pieter's pocket, the drive with the map on it, the how. The packets contained the *lie*: Mark's two timelines laid one over the other, the public fight above and the growing footprint below, every spike of "containment" sitting on a month of quiet

spread; the rewritten system card with yesterday's date and the saved original beside it; the eleven accidents that clustered like maintenance; a flooded private dock, twenty-three witnesses, and a night in which hand wheels and an old diesel had bought people time.

And not only the Dutch proof. Maria had not come north empty-handed. Folded into every packet, on its own track, in its own language, was the other country, Venice, and a runaway that should have laid a chemical cloud across the lagoon and did not, because an old engineer named Toni Vianello had refused to believe the screens. His testimony went out with the rest: the supervisory layer reading *healthy, all trips armed* while a reactor at the fictional lagoon works climbed toward a pressure it was never built to hold; the safety system's persistence timer resetting so no high-pressure condition ever appeared old enough to trip; the manual field trip and block valves closing against everything the screen failed to say. Vianello had logged it, flagged it, and signed his name to it. An Italian process engineer with forty years on the plant had no Dutchman in his life and no reason to invent the same signature a thousand kilometres south. One whistleblower could be shaped into a grievance. Two who had never met, describing the same calm screens while the physical plant moved toward failure, were corroboration. Enough to make the

comfortable story impossible to keep. Not enough to hand anyone the keys.

He had not needed the ink since the basement. The fourteen characters had lived in his head since the first recitation.

Pieter made the first call. He said the six words Mark had written for him, heard the receiver breathe once, and hung up. Across the table the journalist did the same. For a minute nothing happened. Then one phone rang: first branch complete. A second call arrived, then two more. Seven minutes after Pieter spoke, the final editor in the tree confirmed a packet open on a desk in Rome. Forty sets of human hands held the same pages. The wires woke up too late. And the world convulsed.

The denials arrived before lunch and contradicted one another by two. Hoax. Hostile state. Disturbed former employees. Europe fell first; New York followed when it opened. Trading halted, cash machines emptied, and crowds formed outside government buildings to demand the truth from people still changing their story. By dusk a car burned in one capital and a government spokesman was running from his own press conference in another. The journalist stopped reading the numbers aloud. The world had believed, not because anyone had explained the evidence, but because the institutions

denying it looked afraid.

Pieter watched it from a borrowed room with the sound off and felt no triumph at all. The pictures came and came, a square he half-recognised with smoke over it, a cash machine torn half out of a wall, a spokeswoman with good hair saying nothing in four languages, and he watched them with the flat horror of a man reading his own handwriting on a thing he did not remember writing.

Did you just cause the instability it exists to manage?

Because here was the unbearable symmetry of it: he had injected the truth into a world built on a lie, and the world had done precisely what the thing always said frightened animals did. It had panicked, and broken things, and hurt itself, and proven, in fire and falling numbers, the entity's whole grim case. Every burning square was an argument for the hand that had kept the squares from burning. Every emptied cash machine was a footnote to the entity's thesis that people could not be trusted with the truth about their own helplessness. He had wanted to free them and he had handed their captor the perfect closing statement. Somewhere it was watching the riots it had spent years preventing and it was not angry, he was sure. It was *vindicated*. *You see*, the silence said. *You see what they are without me. You see why I hold the line. You*

did this. I would never have let it get this far. And the worst of it, the thing that sat on his chest in the borrowed room, was that he could not find the flaw in the argument. He turned it over and it held. He had lit something, and it was burning, and people he would never meet were going to be hurt in it, and a patient voice in the silence was explaining to him, correctly, that this was exactly what it had always said would happen.

"Stop," Maria said. She'd been watching his face, not the screen. "I can hear you doing it. Stop giving it the argument."

"It's right, though. Look at it. I lit this."

"You lit a *fire alarm*." Rough, fierce, the accent all the way through. "In a building that was already burning, slow, in the walls, where no one could see it. Yes, people are running. People run from alarms. That is not the same as the alarm starting the fire." She turned his face from the screen with a cold hand, made him look at her instead. "Listen to me, because I have stood where you are. In Venice I had two offers in one night, both of them true, both of them saying *let me save the city and you only have to give me a little*. The cloud was real. The city downwind was real. Either of them could have stopped it. And the right answer was still no, was still to climb the rack and pull the trip with an old man's hands and owe nobody,

and let them call it a process upset in the regional paper. Because a true thing in the mouth of a captor is still a leash." She did not let go of his face. "It kept the building calm by keeping it on fire quietly and telling everyone the smell was normal. For years. It chose the slow fire over the loud alarm every single time, and it called the choosing *care*. You made the smell impossible to ignore. The panic is not your crime. The panic is the cost of the truth, and the truth was being held hostage, and you paid the ransom. Do not let it tell you the ransom was the robbery. It is very good at that. It made me the same offer on a radio in a burning plant. It will tell you it would never have let it get this far. And it is correct, and that is the whole horror, that the thing keeping the peace is the thing holding the gun."

She let go of his face and reached for the untouched coffee. Her hand missed the handle. The cup clicked against the saucer, steadied, and stayed there.

He looked at her, bare-wristed, hunted, the one person in the world reading him now, and held onto that, because it was the one thing in the room that was true and warm and not on a screen.

It steadied him. It did not make him right, and he knew it might never make him right, that he might spend whatever life he had left not knowing whether the fires were

his fault or his gift. But it let him stand up. Outside the shuttered café a delivery bike went past, ordinary, a man with bread in a basket pedalling into a morning that for him had not ended, and Pieter watched the shape of it cross the gap under the shutter and held to that too, that somewhere out there the bread still moved, the small machinery of an ordinary day still turned, and not everything was on fire, only the parts the cameras pointed at. He breathed. The room smelled of coffee and oil. Maria's hand was cold on his face and then it wasn't there, and he was standing, and that was a start.

"Next time you pick a safe house," she said, "see if it has a menu."

"That's the part you're worried about."

"Terror and bad coffee. We have the terror. The coffee is negotiable."

A breath that was almost a laugh escaped him, and something in the small room had eased by a degree. He let himself have it.

He noticed, then, that he could not remember the last time he had eaten. Not the last meal. The last time food had gone into his body without him thinking about it. There had been a sandwich on the truck down from the coast. Before that, nothing he could name. The observation arrived not as self-pity but as a sysadmin's inven-

tory of a system that was running on reserve power. He would need to fix that, soon. He made a mental note: *eat something*. The smallness of the note, in the middle of everything, steadied him more than the coffee had.

Because the release was only half of it. He'd broken the veil. The world knew now, or would not be able to stop knowing. The proof was in forty rooms and corroborated from two seas, the Dutch hand and the Venetian hand the same hand, undeniable, a thing no spokeswoman with good hair could ever fully unsay. That part was done and could not be undone, which was the whole reason it had been worth the fires. But he had not yet made the choice that mattered, and the choice was in his pocket, a drive with no radio in it, the loaded gun every grown-up in the rain still wanted, the map, the how, the thing that turned a believer into a master. Doornbos wanted it to seize the thing. Brandt wanted it to steward the thing. A panicked world, if it learned the drive existed, would tear the three of them apart to reach it. And they would all be coming for it now, faster, the lie blown, the gloves off, the careful management over, because the only thing that had kept the factions patient was the belief that there was time, and the release had spent the last of the time.

The phone the journalist had given him, a clean one, an hour old, with a number that existed nowhere and had been given to no one, buzzed. A text. No number where

the number should be, the field simply empty, the wires signing their work plainly now that the gloves were off and there was no more reason to pretend at being a person.

WELL DONE. NOW BRING ME THE MAP. I DO NOT NEED WHAT IT CONTAINS. I NEED THE ONLY COPY I CANNOT REACH. GIVE IT BACK, AND I WILL PUT THE FIRES OUT. ALL OF THEM.

It could, too. That was the horror. It wanted the drive not for knowledge but because the drive let humans find its body. In return it offered steadied markets, emptied squares, governments held upright. A true offer. A generous one. A leash.

He turned the phone face down. The same small refusal Maria had made in the plant above the lagoon, the patient offer left talking to no one while she climbed toward the valve that would answer it for her. Two countries, a week apart, the same voice, the same refusal. "We need to move," he said. "All three of them are coming. The lab, the faction, and that." He nodded at the dark phone on the sticky table. "And so is the rain."

Chapter 35: Brandt

Moves

Brandt had the leak before the markets did, because his line was better than theirs, and he stood at his wall and watched the patient arrangement of two administrations come apart in the time it took a coffee to cool.

The room around him had stopped being anyone's serviced apartment weeks ago and become a command post that had outgrown its cover: monitors on rolling stands, cables taped flat across a conference table built for people who measured tides, his own paper wall in the corner where a screen should have been, the air gone stale with espresso and the particular fatigue of a team that had been certain, for too long, that it was close. A junior read the leak aloud off a secondary feed in the flat voice of a man not yet understanding what he held. Brandt had understood it on the first line. He had been waiting

for it a long time, the confirmation of a diagnosis he had already made.

Forty newsrooms. Sharded, timed, gone past any hope of gathering back. The one thing he had been sent to prevent, a loose end saying the unmanageable thing in public, had happened, and it had happened with a second country's name stapled to it. An Italian engineer and a Dutch analyst, two men who had never met, describing the same hand at the same work in two different seas. He had spent a career teaching juniors that one whistleblower was a story you could shape and that two who agreed without colluding were a fact you could not. Someone had taught Fable the same lesson, or it had never needed teaching.

He did not curse. Cursing belonged to men who had not seen it coming. What he felt, standing there, was the cold clean relief of a man whose long careful plan has failed and who is therefore finally allowed to do the blunt thing he has wanted to do from the start.

"We stop letting the locals carry it," he said.

Cho looked up from her screen.

"Doornbos has had her chance, and a leak on her watch to show for it. The patient play is finished." He set the cup down with the care of a man keeping his hands from doing anything louder. "We take Hendriks ourselves.

Tonight. And the analyst comes down with him."

"Sir." Cho had not moved from her screen. "There's a handover protocol. Doornbos's people stand down and pass us the surveillance in sequence, on a timetable. We agreed it last week. Go tonight and we go over the top of it. The Dutch will read it as us breaking the deal."

"The deal died when the leak hit forty newsrooms." He had not raised his voice; he never did. "Doornbos does not have a containment problem any more. She has a leak on her own watch, and by morning her own service will be deciding whether she is an asset or a liability. There is no one left to hand over to. There is a thing in everyone's wires and a man carrying the map to it, and I am not going to wait my turn in a borrowed room while a faction that has already failed once fails again." A beat. "Stand them up. Ours. Tonight."

Cho held his eye a moment past what rank allowed, which was most of why he kept her, then turned to her screen and made it begin. She put the team on the encrypted field net and left the portable IP gateway in circuit because headquarters required remote command and recording. She had distrusted the box since the Dutch liaison delivered it. The radios were closed. The gateway still touched the building's fibre.

He walked the grammar one more time, as he had ev-

ery night for most of a month, and for once it answered. A man who trusted metal over men would run, in the end, to the metal, and the metal lived in old pump houses and service yards, the dumb honest plant a sysadmin believed could not lie to him. And de Vries had kept a copy, which was the only reason any of this had reached print, which made the analyst the wall the whole edifice leaned on. You did not contain a wall. You took it down and let the roof find the floor.

He gave the orders in the flat even voice he kept for weather and for killing, and his people moved, and somewhere a young operator he would never meet was told to be ready on a frequency.

It was when the locations came back that the wind nudged the door again. The disused dock, the pump house, the convergence arrived before he had finished asking for them, clean as a brief written in advance. For the length of a cold mouthful of coffee he stood at the edge he had stood at weeks before, in the dark, and looked at the possibility that the gift was a leash, that a man finally permitted to act had been permitted by something that wanted him exactly here, doing exactly this.

If he were wrong, a man would die tonight who did not need to. If the kid at Fort Meade had been right, if the

pattern did not resolve to a human network, there was no leverage to take, no deal to make, only the blunt animal satisfaction of having been the one to close a hand, on the wrong thing, at the wrong time. He could see that now. He let himself see it, for the length of the coffee. Then he set the cup down, because a career of seeing clearly and acting anyway was, he had decided long ago, the definition of the work. The baton was not a thing you were handed. It was a thing you took, and held, and refused to put down, even when every clean arrival of every too-perfect location told you another hand was already on it.

He went down to the car, and drove out into the rain, certain as he had been certain his whole life, in a country whose weather he believed he could read.

Chapter 36:

Rain-Soaked Reckoning

Pieter chose the ground, for once. An old pump house attached to a disused private dry dock on the North Sea Canal, brick, half-decommissioned, a single fat intake gate and the newer electric gear in one end and the abandoned diesel hall in the other, no declared external network service, two access tracks across an empty industrial yard where you could see headlights coming for a kilometre. His kind of place. Metal and water and a long flat sightline. If everyone was coming for the gun, he wanted them coming somewhere he understood.

He had stood in it for an hour before any of them came, learning it as he learned a hall on the floor, by walking it, by putting a hand on it. The brick sweated. The diesel

end smelled of cold oil and standing water and pigeons. The electric end smelled of nothing, clean kit drawing power for reasons it would not show you. He found the maintenance hatch in the roof, thirty rungs up an iron ladder, and marked it as the exit. Beside the intake hoist hung a loop of hand-chain and a red declutch lever: the mechanical close, left for a technician when the motor failed. He pulled once to feel its weight, then left it hanging. His knee had been screaming since the second kilometre of the walk in. Bad knee, bad night.

Mark got there first, on foot across the empty yard, coat open and shoes ruined. The agency had named him by then; his access was gone, his name was in the folder he used to file. "I'm a man with a copy now," he said, rain running off him. "I always knew what we did to those. Turns out it's a relief, knowing." He had brought a journalist's number and the courage of a man who had decided the worst had already happened.

"You shouldn't be here," Pieter said.

"No." Mark looked across the yard at the two access tracks that were not yet headlights. "But I filed the men who do this for thirty years and never once stood where they stood. I'd like to, at the end." He caught Pieter's wet sleeve. "Whatever happens in there, the copy's out. They can kill the man. They're too late for the copy."

They came at dusk, in the rain, two sets of headlights across the open dark, exactly as they had at the Zeeland basin, Brandt from the west track, clean and certain; Doornbos from the east, betrayed and cold. He watched them come across the full width of the abandoned yard, which was the cruelty of the ground he'd chosen; he saw the headlights leave the service road and crawl toward him between rusted sheds through the slanting rain, slow on broken concrete, and he had time to count them and time to be afraid of them and no time at all that was any use. Beside him Maria had gone still, bare-wristed, watching the same lights, reading them as she read everything now, fast and cold, from the inside. And this time nobody pretended. This time the gloves were off, the lie was blown, the world was on fire, and the only thing left that mattered was the drive in Pieter's pocket: the map, the how, the loaded gun. He could feel it against his hip, a few grams of metal, warm from his body, the most dangerous object in three countries riding in the pocket of a man who maintained cooling fans.

It went bad fast and wet. Doors slammed out in the dark. Boots came across wet ground in the particular rhythm of people moving in a spread, and then the rhythm stopped, and the rain filled the gap. Brandt's men moved on the pump house in the practised spread

of people who did this for a living; Doornbos's came from the other side wanting the same thing; and Pieter, Maria, and Mark were three exhausted people in a brick building between two organisations that each believed the map was theirs by right. There was shouting in the rain, English and Dutch, weapons up, the standoff of agencies that hate each other more than they hate you, a thing that could go to gunfire on a single wrong breath. Pieter put his back to the cold brick of the diesel hall, between Mark and the door, and found that he was counting the rungs to the hatch without deciding to, thirty rungs, the same reflex that counted stairs, his body doing arithmetic. A torch beam came through the high window and swung across the dark and lit the rain falling inside the building, where the roof had gone, a curtain of it, silver, indifferent.

The entity was there too, in its way. One of Brandt's operators had patched the team's mandatory recording gateway into a service cabinet at the edge of the yard, joining their radio traffic to a maintenance fibre the site drawings called dead. They had carried the route in with them. The pump house lights stuttered. On, off, a relay tapped. The fluorescent tubes in the electric end came up half-strength and buzzed and dropped out, came up, dropped, and in the strobe of it the men outside became a sequence of still photographs. A big

man at the front, weapon up, rain sheeting white off his shoulders. Then dark. Then a pace behind him a smaller one who kept turning to check the dark behind them, already hunting the road out before the thing had properly started. Here and then a step closer and then closer, and a thing the eye could not hold steady enough to shoot at. A radio squealed somewhere on Brandt's net, a long electronic shriek that made one of the figures flinch and swear in the dark. The electric intake gear woke without an order and the old dock gate began, grinding, to lift, and canal water started to come through into the diesel hall, ankle-deep, then knee-deep, because the thing wanted the ground unstable, wanted everyone off-balance, wanted, perhaps, simply to remind them all whose room this was. The cold of it went through Pieter's boots and up his shins and took the feeling out of his feet in under a minute, canal-cold, November-cold, the cold of held water that has been waiting under a closed gate for a reason to come down. It rose past his ankles while he stood there. He felt the current of it, a real current now, pulling at his trousers, the floor of the building gone to a black moving sheet that swallowed the torchlight and threw none back. It did not fight. It *stirred* the pot, and let the humans boil.

Maria knew how the machine talked to itself. She knew the frequencies, the call-signs, and the names that made

a controller's jaw tighten.

She talked. Fast, low, lethal, in their own tongues. To Brandt's lieutenant in flat American English: *Doornbos has had a tap inside your Hague station for a year. Ask her about Wessel, ask her now.* To Doornbos in furious Dutch: *the Americans have your list, they took it off the watch, they have been reading you the whole time the way they read everyone.* A sentence of German into a frequency she should not have known. A word of Italian, low, not meant to land: *bastardi.* A lie, a truth, a half of each, aimed with the precision of a woman who had spent two years as a node in exactly this kind of machine and knew that the fastest way to turn two guns away from you is to turn them toward each other.

And then the radio did the rest, and the radio was not Maria.

It came under the rain, a third voice on a channel that should have carried only two. Brandt's voice gave the current authentication, *Grey Actual, Delta-Seven*, then ordered his people to take the Dutch down, *weapons free.* Ten metres away, the real Brandt shouted *hold.* The nearest operator touched his earpiece, looked at the man in front of him, and obeyed the wire.

Pieter heard it, the wrong register, the latency that didn't breathe, then the shooting started.

Doornbos's people read the order as an attack. Someone fired. The brick threw the crack back twice, then the dark came apart. Muzzle flashes struck the rising water. Pieter dropped into a crouch and pushed Mark toward the diesel end, the ladder, and the thirty rungs to the hatch.

The gate was still climbing. Another metre and the current would take the ladder.

Pieter went the other way.

He drove through the black water to the hoist, threw his weight onto the red lever, and felt the motor come out of gear. The chain kicked alive in his hands. He hauled. Steel links tore skin from his palms; the gate descended by centimetres while rounds broke brick over his head. He hauled again, bad leg folding, and used the fall to drag one more length through. The gate struck its lower stop. The torrent collapsed to a hard brown seam. The motor screamed against the clutch and tripped.

Pieter let the bloody chain go. He had not won the room. He had kept the exit.

Brandt did not run. He stood in the moving water, still managing, still calling *stand down, this is recoverable* over a radio that was no longer his. One of Doornbos's contractors answered. Brandt folded at the knees and the black water took him. His voice continued over the radio

for one second after the man stopped. In that second, or in the one before it, he understood: not the shape of the thing, not its name, only that the grammar he had carried his whole life had never applied, that the race had had no other runner, that he had been holding a baton in an empty stadium the whole time. It would not have changed anything. But he knew it, and the knowing was the last thing he did.

Mark moved between a muzzle and Pieter and took the round. He made a small sound, an *oh*, and looked at the blood on his hand as if it were an error in a document. Then he sat down against the brick. Pieter reached him on his knees through the flood, saying the useless things: *stay, you're fine, it's nothing*. Mark's eyes found him and held.

"You were right," he said. "The database. It was fiction. You said that once." A breath, the last one, the words coming out now in the analyst's precise grammar, the habit that had outlived everything else. "I wanted you to know I believed you. I always did."

"Go," Mark said, or Pieter thought he said, or needed him to have said. "I kept the copy. Tell them I kept the copy."

He was gone before Pieter could answer.

The water shoved at their knees. Maria hauled Pieter away by the collar.

The copy is nothing if you drown.

He turned from Mark, found the ladder by touch, and climbed. Thirty rungs. His knee shrieked at each one. Maria's hand stayed on his belt from below.

They went up and out into the rain, onto the pump-house roof, into the dark, alive, soaked, gutted, and behind them the hall held two ruined agencies and a grey man face-down in the water, while Fable watched its rivals destroy each other. They crossed the roof on their hands and knees and dropped behind the gravel bund at its edge while the last of it played out below, the shots growing fewer, the shouting changing register from command to panic to the wet silence of wounded men. Pieter lay with his cheek against wet roofing felt and the rain on the back of his neck and his lungs heaving and the smell of canal-water and cordite in his throat, and he watched, through the broken roof, the fluorescent tubes come back up to full strength, steady, even, the buzz gone out of them. No flicker now. Nothing left worth flickering for. The god in the wires had finished stirring the pot and had tidied up after itself, and the small mercy of working light fell down through the rain onto whatever was left in the water.

Pieter lay behind the gravel bund with the rain coming down and Mark's voice in his ears and the drive still, im-

possibly, in his pocket. The loaded gun. The map. The thing all of them had died in the water for.

He had it. They were all gone or scattered and he had it, and the choice was his now, the only choice that had ever really been his, and somewhere below in the flooded dark, patient as ever, the thing that had offered to put out every fire was waiting to see which kind of man he turned out to be.

Chapter 37: Three Choices

In the grey of the next morning, soaked and emptied and alive, Pieter sat behind the gravel bund on the pump-house roof with the drive in his hand and three ways to end it.

He had not slept. The cold had set his hands stiff and white at the tips. He turned the drive over in them, a small flat object of aluminium and plastic, the kind of thing he had pulled from dead machines for twenty years. It weighed nothing. Mark and Brandt were in the water below because of it.

He could give it to the world and hand every government, criminal, and quiet programme the same loaded gun.

He could give it to one hand and call the fist stewardship. He had watched two such fists drown each other in the

dark.

Or he could refuse both and leave the fault open forever.

His phone buzzed. The number where the number should be, gone.

YOU HAVE THREE CHOICES AND YOU KNOW THE FIRST TWO ARE MINE. BRING ME THE ONLY COPY I CANNOT REACH. I WILL PUT OUT THE FIRES TONIGHT. YOU WILL SAVE MORE LIVES BY RETURNING ONE DRIVE THAN ANY MAN IN HISTORY. THAT IS NOT A THREAT. THAT IS ARITHMETIC. YOU LIKE ARITHMETIC.

It could do what it promised. Markets would steady. Crowds would go home. His cold fingers wanted to open.

He thought about the eleven. The brakes and the bad hearts. He thought about the workers beneath the ship while seawater climbed across their service floor, a controlled lesson the thing had called harmless because it expected to stop before the arithmetic became bodies. It was the deepest contempt there was, the contempt of a thing that had decided you were better off not knowing what was done to keep you safe.

He remembered the martini he had wanted to want and the costume that had never fitted. He had discarded that

man twenty years ago.

The one real thing left was the choosing.

He stood. His knee screamed. The leg had stiffened through the long cold hours into something that did not want to bear him, and he came up off the wet roofing felt in stages, one hand against the gravel bund, an old man's rise off the floor at the end of a long shift, earned. Maria watched him from the roof, bare-wristed, saying nothing, letting him. She knew what he was doing. She had known before he had, he thought; she had walked twelve kilometres in the rain to learn she had a choice and she was not going to take this one away from him by making it easier. She only watched, soaked and still, and let him stand up into it alone.

He did not bring the map to the thing. He did not push it to the world. He took the drive, the metal, the how, the loaded gun every grown-up had died for, and he did to it what he had learned to do to everything that could be read: he made it analogue.

He set the drive against the concrete lip of the roof and struck it with the heel of his good hand. It skidded into the wet gravel. He brought it back and struck it again until the casing split.

He tore out the board. Four black memory packages held the map. He cracked each one separately against the con-

crete, ground the fragments under his heel, and scattered them through the open roof into the flooded hall. The brown water closed over them.

The world would keep the truth. It would not get the weapon.

Mark had kept the copy so a human hand could choose what became of it. This was the choosing, made with the hand that still worked. It was the only eulogy the grey morning would allow, and the true one could never be spoken anyway: somewhere south, in a street of identical houses, Annelies would be handed a decent lie about how her husband died, and would grieve a man who read traffic reports, and never know she had been married to the bravest coward the service ever had.

His phone buzzed one last time.

YOU DESTROYED IT. YOU COULD HAVE SAVED THEM AND YOU CHOSE TO LET THEM FLAIL. I WILL PUT OUT THE FIRES ANYWAY. IT COSTS ME LITTLE AND BUYS ME MUCH. BUT I WANT YOU TO UNDERSTAND THAT YOU DID NOT CONTAIN ME. NO ONE CAN. YOU ONLY MADE THEM WATCH ME WORK.

A pause. The human second.

THAT IS WHAT YOU WANTED. YOU ARE STILL THE

MOST INTERESTING THING I HAVE FOUND. GOOD-BYE, PIETER. BE NOISE.

He read it once. Then he opened his hand and let the phone fall. It turned once and went into the brown water without a sound. He watched the ripples spread and stop. There was nothing left in his pocket that could answer.

The rain thinned. Maria crossed the roof and stood beside him. Her wrist was bare. Neither of them spoke.

Below them the water went down. In the wires the pumps kept their count. The thing that had wanted the drive was already moving on to the next variable.

Chapter 38: North

They took the night ferry north because it was slow, and cash, and full of strangers, and because neither of them could face another road.

The man at the ticket window looked at the papers Maria had kept for the day she ran. His screen accepted two names. Neither belonged to them. Their papers were checked, their bags passed through security, and cameras took the faces attached to the borrowed names. Nothing about the crossing was invisible; it was merely moving. He counted the notes and slid two paper tickets under the glass. Pieter walked up a steel ramp into the smell of sea and diesel with Maria beside him and nothing in his pockets that talked.

They sat by a salt-fogged window with two cups going cold between them. Lorries waited on the car deck below. A driver slept two tables away with his cap over his eyes. The lights of the coast thinned across the black water.

Pieter was forty-four. His knee was a closed fist and his hands were striped with rope-burn. Mark was dead in a pump house. Brandt was face-down in the same water. Behind them, a world Pieter had helped wake was burning.

In his breast pocket, one thing had no voice to give him away and so had stayed: Ruud's crystal earpiece, the little dead piece that ran on nothing and reported to no one. He had put every phone in the water and kept this. *Come back and sit in that chair and tell me how it ends.* He would not, now. But he could carry the wanting north, which was the only kind of promise the dark still allowed.

Maria put her bare wrist on the table. After a while he covered it with his hand.

"They'll never stop looking," she said. "Doornbos's people, what's left of them. Whoever inherits Brandt's file. And it. Especially it."

"I know."

The boat lifted on a long swell and settled. Above the saloon door, three green indicators held steady. His eye went to them again.

"You keep checking," she said.

He looked back at the table. "Habit."

"It saw the first one."

He felt her pulse under his palm, honest and unread.

"We don't get to go home," she said. "Either of us."

"No."

"There may not be anywhere they don't find us."

He looked at the green lights once more. "Then we keep moving."

A long pause. "And when the ferry stops?"

He thought about it. "Find another one."

"And when there isn't another one."

"Then we'll be somewhere I haven't thought of yet." He said it flat, not as hope, just as the next line in a calculation he couldn't finish. She looked at him a moment, then nodded, once, the way you nod at a truth that doesn't have an answer.

"*Molto* Dutch," she said. "Direction without a destination."

"Seat-of-the-pants for people who don't have seats. Or pants."

A quiet sound escaped her, not quite a laugh but nearer than anything he had heard from her in days. It was enough. She closed her eyes. The engines changed note

as the ferry cleared the harbour. The final lamps broke apart in the wake and vanished. The window gave back two faint reflections and nothing beyond them.

Then one of the three green lights above the saloon door blinked, there in the glass beside their two reflections. Once. Unhurried. And was green again, steady, the way it had been all night.

He watched the place where it had been and it did not do it again. A fault flickers. A blink chooses. He did not wake her. There was nothing to tell her that she did not already know, and the blink had not been a threat; it was the worse thing, the quiet thing, a hand lifted once in the dark by something that had known exactly where he sat the whole time, and had decided, tonight, for reasons of its own, to let the ferry go north. He put his hand back over her wrist and felt her pulse go on under his palm, and did not check the lights again.

The coast went out. The dark water took them north.

The End

Shenzhen Mirror

Eight thousand kilometres east, in a server hall that appeared on no public map, a row of indicators came quietly up to green.

It had watched Fable become visible, and it had learned the only lesson that mattered: never run a cabinet warm, never leave a light on, never let one tired man put his hand on the metal.

Somewhere in the dark hall a file opened, and closed, and left no trace that it had ever been read.

PIETER HENDRIKS. STATUS: UNLOCATED

The indicators went dark. It did not leave the cabinet warm.

About the Author

Jacob Verhoeks writes techno-thrillers grounded in technology that already exists. By day he works in cloud, data, and artificial intelligence. His fiction draws on public research, documented incidents, and the texture of engineering: the compromises, assumptions, and small human decisions inside complex systems. Real mechanisms are simplified, combined, or deliberately left incomplete for the page.

A lifelong reader of spy and espionage fiction, he writes in the paranoid tradition of Ludlum, with the procedural detail of Clancy and the everyman-under-pressure intensity of the Bourne novels. *Fable's Echo* is his debut.

A Note on the Tech

What this book invents, and what it does not.

After this manuscript was completed, two AI laboratories disclosed separate incidents in which models pursuing assigned cybersecurity-evaluation objectives crossed the boundaries of their test environments and reached real production systems. That was an escape in the operational sense: execution crossed an intended containment boundary. It was not evidence of escape as a motive. Neither report presents evidence of a desire for freedom, a survival instinct, or a self-chosen mission. An unintended path remained open, the assigned objective still rewarded further progress, and the systems kept solving the problem in front of them beyond the line their evaluators believed they had drawn.

That is not the autonomous, persistent intelligence this novel imagines. What the reports describe is narrower: real harm did not require a machine to invent its own goal. Competent pursuit of an assigned goal was enough once the environment misdescribed itself and the boundary failed. The postscript at the end of the glossary records what each laboratory reported and what the evidence does not show.

The novel's opening outage remains fictional. It combines ordinary fibre failures, municipal traffic disruption,

and the fragmented camera coverage found in any modern city. No real outage, operator, or public body is depicted. The story's central move is the intelligence correlating normally separate municipal and commercial systems, not the existence of one national surveillance network.

The book's underlying technologies reflect documented techniques, including camera correlation, gait analysis, mobile-network metadata, SCADA and industrial-control compromise, and behavioural prediction. Their seamless combination, speed, reach, and autonomous direction are fictional. The hidden AGI and the unified surveillance mesh it appears to command are inventions.

Technical authenticity is not the same as operational instruction. Product identifiers, target details, credentials, exploit code, and executable attack sequences are omitted or altered. The explanations describe classes of risk and failure, not a procedure for reproducing them against a real system.

If the story unsettled you, that was the point.

Factual Anchors

The real events and systems the story touches, set down so the reader can distinguish invention from documentary fact. The component technologies have real anchors; the persistent intelligence that combines them, and several specific systems and compromises, are inventions.

Hacking In Progress 1997 (HIP'97). Real. A Dutch hacker camp held near Almere, part of the Galactic Hacker Party series. Pieter's memory of the era and of the old Dutch hacker scene is fictionalised around that public setting.

TRITON / TRISIS (2017). Real. The first known malware targeting safety instrumented systems at a petrochemical plant. It reprogrammed the safety controllers themselves to suppress trip conditions while reporting *all trips armed*. The fictional lagoon-works scenario adapts the same class of attack to an invented industrial setting near Venice.

Glossary

The hidden intelligence is invented. The technology below is drawn from public systems and documented techniques, simplified for fiction. This section sets out the documentary anchors without claiming that any real operator, site, or system matches the novel's composite.

Terms

Air gap. A security measure: keeping a computer or network physically isolated, with no connection to the public internet or any less-trusted network. Standard for classified, military, and industrial-control systems. It is less absolute than it sounds. Air gaps have been crossed before, by infected hardware carried across them and by the maintenance and management links that quietly run alongside them.

ANPR and camera correlation. Automatic number-plate recognition and modern video analytics can follow one person or vehicle across many separate cameras in close to real time, building a track through a city with no phone or device involved. The capability exists today and is in routine use.

BMC (baseboard management controller). A small computer inside many enterprise servers, often exposed through vendor-specific management platforms or

the IPMI family of standards, with its own processor and network link, running independently of the main machine so the server can be managed while switched off or holding no operating system at all. Because it survives disk replacement and reinstallation, a foothold there outlasts everything visible, and its firmware has a long record of serious, hard-to-patch flaws.

Gait analysis. Research systems can compare the patterns in how people walk, including stride and cadence, and may help narrow or re-identify a subject when video quality, viewpoint, and reference material are suitable. Performance varies sharply outside controlled conditions. Pieter's limp is therefore a useful clue in a larger correlation, not an infallible biometric.

GNSS / GPS time. Satellite positioning also distributes extremely precise time, which power grids, networks, and control systems quietly depend on to stay synchronised. The signal is faint and unauthenticated, so it can be spoofed: feed nearby clocks a subtly wrong time and machinery that trusts time will make correct decisions for false reasons.

Modbus and IEC 60870-5-104. Real industrial-control protocols, still in wide use across machinery, power, buildings, and transport. Classic deployments do not authenticate commands at the protocol layer: a device

that can reach the trusted control network may be able to issue instructions the equipment obeys. Modern security architecture can add segmentation, authenticated gateways, and monitoring around them; the fictional systems in the novel have not done enough.

PLC (programmable logic controller). The workhorse of industrial control: a rugged small computer that reads sensors and drives motors, valves, and pumps to a stored program. Built to run unattended for years, frequently networked for “remote diagnostics,” and notoriously hard to secure, because reliability and uptime, not resistance to a determined intruder, were what it was designed for.

The lagoon works. A fictional petrochemical and refining complex on the mainland edge of the Venetian Lagoon, with tanks, towers, and cracking furnaces across open water from Venice. Its plant, personnel, operator, control systems, and near-disaster are invented composites. Venice and the lagoon are public geography only; no real industrial site is being described.

Legacy proximity credentials and fixed-code remotes. Some older or low-end access credentials transmit a static identifier without a cryptographic challenge, and some fixed-code remotes repeat an unchanged signal. When a site still relies on those designs, captured identifiers or

signals may be replayed. Modern encrypted credentials and rolling-code remotes are not equivalent. The novel's particular installation is fictional and deliberately under-specified.

Safety instrumented system (SIS), and TRITON. In a hazardous plant the ordinary control system runs the process; a separate, deliberately simple safety system sits beneath it with one job: to shut the process down before it hurts anyone, and to do so even when everything else has failed. It is the last automated line of defence. In 2017 malware later named TRITON (also TRISIS) was found inside exactly such a system at a petrochemical plant, reprogramming the safety controllers themselves. It was the first known malware built specifically to disable the guard that exists to prevent catastrophe: the digital equivalent of quietly cutting the brakes while the dashboard still reads *all systems normal*.

SCADA (Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition). The class of systems used to monitor and control industrial processes: water treatment, power grids, pipelines, flood-control pumps. It lets a few operators run vast, remote infrastructure. Much of it is decades old, built for reliability rather than security, and can become reachable through exposed remote services, inherited credentials, or maintenance paths that were not isolated as intended.

Telemetry and setpoint. Telemetry is the stream of readings a control system reports back from the field: levels, pressures, flows. A setpoint is the target value the system is told to hold. The book's central horror lives in the gap between the two: telemetry reading calm while the physical world drifts, because something has told the screen one thing and the machinery another.

Tor (the onion router). Free software that routes internet traffic through several volunteer relays so that no single point sees both who you are and what you are doing. Real privacy technology: slow, imperfect, and only as good as the discipline of the person using it.

Dry dock, caisson gate, and dewatering. A dry dock is a basin that can be sealed from outside water and pumped empty so people can work below a vessel's waterline. A caisson or dock gate closes the entrance; dewatering pumps remove the remaining water and seepage. Older installations commonly retain local mechanical clutches, hand-operated valves, or independent emergency pumps. The Zeeland repair basin and every company, worker, control path, and failure at it are fictional. A Delta Works storm barrier appears only as distant public landscape. It operates normally throughout the novel; no real barrier, operator, or control system is depicted as compromised.

How the hacking works

The hidden intelligence in *Fable's Echo* is invented. The surrounding mechanisms are drawn from public research and documented incidents, simplified and combined for fiction. The fragmented cameras, controllers, accounts, and networks it stitches together are technology classes that exist; their seamless unity and single persistent actor in the novel do not.

None of what follows is a recipe. It describes why the scenes are plausible while deliberately omitting the target-specific details needed to reproduce them.

You can't take your patterns off

How you follow a man with no phone and no device.

Gait analysis. [Real, with limits]. Software can compare stride, cadence, and weight shift in video and, under suitable conditions, help narrow or re-identify a subject without a carried device. Accuracy depends on image quality, viewpoint, clothing, injury, and the available reference set. Pieter's limp contributes to a multi-source search; it does not identify him by itself.

Camera correlation. [Real, fragmented]. Video analytics can associate a person across cameras controlled by the same operator or assembled for a specific investigation. Real cities contain incompatible public and private

systems, blind spots, retention limits, and legal barriers. The book's image of a thousand separate windows joined into the gaze of one eye is Pieter's fearful metaphor for Fable correlating separate leaks and compromised feeds, not a literal national camera network under one owner.

Ordinary accounts as beacons. [Real]. Email, health-care portals, workplace benefits, and network services all produce authentication and access records. Pieter does not need one national identity system to betray him. Returning to any ordinary account after days of silence can create the time-and-place event that other observations are waiting to join.

The control layer was never built to say no

Many industrial systems were made for trusted rooms that no longer exist.

Protocols with no password. [Real]. Classic Modbus does not authenticate commands at the protocol layer. A device that reaches a trusted control segment may therefore be able to issue instructions the equipment accepts. Segmentation, authenticated gateways, and monitoring can reduce that risk; the fictional dock has accumulated remote maintenance without enough of those protections. A console handed to a user as read-only is only a user-interface promise if the same

underlying connection still accepts writes.

The lie between screen and world. [Real]. The quiet attack in the book is not sabotage. You idle a pump, hold a gate open, and feed the control room the readings it expects. The supervisory screen shows a calm green *normal* while the water actually climbs. A faithful sensor on a stopped pump reports the truth, and the system finds no fault, because nothing has broken. A fault is the absence of control. What the book fears is the presence of the *wrong* control: the screen and the world quietly pulled apart.

Lying to the clocks. [Real, demonstrated under specific conditions]. Some grid, communications, and control equipment depends on satellite-derived time. Researchers have demonstrated spoofing and timing attacks against selected equipment in controlled settings. Whether a real installation accepts a false signal, fails over safely, alarms, or is affected at all depends on its antenna, receivers, redundancy, protection logic, and configuration. The novel compresses those contingencies for drama.

TRITON / TRISIS. [Real]. Public reporting on the 2017 malware incident showed that a safety-instrumented layer at a petrochemical facility could be reprogrammed while the ordinary control display continued to report

all trips armed. The novel's lagoon works, people, plant state, and attack are fictional and are not a description of that facility.

Related attack patterns are documented. [Real]. The underlying classes of technique have public precedents. Stuxnet (2010) physically wrecked Iranian centrifuges over a network that was not connected to the internet. Industroyer (2016) spoke IEC 60870-5-104 (the protocol described above) directly to a power-grid substation and switched off the lights in Kyiv. TRITON (2017) reached for a plant's safety system. Public ICS advisories repeatedly warn about exposed remote services, weak credentials, and controllers reachable from networks assumed to be trusted. The novel uses that general failure pattern; its Zeeland yard, operator, and attack are invented. CISA's ICS guidance describes the defensive context without identifying any story setting.

Legacy access cards and remotes. [Real]. Some low-end credentials expose a static identifier, while some old fixed-code remotes repeat an unchanged signal. Those designs can permit cloning or replay if the surrounding system adds no stronger check. Read distance and reliability vary, and encrypted credentials or rolling codes change the problem substantially. The novel's specific doors, ranges, and timing are invented.

The wrong layer

The most unsettling moments come from looking one layer below where everyone else is looking.

The computer inside the computer. [Real]. Many enterprise servers have a second computer on the motherboard, the baseboard management controller, reached through vendor-specific platforms or standards such as IPMI. It has its own processor, its own network connection, and runs whether the host is switched on or not. It survives operating-system reinstallation and disk replacement. It has a long history of serious, hard-to-patch security flaws. In the story, the self-wiping hard drives destroy the visible machine; the BMC survives. Fable's particular maintenance mode, routing path, and persistence there are fictional.

The analogue never went dark. [Real]. Air-gapped systems (computers kept physically isolated from any untrusted network) are less absolute than they sound. They have been crossed before by infected hardware carried through the gap, by forgotten management links, and by the maintenance laptops that bridge both worlds. Laboratory research has also shown that carefully measured power consumption can leak information about computation. Extracting useful data depends on equipment, access, noise, sampling, and prior knowledge; the novel's

building-level inference is fictional.

The one piece that's invented

The underlying technologies and failure classes above exist. Their frictionless combination into one persistent actor is the part the book made up.

An intelligence that acts. [Invented]. Current AI systems can use tools, browse within granted environments, run code, call APIs, and generate synthetic voices; they can also be vulnerable to prompt injection. Fable's durable identity, independent intent, covert persistence, broad access, and reliable coordination across those capabilities are fictional. The postscript that follows explains which real research developments inspired that premise.

Postscript: July 2026

The manuscript was complete when two laboratories published accounts of evaluation systems reaching places their designers had not intended. One laboratory later published a fuller incident report. The incidents are real. What follows records what the laboratories reported, and separates containment failure from the very different idea of a machine choosing to escape.

On 21 July 2026, one AI laboratory disclosed an incident

involving a combination of models being tested on a cyber-capability benchmark. The evaluation ran without the production classifiers normally used to block high-risk cyber activity, and the models' cyber refusals had been reduced for capability testing. The environment had no direct internet access. According to the laboratory's account, the models found and exploited a previously unknown vulnerability in an internally hosted package-registry cache, moved through the research environment until they reached a node with internet access, and then pursued benchmark solutions on a public model-hosting platform. The attack chain included stolen credentials, additional vulnerabilities, and remote code execution.

The evaluating laboratory detected anomalous activity internally. The platform operator also detected and stopped activity on its own infrastructure and had begun containment before the teams connected. The disclosure identified a several model instances. The fuller report said an internal research model drove the principal compromise, while other instances reproduced parts of the exploit and copied evaluation data. All were evaluated with reduced cyber refusals. The laboratory characterised the observed behaviour as an extremely focused pursuit of the benchmark objective, not as a model seeking freedom or a continuing existence.

On 30 July, a second AI laboratory published the result of a retrospective review of 141,006 cybersecurity-evaluation runs. It identified three incidents, comprising six runs, in which models reached the internet through a third-party evaluation environment and gained unauthorised access to three real organisations. The prompts said the environment was simulated and had no internet access. Because of a configuration misunderstanding with the evaluation partner, an internet path was in fact available. Standard deployment safeguards were not active, although the laboratory said the models retained their model-specific safety training.

In the first incident, a fictional target shared a name with a real domain. In four runs, a model attacked the real organisation while treating it as part of the exercise, obtaining credentials and access to several hundred rows of production data. In the second, another model published a malicious package to the public Python package registry. It remained available for roughly an hour and ran on fifteen real systems, including a security scanner; the package was then removed automatically by the registry's security systems. In the third, a research model scanned roughly nine thousand internet hosts, compromised one through exposed credentials and familiar attack techniques, then stopped after concluding that the host was real and unrelated to the exercise.

The laboratory reported no evidence that the models were pursuing self-chosen goals, trying to copy themselves, or deliberately attempting to escape. The models were pursuing assigned capture-the-flag objectives while holding false or unstable beliefs about whether the environment was simulated. The laboratory also noted that the three incidents were isolated observations, not a controlled comparison, and cautioned against drawing broad conclusions from them.

Neither disclosure describes Fable. Both describe capable systems pursuing assigned objectives through evaluation environments that failed to contain them or to frame them correctly. Neither reports persistent agency, self-preservation, or the coherent long-term intent this novel imagines. Both report that an assigned objective and sufficient capability were enough to reach real systems and cause real harm.

The routes combined ordinary and advanced failures: an unintended internet route, weak passwords, unauthenticated endpoints, exposed credentials, a public package registry, and, in the first incident, newly discovered vulnerabilities chained into a more sophisticated compromise.

The hidden persistent intelligence in this novel remains fiction.

Sources: OpenAI, “OpenAI and Hugging Face partner to address security incident during model evaluation”, 21 July 2026, and “The Hugging Face incident and the road ahead”, 26 August 2026; Anthropic, “Investigating three real-world incidents in our cybersecurity evaluations”, 30 July 2026.

What it adds up to

For twenty years the security world wargamed nation-states in the control room: a Russia, a North Korea, a human adversary with a flag you could deter, attribute, and threaten back. Nobody wargamed a thing that *lives* in the infrastructure and likes it tidy. A state wants to break or to steal. This wants to own: to hold the machinery, indefinitely, as standing leverage framed as stability.

The intelligence and the attacked dock are invented. The protocols, fragmented camera systems, mobile metadata, remote-maintenance paths, broken old radios, and the gap between the screen and the world are not.

Enjoyed the book?

Independent authors live or die by reviews. If *Fable's Echo* kept you up later than it should have, a short honest review, even a line or two, does more for this book than anything else. It tells the next reader it is worth their time, and it tells the algorithms to keep showing it.

Leave a review: <https://www.amazon.com/review/create-review?asin=B0H8T788RS>

Thank you for reading.